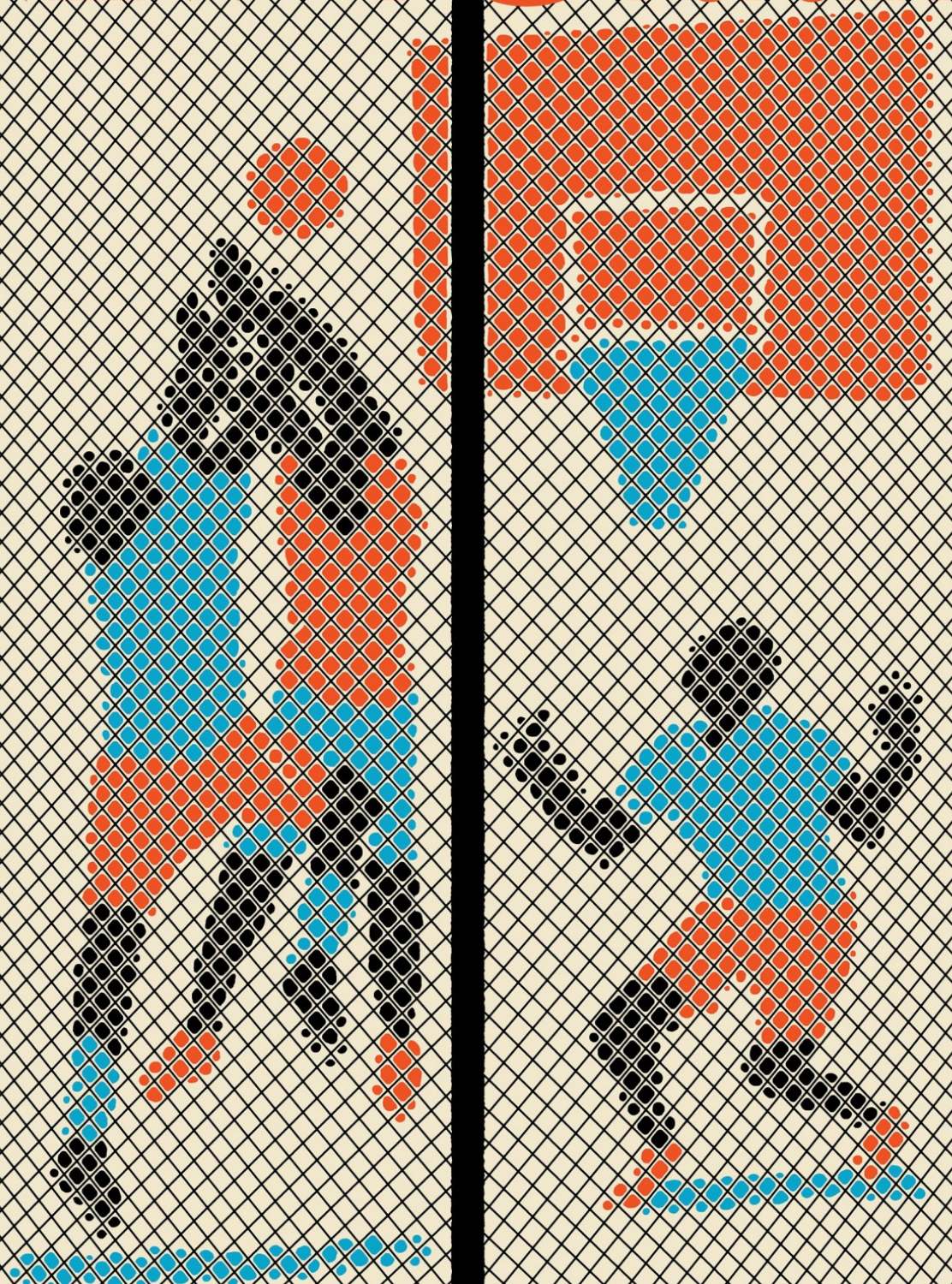


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By [Vince Aletti](#), [Dan Stahl](#), [Zoë Hopkins](#), [Hilton Als](#), [Sheldon Pearce](#), [Marina Harss](#), [Richard Brody](#), and [Taran Dugal](#)

April 17, 2026

[You’re reading the Goings On newsletter, a guide to what we’re watching, listening to, and doing this week. **Sign up to receive it in your inbox.**](#)

The photographer David Armstrong, who was based in Brooklyn and died in 2014, at sixty, has never looked as good as he does right now, in a big, smartly installed retrospective at Artists Space (through May 23). That’s partly because this is the first time we’ve been able to grasp his career as a whole. The exhibition, although it includes landscapes, still-lives, and nudes, is titled “[David Armstrong: Portraits](#),” because that’s where the emphasis lies. With more than ninety works, the galleries are thronged with beauties, many of whom refuse to be pinned down to a gender. Still, men tend to snag the most attention, if only because they return Armstrong’s tender, probing gaze with affection and plenty of heat. Desire defines the work and is impossible to divorce from our response to it.



“Moritz, Jefferson Avenue, Brooklyn,” from 2009. Photograph by David Armstrong / Courtesy the Estate of David Armstrong

Without overplaying Armstrong's key role in the Family of Nan (Goldin; they were lifelong friends and collaborators), the curators Kelly Taxter and Jay Sanders are careful to ground the show in his history of books and exhibitions. The soft-focus color landscapes and interiors from his 2002 book, "[All Day Every Day](#)," had looked minor and imitative at the time. Here, ringing the main galleries like establishing shots in old movies, they suggest a world fading into memory—a misty past with little meaning for the present. On the other side of the scale, in a vitrine at one end of the space, are a group of five small scrapbooks. Only a few open pages are visible (more are included in the show's catalogue), but they're as tantalizing as a peek into a friend's diary—and proof that pictures in separate bodies of work were being made simultaneously.

That everything-at-once approach explodes across a whole wall at the opposite end of the gallery. Here, a collagelike installation of photographs, framed and unframed, color and black-and-white, abut and overlap across twenty-seven feet. The undertow of nostalgia—a tribute to the way we were—is overwhelmed by the celebration of a spirit that has never seemed more alive.—*Vince Aletti*



About Town

Off Broadway

At the start of "**The Adding Machine**," the narrator (Michael Cyril Creighton) announces what viewers are going to see: "a heartwarming tale about modern life crushing the human spirit," thereby setting the ironic tone. He is himself an addition, introduced into Elmer Rice's 1923 drama by Thomas Bradshaw, who has revised the text for this New Group production, directed with flair by Scott Elliott. Thank God for the flair, because the characters are satirically tedious. Mr. Zero (Daphne Rubin-Vega) spends his days crunching numbers and his nights henpecked by his wife (a droll Jennifer Tilly), until he's unceremoniously replaced by the

titular machine. The stylishly designed show conjures a world where capitalism supplants all ideals except its own: ruthless optimization.—*Dan Stahl* ([Theatre at St. Clement's](#); through May 17.)

Art

What to call objects that bespeak both the three-dimensionality of sculpture and the surface drama of painting? **Leonardo Drew's** uncategorizable works are made from dried and cast paper pulp—leaking with fleshy, organic texture—that the artist reconfigures into jagged, rough-hewn sprays of abstraction which protrude from the frame. Some of these are arranged into more staid compositions of geometric bands of color, while others bend and bulge into shapes evoking the baroque ruination of junk-yard findings. The paper suggests a substrate on which to write but also seems to posit itself as its own kind of language, a haywire syntax made of excess and spillage.—*Zoë Hopkins* ([Pace Prints](#); through April 25.)

Art



“The Lady of Fashion,” circa 1891-92. Art work by Édouard Vuillard / Courtesy Skarstedt

Édouard Vuillard was one of those painters whose most evocative work—a prime selection of which can be seen in **“Édouard Vuillard: Early Interiors”**—tends to be small. It’s almost as if the limitations of a scaled-down canvas got the artist going in ways that galvanized his extraordinary use of color, and sense of scale, even further. Looking at such beauties as the extraordinary “The Flowered Dress” (1891) and the mind-blowing “The Lady of Fashion” (circa 1891-92), you marvel not only at the control of Vuillard’s hand but at what made domestic life and female garments so fascinating to the artist: their details say as much about the inner life of the

wearer as they do about the cloth.—*Hilton Als* ([Skarstedt](#); through April 25.)

Sophisti-pop

In 2005, when the singer Niia Bertino was seventeen, she was recognized as one of the top high-school jazz singers in the country. The granddaughter of an Italian opera singer, Bertino, known onstage as **Niia**, was soon discovered by Wyclef Jean and, in 2007, featured on his hit single “Sweetest Girl (Dollar Bill).” What initially felt like a meteoric rise tapered off into a slow burn. She performed “James Bond” themes with an orchestra in 2011 before débütting, in 2014, with the EP “Generation Blue”; her first album arrived three years later. You can hear all of her accrued experience in five albums she has released since, easing through their elegant pop production with jazzy vocals.—*Sheldon Pearce* ([Blue Note](#); April 28-29.)

Dance



Tiler Peck and Roman Mejia in Jerome Robbins's "Opus 19/The Dreamer." Photograph by Erin Baiano

For the past two decades, Tiler Peck has been one of **New York City Ballet's** most dazzling dancers; more recently, she has revealed herself to be an agile choreographer as well. Her second ballet for her home company uses Édouard Lalo's "Symphonie Espagnole," a sweeping, melodic tour de force that doubles as a showcase for solo violin. (The virtuoso Hilary Hahn will perform on many dates.) The spring season also includes the company première of Christopher Wheeldon's moody 2002 ballet "Continuum," set

to Ligeti piano pieces, and it closes with a week of performances of the comedic “Coppélia.” On May 24, that work’s plucky heroine will be danced for the last time by the equally plucky Megan Fairchild, who is retiring after twenty-five years with the company.—*Marina Harss* ([David H. Koch Theatre](#); April 21-May 31.)

Movies

David Lowery, who directed “A Ghost Story,” returns with another ghost story, **“Mother Mary,”** with the feeling of a filmed play, starring Anne Hathaway as the titular pop star, who’s been offstage for a few years, and Michaela Coel as Sam, a fashion designer who used to make the singer’s costumes. Though they’re long estranged, Mary barges in on Sam to ask for a new dress for a concert comeback; their tense dialectical wrangle in Sam’s churchlike studio is the bulk of the film. Brief flashbacks to Mary’s earlier concerts are merely informational; another flashback, to a séance at which Mary yielded to self-harming mysticism, is far more consequential, leading to violence in Sam’s studio. The resulting catharsis—spiritual and sentimental—is both flimsy and fascinating.—*Richard Brody* (*In wide release.*)



Bar Tab

Taran Dugal samples experimental cocktails in Long Island City.



Illustration by Patricia Bolaños

Cocktail bars operate by the “Anna Karenina” principle: great ones are all alike; average ones are average each in its own way. Take **25 Hours**, in Long Island City, for example, which is freighted with a depressing ambience that is equal parts chemistry lab and subterranean grotto. On a recent weeknight, two first-timers stopped by with high expectations: 25 Hours, which opened last November, is the brainchild of Ray Zhou, a former head of R. & D. at the hip Lower East Side bar Double Chicken Please. The drinks here correlate with different hours of the day—plus an additional “twenty-fifth hour,” which, according to Zhou, is “more of a mind-set, a futuristic kind of thing.” The depth of thought that went into the menu was not reflected in the space; the visitors found themselves in a small room with exceptionally dark lighting, a wall of haphazardly mounted clocks of various shapes and sizes, and modernist chrome furniture that made the already bleak interior even less inviting. They took seats beside a monstrosity of dark gray plastic, affixed to a wall, designed to look like a sheer rock face. “This must be what Purgatory feels like,” one of the visitors whispered. Thankfully, their cocktails were closer to heavenly. The 17:00—a foamy mixture of mezcal and pineapple, topped with habanero tincture—packed a sweet-and-sour punch, and the 23:00, made of rum and barley-tea-infused whiskey, arrived with biscotti, for a sugary reprieve between sips. Their last order of the night, the 19:00, was also the most experimental: a sharp mix of grape juice, tomato water, gin, and blue-

cheese liqueur, with a pungent aftertaste. Drinks downed, the guests' gazes landed on the horological wall in front of them. It was time, they decided, to head out—after all, the clocks were ticking.

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- [Sand, up close and personal](#)
- [A weekend aboard the Modest Mouse cruise](#)
- [Hailey Bieber enjoys proving people wrong](#)

[Vince Aletti](#) is a photography critic and the author of “[Issues: A History of Photography in Fashion Magazines](#).”

[Dan Stahl](#) is a member of The New Yorker's editorial staff.

[Zoë Hopkins](#) is a contributor to Goings On who writes about art.

[Hilton Als](#), a staff writer at The New Yorker, won the 2017 Pulitzer Prize for criticism. He is the editor of “[God Made My Face: A Collective Portrait of James Baldwin](#).”

[Sheldon Pearce](#) is a music writer for The New Yorker's Goings On newsletter.

[Marina Harss](#) has been contributing dance coverage to The New Yorker since 2004. She is the author of “[The Boy from Kyiv: Alexei Ratmanský's Life in Ballet](#).”

[Richard Brody](#), a film critic, began writing for The New Yorker in 1999. He is the author of “[Everything Is Cinema: The Working Life of Jean-Luc Godard](#).”

[Taran Dugal](#) is a member of The New Yorker's editorial staff.

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[Book Currents](#)

A Reading List from the Director of the Noguchi Museum

Amy Hau discusses some books by Marilyn Chase, Karin Higa, and Edmund de Waal that have guided her work as a curator.

April 8, 2026

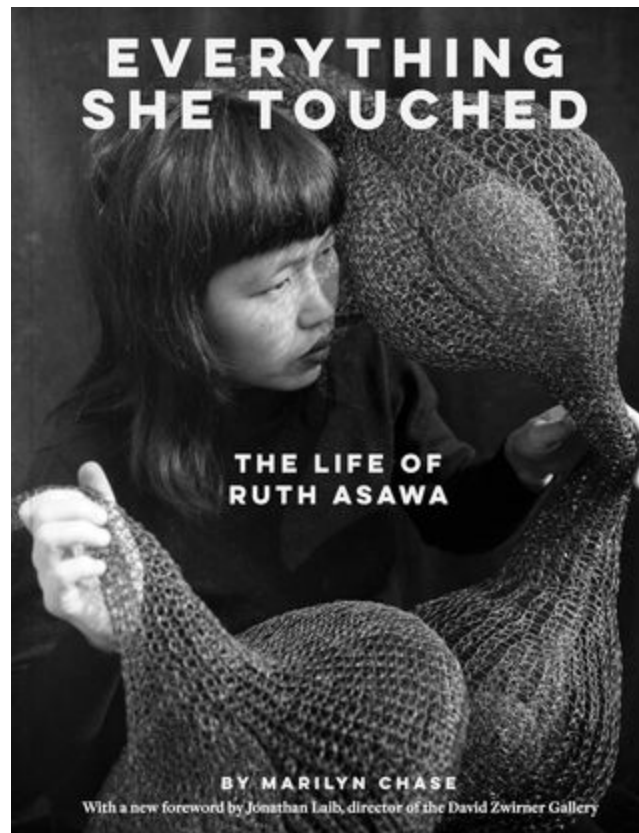


[You're reading Book Currents, a weekly column in which notable figures share what they're reading. Sign up for the Goings On newsletter to receive their selections, and other cultural recommendations, in your inbox.](#)

In 1986, Amy Hau started working with the Japanese American artist, designer, and architect Isamu Noguchi as an assistant at his studio complex, in Long Island City. In 2024, she returned to the space, which now houses the Noguchi Museum—what the artist had called his “gift to the city”—as its director. Lately, Hau spends most of her reading time on archival material related to the artist, but she sat down with us to discuss a few books that have influenced her work and the way she thinks about Noguchi and his themes—among them displacement, community, inheritance, and cross-cultural exchange. Her remarks have been edited and condensed.

Everything She Touched: The Life of Ruth Asawa

by Marilyn Chase



[Amazon](#) | [Bookshop](#)

I'm always fascinated by artists' biographies—reading about where they came from, how they were able to do the work that they did, their obsessions and their points of view. Asawa was born in California in 1926, and was one of over a hundred thousand Japanese Americans who were interned during the Second World War.

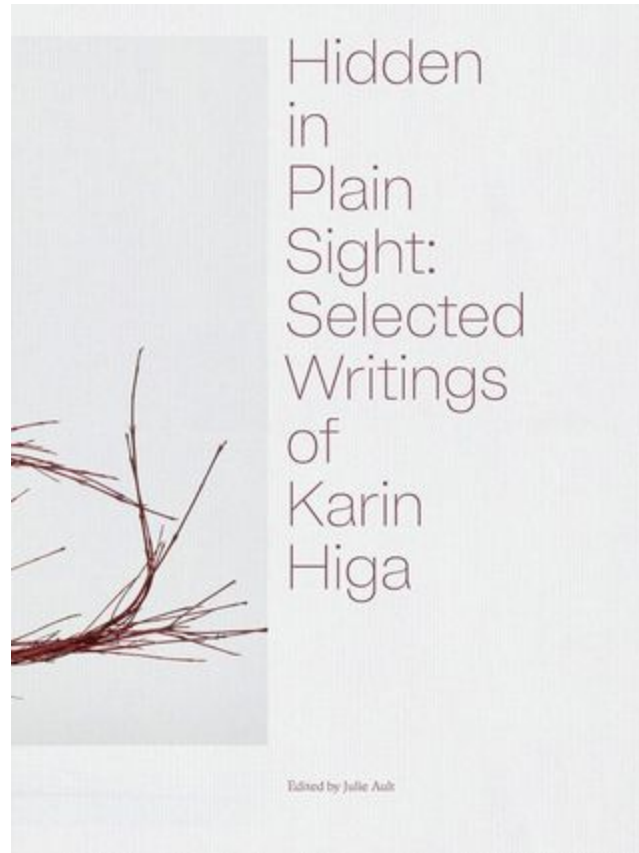
I think it's easy to pigeonhole people into categories—Asian, for one—or to define them by their painful experiences. But Asawa, like Noguchi, showed real resilience. In 1942, Noguchi chose to enter an internment camp in Arizona because he hoped to help find a way to make the conditions livable for the people who had no choice. Both of them came out of these difficult experiences saying I'm not going to be defined by this.

Another thing that's amazing to me about Asawa, and that Chase's book reveals, is her relationship to her family and her community. She had six children. There are photographs of her kids in here, sitting around with her as she's making her work. She also devoted a lot of time to teaching and

working with schoolkids on public-art projects in San Francisco, which is remarkable to me.

Hidden in Plain Sight

by Karin Higa



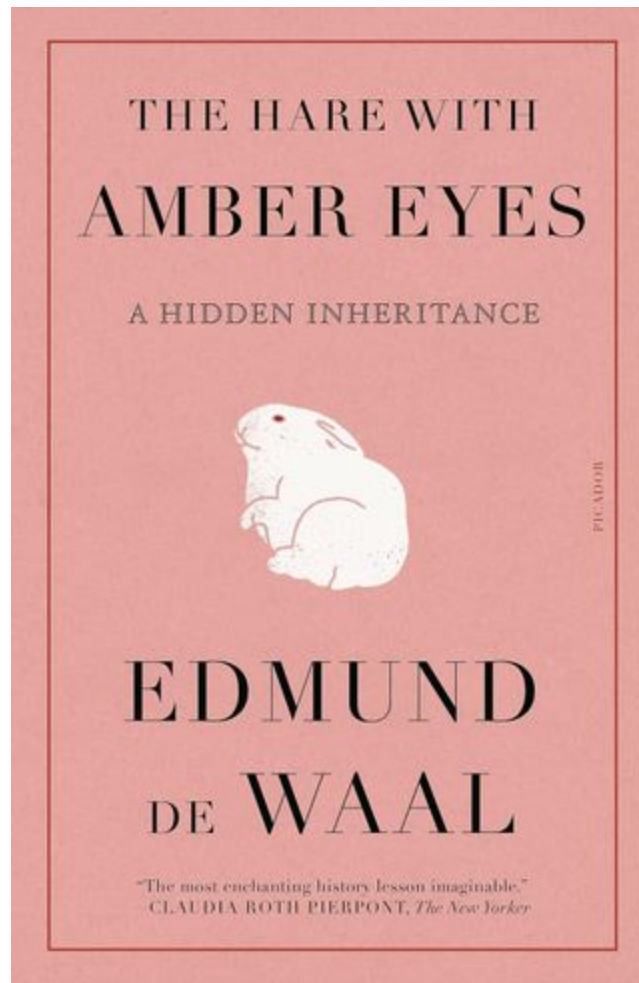
[Amazon](#) | [Bookshop](#)

Higa was a pioneering art historian and curator who died in 2013, when she was only in her late forties. It's so sad that we lost her voice. In this book, which is a collection of some of her writing, she covers famous artists, like Asawa, but also artists who were little known. And these artists—she makes it clear that they're Asian, yes, but they're also American. Her thinking was very multicultural. I always thought, How wonderful, to be celebrating the confluence of different cultures in these artists' lives and works. That's a theme I think about with regard to Noguchi's work, too. Because, in some ways, he did have a little bit of an identity crisis. When he was in the U.S.,

he was sort of seen as Japanese, but in Japan, he was seen as an American. When he went back to Japan after the war, he proposed a memorial for Hiroshima, but it was rejected because he was an American, and it was thought that his participation would have been too painful for people, at that time. So Noguchi struggled all his life to find a balance, asking questions like, Where do I belong? Am I more Asian, or am I more Western? He used that tension when he needed to. And, I also think that, toward the end of his life, when I got to know him, he had a real sense of arriving, in a way. He received a National Medal of Arts, and he also got special recognition from the Japanese government. To see that acknowledgment late in his life, to be embraced by both, really meant a lot, I think.

The Hare with Amber Eyes

by Edmund de Waal



[Amazon](#) | [Bookshop](#)

This is a lovely book that takes you through a personal journey. It's a kind of history of de Waal's family, European Jews who were once wealthy art collectors, that's told through the history of the pieces they collected. Most of them were confiscated by the Nazis in 1938, but one group of items escaped—a collection of two hundred and sixty-four small Japanese figurines, known as netsuke. De Waal is really insightful, and his writing is just beautiful. To me, there's something timeless, even eternal, about the netsuke. You know that they're made in a specific time period, but when you learn about the way that they were loved and treasured, you realize that they have a quality that carries over from one time to the next.

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By Jane Bua | The President thinks Pope Leo XIV is a wuss. Meet some real tough-guy Pontiffs who might have fit the bill.

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J. D. Vance's Bumpy Ride

It wasn't the first time that Trump had debased someone who serves him. It wasn't even the first time that Vance had had to downplay a blasphemy-themed A.I. image.

By [Amy Davidson Sorkin](#)

April 18, 2026



Photo illustration by Cristiana Couceiro; Source photographs from Getty

As recently as a week or two ago, Vice-President J. D. Vance was talking like a man who felt that the odds were in his favor. He'd flown to Hungary to attend a campaign rally for Prime Minister Viktor Orbán, the most Trumpian of European leaders, and, before leaving, he told reporters at the airport how kind the Hungarian people had been to him. Asked about the war in Iran—the day before, Donald Trump had threatened to destroy the country's "whole civilization"—Vance suggested that Iran's insistence on its "right" to enrich uranium might actually represent an opening for a deal. As he put it, "I thought to myself, you know what? My wife has the right to skydive, but she doesn't jump out of an airplane, because she and I have an

agreement that she's not going to do that, because I don't want my wife jumping out of an airplane."

The days that followed were a bleak reminder that whatever rights Vance may think he has—to his dignity, to his faith, or to his position as the *MAGA* heir apparent—are contingent on the agreement he made to subordinate himself to Trump. And the President doesn't seem to mind if Vance humiliates himself running errands. Indeed, Trump has treated a new ballroom as more important to his legacy than his Vice-President is.

Vance had barely wrapped up in Hungary before Trump dispatched him to Pakistan to negotiate with the Iranians. Vance, an Iraq veteran, had reportedly opposed the war, and Trump had not been subtle about wanting to implicate him in its progress. That round of talks fell apart after twenty-one hours, an event that was followed, in quick succession, by Orbán's defeat; Trump's attack on Pope Leo XIV, who had condemned civilization-destroying ("WEAK on Crime"); and the President's posting of a now notorious A.I.-generated image of himself as a robed Christ figure.

Trump deleted that post, claiming that he'd thought the image showed him as a doctor. Vance told Fox News that the President had taken it down because "a lot of people weren't understanding his humor." Was an element of the President's humor insulting the Pope right after Vance had announced that his new book, "Communion: Finding My Way Back to Faith," would be out in June? Vance converted to Catholicism in 2019, after the success of his first book, "Hillbilly Elegy"; in that period, he was pursuing a venture-capital career, backed by Peter Thiel. (In 2022, Vance was elected to the Senate, from Ohio.) Vance has said that his faith was inspired by St. Augustine, but, again, his pact is with Trump. He was promptly put to work telling Leo to stay out of Trump's way and to be careful when he spoke about "matters of theology."

Vance, whose wife, Usha, is expecting their fourth child, might have seen this coming. The plight of Vice-Presidents, with their ill-defined role, is well known, and it is not the first time that Trump has debased someone who serves him. It's not even the first time that Vance has been deployed to downplay a blasphemy-themed A.I. image. Last May, soon after Pope Francis died, Trump posted a portrait of himself as an enthroned Pope. At

the time, Vance said, “As a general rule, I’m fine with people telling jokes and not fine with people starting stupid wars that kill thousands of my countrymen”—a reminder of how the Administration’s goals have morphed. Trump, who once demanded a Nobel Peace Prize, started a war of choice in Iran, inflicting damage that a deal can’t undo.

The American right, too, is in a shifting, querulous state. Last week, at an event in Athens, Georgia, for Turning Point USA, the organization that Charlie Kirk led before his assassination last September, Vance acknowledged that “this Iran thing” had been divisive. Republican opponents of the war, still a minority in their party, according to polls, are a heterogeneous group. Some regret Trump’s bypassing Congress. Many working-class red-state voters—for whom Vance’s right-populist brand is designed—seem dismayed by the spike in gas prices and the neglect of problems at home. There are manosphere anti-interventionists (Joe Rogan, Theo Von). Meanwhile, in a very loud corner of *MAGA* world, inhabited by Tucker Carlson and Marjorie Taylor Greene, the pressing question is how the “Epstein class” managed to corrupt Trump, bending him to its will and Israel’s. And there is talk, apparently in earnest, about the Antichrist. The situation is one of ideological ferment, rather than a reversion to some Romneyite center.

The Turning Point event was meant to feature Vance and Erika Kirk, Charlie’s widow. She cancelled at the last minute, citing unspecified threats to her safety. Onstage, Vance spent ten minutes complaining that certain people doubted Erika’s grief; he decried them as “full of shit” and insufficiently focussed on “left-wing networks of violence and terrorism.” Many in the audience would have guessed that he was referring to Candace Owens, a podcaster with nearly six million YouTube subscribers, who was once a key figure at Turning Point. She has been pushing cartoonish claims groundlessly linking Erika to a supposed vast conspiracy related to her husband’s murder. For what it’s worth, Owens is against the Iran war. (She has also raised doubts about Vance, in part because of his ties to Thiel.)

Trump reportedly enjoys asking associates whom they see as his heir: Vance or the Secretary of State, Marco Rubio? But, if Vance’s bumpy ride is any indication, the G.O.P. field may get both wider and weirder, with a primary

that puts the Party's internal resentments on full display. Still, it would be wrong to view Vance as simply an object of scorn or even pity—devout J.D., an ideas man who just wanted peace and maybe a promotion. He is the same opportunistically malleable demagogic provocateur who, during the campaign, got Trump worked up about migrants allegedly eating cats and dogs. He hasn't shed his affinity for the Viktor Orbáns of the world. Trump recently named Vance “fraud czar,” with a focus on “CROOKED DEMOCRAT POLITICIANS.” He is building a network of big donors. He may yet be President.

Vance does have a noteworthy power as Vice-President: only he can initiate the process, under the Twenty-fifth Amendment, for removing a President deemed unable to discharge his duties. (The Cabinet and Congress also play a role.) The idea that he might do so is, for now, a fantasy. But another aspect of his constitutional role is that the President can't fire him. So Trump will still have Vance to kick around, whether either of them likes it or not. ♦

[Amy Davidson Sorkin](#) has been a staff writer at The New Yorker since 2014. She has been at the magazine since 1995, and, as a senior editor for many years, focussed on national security, international reporting, and features.

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[Peace on Earth Dept.](#)

The Popes That Trump Might've Liked

The President thinks Pope Leo XIV is a wuss. Meet some real tough-guy Pontiffs who might have fit the bill.

By [Jane Bua](#)

April 20, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

The other day, President Trump took to Truth Social to complain that Pope Leo XIV, the new Supreme Pontiff from Chicago, has been “weak on crime.” The Pope preaches peace too much, the President said, which “does not sit well with me.” There have been two hundred and sixty-seven Popes in the history of Popedom; would any of them have measured up to the President’s standards?

Pope Urban VI, who Poped from 1378 to 1389, was as tough as they come. He was so tough that he arrested half a dozen cardinals, confined them in an old cistern, and tortured them, after hearing a rumor that they were plotting to get rid of him. (As Trump once said, “When somebody challenges you unfairly, fight back.”) Only one cardinal survived—smells like a snitch—and Urban was apparently disappointed by how little the other captive cardinals had screamed.

As far as tough guys go, Pope Stephen VI (896-97) is up there, too. Like many strong leaders, he hated his predecessor, Formosus. In the mid-890s, Formosus supported King Arnulf, the leader of the Franks, in his invasion of Italy, then crowned Arnulf Roman Emperor—despite there already being a Roman Emperor. Even after Formosus died, Stephen VI, his replacement, thought that the dead Pope hadn’t been sufficiently punished for this betrayal, so he exhumed Formosus’ body, dressed it up “Weekend at Bernie’s” style, and put it on trial. Formosus’ corpse was found guilty of violating papal law. It was also accused of perjury, as many men—dead, or President—have been. Perhaps Formosus was just the victim of a witch hunt.

Pope Alexander VI (1492-1503) is another Pontiff who might have passed muster with Trump. Much like the President, he was a family man and a nepo baby. His uncle had been Pope and had personally made Alexander a cardinal. Then, when Alexander ascended to the papacy, he made at least nine relatives cardinals. He knew how to keep his family close—to God, of course. Even more up Trump’s alley, Alexander VI was a businessman. During his papal candidacy, he supposedly promised a rival cardinal multiple mules laden with bags of silver in exchange for supporting his bid. (“Leverage,” Trump has remarked. “Don’t make deals without it.”) It is said that, in 1501, Pope Alexander’s son Cesare, born of his chief mistress, Vannozza (“I’ve had them all, secretly, the world’s biggest names,” Trump once wrote, of his romantic partners), threw a party that became known as the Banquet of Chestnuts. Fifty young courtesans attended, according to a journal entry from the time, “at first in their garments, then naked.” Then “chestnuts were strewn around, which the naked courtesans picked up, creeping on hands and knees between the chandeliers.” Trump loves a nice chandelier. His new four-hundred-million-dollar East Wing ballroom was

supposed to have several gold ones, but a very weak judge has blocked construction.

Pope Benedict IX might have caught the President's fancy. At one point, he accepted a pretty sum to abdicate the papacy—the art of the deal. Benedict is also the only Pope in history to hold the office three times, so there's a good chance he's already on the President's radar.

We also shouldn't forget about Chief Pope, the L.A.P.D. officer from “The Closer,” who's not technically a Pope (or a real person) but is definitely tough. As is Olivia Pope, the D.C. fixer from “Scandal,” whom the show describes as a “gladiator in a suit.” It would have been better if she were an actual gladiator Pope, but you can't have everything.

Or perhaps the President would have been satisfied enough with Peter, one of Jesus' original twelve apostles, whom many consider to be the first Pope. Peter is famous for denying ever knowing Jesus. Trump, too, has denied association with people whose names start with “J.” There's nothing tougher than that. Then again, the Bible says that as soon as Peter denied Christ, he “wept bitterly” in remorse, which is decidedly weak. Everyone knows real Popes don't cry. ♦

[Jane Bua](#) is a member of The New Yorker's editorial staff who covers classical music for Goings On. Previously, she wrote for Pitchfork.

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[Collab Dept.](#)

When Soul Food Met Daniel Boulud

The Harlem franchise Charles Pan-Fried Chicken invited a bunch of chefs to take over for the weekend. Up next: oxtails from Lana Lagomarsini.

By [Zach Helfand](#)

April 20, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

This is the era of the Exclusive Dining Experience, which is marketing speak for a meal you'll never get to enjoy: hot reservations you can't get, Michelin-star pop-ups you can't afford, intimate chef nights to which

you're not invited. Two years ago, Charles Gabriel, of the Harlem soul-food franchise Charles Pan-Fried Chicken, collaborated with Daniel Boulud. "It was funny because Daniel Boulud is Daniel Boulud, but everyone's saying hello to Charles," a chef named Quié (rhymes with "twee"), who runs Gabriel's business, said recently. The dinner collab cost two hundred dollars and was held at Bar Boulud. It was great, but something didn't feel right. "I'm pretty dope," Quié said. "Which has got me through amazing doors and into amazing kitchens with some amazing chefs. But my community don't get a chance to partake in their delicious food."

Last week, Quié, who has the build of a refrigerator and the energy of a hummingbird, was at the Charles Pan-Fried Chicken on 145th Street, preparing for another collaboration. He was inviting celebrated chefs to take over for one weekend each month. The meals are open to anyone, to-go, and cost twenty-five dollars. "It's not a money-maker. At all," Quié said. "But it's not about that. It's like when Jay-Z brought Oprah to Brooklyn."

This weekend's chef, Lana Lagomarsini, met Quié at a picnic table outside. She was there to test her dish: tamarind barbecue-glazed oxtails with chowchow, which would pair with Quié's Rasta pasta. Lagomarsini, a semifinalist on "Top Chef," has worked at Gramercy Tavern, Momofuku Ko, and Francis Mallmann's Garzón, in Uruguay. She joined an ongoing lineup—ten chefs so far—that has included Ayo Balogun, of the Dept of Culture, in Bed-Stuy, and Serigne Mbaye, whose New Orleans restaurant, Dakar *NOLA*, is considered among the best in the country. "This is like the Justice League," Quié said.

Lagomarsini laughed. "I'm just regular-degular."

"No, you are in the catalogue of dopeness," Quié said.

Lagomarsini, who wore gold earrings and has arm tattoos, got organized. Quié kept getting up, sitting down, calling out to people in the street, checking on the kitchen, and whipping out his phone to film promotional videos. Lagomarsini seemed used to it: chefs.

She lives nearby. "I come here myself once a week," she said. "There's a three-piece, you get two sides, and it's eighteen bucks. It's very shareable,

but also not shareable, you know?” Lagomarsini’s cooking celebrates the Black diaspora. “I get a kick out of tracking down recipes of old Black chefs,” she said. She has unearthed dishes by Thomas Downing, known in the nineteenth century as the Oyster King of New York, and by James Hemings, born into slavery, who was Thomas Jefferson’s chef in France and helped introduce America to macaroni and cheese. Lagomarsini also discovered material about her ancestors. “I found out for sure my family was enslaved,” she said. “I found the name of our owners, and where the family is. They’re still alive.” This summer, she’s opening her first restaurant, a fourteen-seat supper club on the Upper East Side. She named it Creola, after her grandmother.

Quié popped out of the kitchen and said, “Showtime!” There were four burners going. Quié had prepped Lagomarsini’s dishes and was working on an Alfredo sauce. “I based it off Olive Garden’s,” he said. They assessed the oxtails: too small. “I want huge oxtails for the weekend,” Quié said.

The final side dish was Gabriel’s cornbread, made with plantains and drizzled with cane-sugar-infused honey. Growing up in Harlem, Quié idolized Gabriel, the son of sharecroppers and one of twenty kids. “Same parents, by the way,” Quié said. “Everyone had chores. His job was to catch the chicken, kill the chicken, pluck the chicken.” During the pandemic, Quié was furloughed from a Dave & Buster’s. He approached Gabriel, who is seventy-eight, about cooking for him. Gabriel told him he’d had to close the restaurant. “I was, like, ‘Nah,’ ” Quié said. They partnered to bring it back.

Lagomarsini slathered the oxtails with the glaze, which was dangerously sticky. “It’s a blessing and a curse,” she said. “One time it spilled all over the trunk of my car.” Quié attended to two burners while running around recording Lagomarsini on his phone. Lagomarsini dolloped more glaze and said, “Want me to plate up, chef?”

She displayed the dish as Quié directed her through a promo. “How do I say this properly—you’re gonna describe it sexy-like,” he said. They returned to the picnic table to taste. Lagomarsini offered a bite to Quié’s nephew Poppa, who works at the restaurant. He shyly declined.

“Boss, please!” Quié said. “Grab a fork.” Poppa sat down. “All right, try the oxtail first,” Quié said. “Sauce. Now eat the chowchow. Now take another oxtail. Pasta now. O.K., now you can have the cornbread.”

Quié was delighted with the oxtail: “Oh, my God. It’s sauced perfectly.”

“Cuteness, right?” Lagomarsini said.

As they ate, an older woman with a cane stopped on the corner and yelled out, “What is that?”

“It’s some oxtail,” Lagomarsini called.

“I’ll be back,” the woman said.

“You better be back!” Quié said.

The woman was done bantering: “I better get my cornbread.”

Both chefs replied, “Yes, ma’am.” ♦

[Zach Helfand](#) is a staff writer at *The New Yorker*.

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[The Boards](#)

Daphne Rubin-Vega Comes Home

Strolling through Hell’s Kitchen, the actress recalls old celeb sightings (Jane Fonda! Donald Sutherland!) on her way to playing the swaggering Mr. Zero in “The Adding Machine,” Off Broadway.

By [Sarah Larson](#)

April 20, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

Long before Daphne Rubin-Vega became a Broadway star—in 1996, at age twenty-six, when she debuted the role of Mimi in “Rent”—she felt at home in the theatre district. For a time, as a kid, “I lived here, next to the Actors Studio,” she said recently, in front of a town house on West Forty-fourth Street. She’s currently working two blocks away, starring as Mr. Zero in the New Group’s revival of Elmer Rice’s expressionist satire “The Adding

Machine.” Rubin-Vega is five feet two and trim, with swooping dark hair, and she wore a wool jacket and pin-striped pants. Born in Panama, she emigrated with her mother, a nurse, in the seventies. In New York, her mother married a magazine editor and they moved into his apartment, on that building’s garden level. Her parents were creative—she played Chopin on the piano; he wrote science fiction—and observant. “I remember my mother coming home and going, ‘Hey, so-and-so is out there,’ ” Rubin-Vega said, referring to actors. Her mother collected autographs for young Daphne. “I had a ‘Humpty Dumpty’ book with signatures from Ben Gazzara”—a member of the Actors Studio—“and Donald Sutherland and Jane Fonda, because they shot ‘Klute’ across the courtyard,” she said.

“Honestly, I remember walking out of this place—there was a yearning,” she went on, looking up and down the street. “That’s why I had to come back.” She recalled that feeling: the fantasy of seeing a legendary actor, “and the fact that these buildings look like churches.” She gestured toward the Gothic Revival New Dramatists building (“*DEDICATED TO THE PLAYWRIGHT*”), a few doors down. “There was something very spiritual about it. I used to listen to ‘The Me Nobody Knows’ with Irene Cara, probably the first year I got here. I remember thinking, Oh, my God. I recognized myself somewhere.” A savvy bohemian neighbor gave her a copy of *Backstage*, where she saw an audition for “children’s theatre”—“The Princess and the Pea.” “So, after school, I went to where this audition was—I was a latchkey kid—by myself. The woman was, like, ‘What are you doing here? How old are you?’ And I said, ‘Nine years old.’ And she said, ‘Come back in another nine years.’ It was devastating.” Rubin-Vega gazed toward the under-stairs entrance to her former apartment. “I feel like sitting on the stoop until I get kicked out,” she said. Eventually, she headed to Amy’s Bread, on Ninth Avenue, for a café warmup before showtime.

“The Adding Machine,” from 1923, is about Mr. Zero, a repressed number cruncher who gets replaced by an adding machine. He kills his boss (Michael Cyril Creighton), impassively accepts prison and execution, and fails to find happiness even in the Elysian Fields; he’s also a bigot who shuns its “mixed” and pleasure-seeking crowd. Rubin-Vega plays Zero with muted calm and quicksilver rage; he can look stunted, stunned, then lash

out, floridly. “I try to lose myself in this character, at least physically,” she said. “Particularly for Zero, I need to leave that wiggle room of Daphne.” She hasn’t played a man before. “But, in my teens, I had this comedy-sketchy character named Dick Manly. He was so ratchet. The ego!” Zero’s swagger is a descendant of Dick’s. “Zero really has permission to say the things he says because he knows that somebody in there gets him,” she said. “And that’s the permission that I give myself, as a brown woman—to speak those words and, like, bite into them.” His language doesn’t faze her. “I grew up in New York. My teachers used to talk like that!” she said, laughing. “They were, like, ‘Do you think you’re better than me?’ ”

The New Group’s new home is at the Theatre at St. Clement’s—a church building, like those on her old block. “Just coming off the run of ‘Twelfth Night,’ ”—Shakespeare in the Park, last summer—“it’s hard not to absorb the fact that theatre and democracy were born at the same time in Greek civilization,” she said. “And that theatre was mandatory in order for people to be urged to make up their own minds. I’ve always thought of the theatre as a sacred place.”

At the café, she’d taken her coat off, revealing a butterfly brooch. “This was my mom’s,” she said. Her mother died when she was ten, not long after they left Hell’s Kitchen. Rubin-Vega doesn’t often talk about the autographed “Humpty Dumpty” book, she said, “because it’s so long ago that I didn’t even know that this was what I wanted, you know? It was, like, my mom—because I lost her—this sounds freaky, but I often think that, like, this is beyond my own will. Like, I’ve been buoyed, the wind is at my back.” She looked at the time; it was almost six. “Oh! Time to go and turn into a man.” At the Theatre at St. Clement’s, she signed some autographs and went inside. ♦

*[Sarah Larson](#), a staff writer, has been contributing to *The New Yorker* since 2007.*

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[Paris Postcard](#)

The Anatomy of a Failure

From spray-on condoms to radioactive wrinkle cream, “Flops?!,” at the Musée des Arts et Métiers, in Paris, puts terrible inventions in the spotlight.

By [Lauren Collins](#)

April 20, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

“Why not come up with a condom that fits the man, rather than vice versa?” a German entrepreneur named Jan Vinzenz Krause once asked. His solution, the spray-on condom, which involves coating a penis with liquid latex, made it to the prototype stage only to encounter a fatal problem: the latex took up to three minutes to fully dry. *Pfffffft*. This is just one among hundreds of cautionary case studies awaiting visitors to “Flops?!,” an exhibition at Paris’s Musée des Arts et Métiers focussing on the “failure, bust, bomb, fiasco, debacle.” Behold the V-shaped keyboard, the hydrogen helicopter, the roller-skating Barbie that sets the rug on fire.

“We thought it would be interesting to show that which we never show,” Marjolaine Schuch, who co-curated “Flops?!,” explained recently. “All the stuff that gets shoved under the carpet.” The show originated at a design museum in Saint-Étienne; Musée des Arts et Métiers has supplemented it with lemons from its permanent collection, such as the ten-hour decimal-time clock, used during the French Revolution. “This is the Pascaline,” Schuch said, pointing to what looked like a jewelry box covered in brass gears—an early, not entirely dependable, calculating machine conceived by Blaise Pascal. In mounting the show, Schuch and her team committed a gaffe of their own. “We didn’t include the dates of the inventions, and we immediately started getting all kinds of comments,” she confessed. The Pascaline’s label bore evidence of their cleanup job: a rubber-stamped addition reading “1642.”

Nearby, a screen displayed e-mails between the investors Paul Graham and Fred Wilson: “I am not sure they can take on the hotel market,” Wilson writes, deciding against investing in Airbnb. Graham published the exchange on his blog in 2011, as a testament to the fact that even successful people don’t always get it right. That such a blunder might be shrugged off and even celebrated, rather than shamefully shunted away, struck Schuch as a very American notion. (Anyone who has witnessed a French schoolchild’s horror of committing “*fautes*” will agree.) “In France, we never talk about these steps, this groundwork, these impasses,” Schuch said. “This was an opportunity to demystify and de-dramatize failure, this idea that making a mistake is something rather serious from which one doesn’t necessarily recover.”

Not every downfall has an upside, as early adopters of Tho-Radia, a line of thorium- and radium-based face creams, promoted by Dr. Alfred Curie—no relation to Marie—soon learned. And then there’s London’s “Walkie-Talkie” building: a skyscraper whose convex shape caught the sun like a magnifying glass, melting cars. In addition to such “dangerous flops,” the exhibit features inventions that fizzled because they were expensive and unnecessary (the Juicero juicing machine), poorly designed (the Vasa, a Swedish warship that sunk on its maiden voyage), or simply ahead of their time (La Jamais Contente, a speedy electric car that came out in 1899). “Everybody forgets that electric vehicles were invented at the same time as

combustion-powered vehicles,” Schuch said. A case nearby contained an old Michelin guide, listing charging stations in every city.



“I think he wants homemade dog food.”
Cartoon by Victoria Roberts

Of all the categories of fuckups, perhaps the most jaw-dropping is the “faux pas,” demonstrating, according to the museum’s literature, “at best tactlessness, and, at worst, bad intentions.” A crowd gawked at such specimens as a hollow golf club that one can urinate into and the pastel-toned Bic for Her ballpoint pen, designed “to fit comfortably into a woman’s hand” (though perhaps not into her wallet, as the product cost up to seventy per cent more than non-gendered pens). In 2014, Zara released a blue-and-white-striped child’s shirt embellished with a yellow star. It was meant to evoke a sheriff’s uniform, but, for many, it called to mind concentration camps.

Schuch led the way through a room wallpapered with whimsical non-starters dreamed up by the artist Jacques Carelman: a sinuous Ping-Pong table, transparent playing cards. A section devoted to transportation offered such wonders of disappointment as a shuttle bus, proposed for the La Défense district near Paris, that progressed twice as slowly as a person on foot. The food-processing sector proved equally inadequate: Colgate lasagna, anyone? Schuch paused in front of a Tetra Pak carton of Côtes du Rhône, noting that while such packaging had gone over fine in Nordic countries, French consumers had rejected it vehemently. “Wine in a carton,” she said, shaking her head. “It’s impossible, psychologically.”

In the final gallery, a line had formed in front of an arcade-game-shaped kiosk where museumgoers could play something called “Flop or Top?,” voting on the desirability of new inventions. Sixty per cent, so far, were in favor of an invisibility cape made from lenticular lenses. More than ninety thousand people had visited the exhibition, with a month to go. “It’s not a lot for some museums, but it’s enormous for us,” Schuch said. Only somewhat inconveniently, “Flops?!” was a big success. ♦

[Lauren Collins](#) has been a staff writer at *The New Yorker* since 2008. Her books include “[They Stole a City: Wilmington’s White Supremacist Coup and the Families Who Live with Its Legacy](#)” (July, 2026).

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When Your Digital Life Vanishes

A broken phone or corrupted drive can mean the loss of work, evidence, art, or the last traces of the dead. But sometimes data-recovery experts can summon lost files from the void.

By [Julian Lucas](#)

April 20, 2026



*“I came up with this theorem,” Steve Burgess, a data-recovery pioneer says. “The value of a person’s data is negatively correlated with whether or not they have it. Once they have it, it really wasn’t worth anything. But, if they don’t have it, it’s worth an arm and a leg and their children.”*Illustration by Carolina Moscoso

The man had been slumped over his laptop for a week by the time his body was discovered. His deliquescent tissue had seeped under the keys, short-circuiting the motherboard. It was a killing from beyond the grave, flesh and blood’s revenge on silicon. Yet digital death differs, crucially, from the genuine article. Sometimes, with luck, it can be reversed.

It happens to the best of us—the farmer who plowed over his smartphone, the biologist with a flooded lab, the professional photographer whose dog chewed through his SD card just after an important shoot. Losing files is inevitable in our paperless, data-driven, device-mediated world, notwithstanding its fanciful promises of cloud-based immortality.

I used to count myself one of the prepared. Little escapes my archival dragnet: I keep every phone I’ve ever owned in a labelled shoebox, and the

archived “souls” of long-defunct computers on a PC called *Thoth*, for the Egyptian god who records the weighing of hearts on the journey to the afterlife. Then, six years ago, I set my iPhone down on the edge of my bathroom sink, and it fell, shattering on the tiles.

The spiderwebbed screen bled colors, and the keypad flashed, as though ghostly fingers were trying to guess my passcode*. *{: .small} I winced at the expense, but the intangible costs emerged more slowly. I realized that the phone had stopped synching with my iCloud, and, when I brought it to a repair shop, they couldn’t fix it. Among the likely casualties were some of the last texts and voice mails I’d received from my father, who’d died of heart failure not long before.

It was from him that I’d learned to protect my files in the first place. Growing up, I practically lived in his home recording studio, a starship’s bridge of mixers and monitors where he set aside a corner for my experiments with code. A musician who’d played with Miles Davis, and written and produced for Madonna, he was also a data hoarder, and he had spent a decade digitizing his extensive record collection for a custom music server that he dubbed *Soulbro*.

My father taught me to burn disks, to back up files, and to discharge static electricity before handling a computer’s delicate innards. He had a surgically implanted defibrillator and liked to call himself a cyborg—a boast laced with irony, because the device periodically misfired, delivering shocks that could knock him to the ground. He spent his final weeks in an I.C.U., which appeared to me like a nightmare double of his studio, its monitors transcribing the rhythms of his own waning heart.

The studio took years to clear out. I made disk images of the half-dozen computers, which were subsequently dismantled. Then, this fall, my mother found two hard drives we’d overlooked, which could have been either mine or his. Both failed to register when I plugged them into my computer; one made an ominous grinding noise. Still, I couldn’t bring myself to let them go.

For thousands of data-loss victims, the last resort is a recovery service called DriveSavers. It’s a half hour from San Francisco over the Golden

Gate Bridge, in the balmy, scenic suburb of Novato. The boxy, low-rise office overlooks a verdant wetland frequented by otters and egrets. Visiting in January, I felt that I'd arrived in hard-disk heaven.

I was greeted by Sarah Farrell and Mike Cobb, two directors of the company. Farrell, a teacherly woman with blond hair and a beekeeping hobby, oversees business development but used to be an engineer. "In the lab, I just assume everything has been in the toilet," she told me. "During *COVID*, I can't even tell you what people spilled on their MacBooks." Cobb, who runs engineering, is a genial man with lively blue eyes, and once saved a computer tower from a burrowing squirrel: "He peed right on the power supply." Cutesy anecdotes alternated with triumphs and tragedies—a school district rescued from a ransomware gang, an iPad salvaged from a plane crash. "They made me too sad," Farrell said of the worst cases. "I had to be, like, 'Symptoms, no story,' or I'd never be able to go home."

Their handiwork was on display in the lobby's Museum of Bizarre Diskasters, an exhibition of silicon carnage. "I remember opening this one out on the deck," Cobb said of an ancient Toshiba laptop, which had burned shut in a fire. "It was like an oyster." One successfully recovered smartphone had been shredded by a snowblower. Another had been sliced in two by a monorail, like a magician's assistant. The company regularly buys brand-new devices and tears them to pieces. "It's like the jaws of life," Cobb said. "If a car gets absolutely demolished, you need to know what to cut and what not to cut."

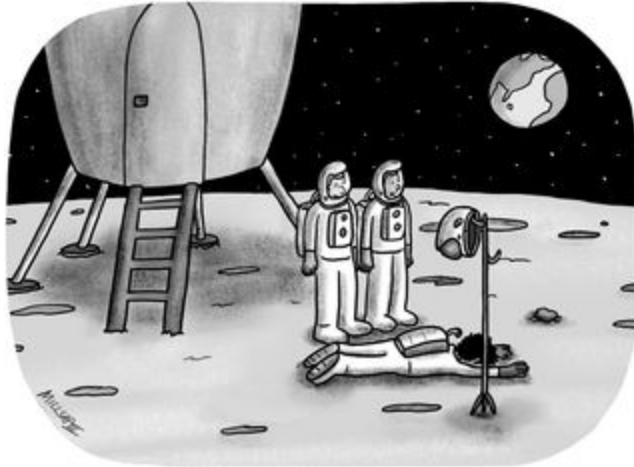
DriveSavers receives some twenty thousand inquiries each month. It has saved data for government agencies, multinational corporations, and more than a few celebrities, whose autographed portraits beamed from the lobby walls. Sidney Poitier recovered a draft of his memoir through the company's good offices; Khloé Kardashian, a phone that fell into a pool. Data loss has been the digital age's great equalizer: What else could bring together such disparate figures as Willie Nelson, Buzz Aldrin, Gonzo the Muppet, and Gerald Ford?

The memorabilia dated back to the eighties. Back then, hard drives stored so little and cost so much that they were generally more valuable than the files they contained; one forty-megabyte drive on display in the lobby

originally retailed for twenty thousand dollars. Advances in storage density, and the digitization of everything from filing taxes to laying out magazines, changed this calculus. “It was like two crossing lines,” Jay Hagan, who co-founded DriveSavers, later told me. “The cost of drives was going down, and the value of data was going up.”

Fittingly, the company emerged from the crash of a hard-drive manufacturer, Jasmine Technologies, where Hagan met his co-founder, Scott Gaidano. In 1989, they established DriveSavers as a repair service for their former employer’s abandoned customers, whom they quickly realized were more concerned about their files than their hardware. “I came up with this theorem,” Steve Burgess, a data-recovery pioneer who sold his own company to the duo, told me. “The value of a person’s data is negatively correlated with whether or not they have it. Once they have it, it really wasn’t worth anything. But, if they don’t have it, it’s worth an arm and a leg and their children.”

Recovering data from an iPhone or a hard drive can set you back three thousand dollars, and from an enterprise server, six figures. Although DriveSavers has a “no data, no charge” policy for most customers, it gets accused of overcharging by scrappier competitors, who tend to attribute the company’s success to attention-grabbing stunts. (One rival has mocked DriveSavers’ engineers as “clowns in spacesuits,” alluding to the protective gear they wear in ads.) But Farrell insists that the fees reflect care and determination. She once spent a week recovering an iPad for a couple with an autistic child who was so attached to a farming simulator that he couldn’t calm down without it. “They still invite me to barbecues,” she said. There have also been litigants who’ve lost their evidence; scientists, their research; the bereaved, their dearly departed’s final words.



"I told him the hat rack is decorative."

Cartoon by Lonnie Millsap

DriveSavers' own death has been foretold many times. The cloud was supposed to destroy them; before that, it was commercial backup services, solid-state drives (SSDs), and encrypted smartphone hardware. Still, people keep finding ways to imperil their files, which grow ever more numerous and irreplaceable. Our precarious datasphere extends from cryptocurrency to telemedicine; now, with the advent of virtual companions, it's even possible to lose the love of your life to a glitch.

Technological progress may be increasing our exposure. A.I. agents are becoming notorious for accidental deletions, while the proliferation of data centers has wildly inflated the cost of storage. And, despite exponential growth in capacity, the average hard drive's life span remains just under seven years. Considering the hundreds of zettabytes of data estimated to exist in the world, it's as though a million Libraries of Alexandria were saved from annihilation solely by hamsters on wheels.

Perhaps this is why I found it so soothing to be among the Diskasters, whose data, after all, had survived. I'd sent my phone ahead of me, and the tour had kindled a cautious optimism about its fate. One vitrine contained a decapitated Mac PowerBook 100, which had spent three days underwater; next to it, for emphasis, a taxidermied piranha bared its teeth. All *these* devices had escaped the maw of oblivion. Why should mine be any different?

The PowerBook had belonged to a couple of jugglers, Tony Duncan and Jaki Reis, who nearly lost it on a cruise down the Amazon in March, 1993. They were performers on the *Ocean Princess*, where they juggled swords and torches after dinner. One afternoon, they were practicing as the *Princess* left Belém, in northeastern Brazil, and promptly hit a sunken wreck. They helped the crew evacuate the ship and were safe in a hotel by nightfall. But they neglected to retrieve their PowerBook, which held their contacts, promotional materials, and financial records. “Everything was on that computer,” Reis told me. “I couldn’t leave it behind.”

Reis talked her way onto a crew member’s unofficial salvage expedition. Back on the *Princess*, whose lower decks had sunk below the waterline, she waded down a corridor with a flashlight in her mouth, trying not to think about piranhas. She found the laptop fully submerged and assumed that it couldn’t be resuscitated but brought it back with her anyway. “I’m an Apple person,” she explained. Four repair services turned down the case. Then Duncan saw an ad for DriveSavers: “They were, like, ‘Doesn’t seem likely, but what the hell?’ ” Miraculously, they succeeded, and began exhibiting the PowerBook in an aquarium at the annual Macworld trade show. “We should have negotiated for dividends,” Duncan said.

Many such resurrections take place in DriveSavers’ “clean room,” an E.R.-like space equipped with fans and *HEPA* filters which reminded me of where the Oompa Loompas operate Wonkavision. Before entering, I walked across an adhesive mat that tore the dust from my soles, then donned a mask, gloves, and white coveralls. The room had about eighty computers, which, because of the controlled environment, could safely run in their birthday suits, their bare motherboards mounted to the walls. Monitors showed digits scrolling in columns as repaired hard-disk drives (HDDs) were imaged; others waited in red and blue bins. Phil Reynolds, an engineer, showed me to a table where a four-terabyte drive lay open. “You got a firm grip?” he asked.

It was about the size of a paperback novel, with smooth, reflective disks nestled inside. HDDs store data on swiftly spinning “platters,” usually made of glass or aluminum. Embedded within them are microscopic grains of a magnetic alloy, whose polarities are flipped by “read-write heads” that float

just nanometres from the surface. Every year, the grains get smaller, and the means of zapping them more sophisticated; in March, Seagate, one of the leading hard-drive manufacturers, announced a forty-four terabyte drive, its largest ever—a milestone made possible by a technology called heat-assisted magnetic recording, which uses a laser to heat each grain for a nanosecond.

Reynolds turned a flashlight on the platters, which reflected our masked faces. A single drive might have two, five, or even ten spinning in parallel, with a stack of heads flitting between them. Because of the speed of revolution, a single grain of dust can be enough to strip the magnetic film and obliterate the underlying data. Another threat is corrosion, usually from immersion in liquid: Reis and Duncan's hard-drive platters were cleansed with a deionized solution, then swapped into a replacement drive. "All kinds of catastrophic things can happen," Reynolds said.

My apprenticeship began with a simple disassembly, a typical exercise for new employees. After a brief demonstration, Reynolds handed me pliers and a tiny screwdriver; I struggled to remove one of the actuator magnets, which held so firmly to its opposite that I feared smashing it into the platters. Similarly tricky was the printed circuit board, or PCB, which precisely choreographs the drive's machinery. Each is particular to its model, Reynolds explained: "Without this chip, you're not ever going to get that drive to work again."

Sourcing parts is half the battle. Outside the clean room, I spoke with Pamela Rainger, who manages DriveSavers' inventory. "These are our donor bodies," she said with a sweeping gesture. "They've all been tested and are ready to give up their lives." Behind her, more than thirty thousand drives were shelved in antistatic bags on metal racks. It's not always enough to simply buy a replacement; because of a complex supply chain and the relentless pace of innovation, the donor drive should, ideally, have been made in the same factory, even in the same week, as the recipient. DriveSavers retains a personal shopper in Shenzhen to track down elusive models. For obsolete equipment, they turn to eBay and specialized vendors; once, Rainger had to find a match for a forty-year-old drive from an embroidery factory, which had operated a robotic arm. The trickiest

category might be novelty items, such as the SpongeBob disposable camera one family had used to document a vacation. “There are actually *several* SpongeBob disposable cameras,” she said. “I had to find the exact same one.”

Smart devices add yet another layer of complexity. Downstairs from the clean room, I visited the Flash Physical Department, where a handful of engineers hunched over soldering irons, microscopes, and assorted diagnostic tools. I was greeted by Matt Burger, the head of the department, a friendly, bearish young man with glasses and a mop of brown hair, who was putting a thumb drive through an X-ray machine. “Somebody had it in their laptop and dropped it on its side,” he explained. The monitor showed a slightly bent rectangle covered with dots and lines, which didn’t look so bad to me. I listened for a prognosis, hoping that it might have some relevance to my own wounded machines. Then he spotted a faint crack through the tiny region of the drive that held the memory chip. “This is going to be a no-recovery,” he said.

Flash memory is used in thumb drives, smartphones, newer laptops, and SSDs. The technology exploits a phenomenon known as “quantum tunnelling” to trap electrons in floating-gate transistors, like the genies imprisoned by King Solomon. Because they have no moving parts, flash chips are generally considered to be more stable than HDDs. But their design can also complicate data recovery. Many devices integrate flash storage into their main logic boards and cryptographically pair it with other components for security, a practice popularized by Apple. Saving them can involve transplanting not one but several chips. Burger explained, “You have to have it all working as one cohesive thing. No funny business.” The dead man’s laptop, which arrived still soaked in bodily fluids, had required engineers to remove and clean nearly every chip on the logic board before it could be resurrected, much as Egyptian embalmers preserved the stomach, the liver, the lungs, and other organs so that the deceased could function in the afterlife.

The arcane art that makes all this possible is called “microsoldering”—essentially, soldering under a microscope. Burger sat me down for a tutorial at an empty workstation, where a damaged iPhone board had been readied

for my inexperienced hands. It was an L-shaped thing about the size of my thumb and forefinger; in one of its corners, a chip no bigger than a peppercorn had slightly cracked. “See how it’s impacted there?” Burger asked as I adjusted the microscope. “You can see the actual glass through the top coating.” Burger gave me tweezers and heat-resistant gloves; though my hands felt steady, under the microscope they shook like mad. I was like a giant medical student with a tremor, about to perform surgery on a Who out of Dr. Seuss.

Burger tasked me with swapping out the chip. First, I used a syringe to apply flux, an antioxidant that helps solder stick. Next, I heated the chip with a hot-air gun until the tiny grid of metal balls connecting it to the board melted. “Get your tweezers in there,” Burger encouraged; at last, it came loose. Putting in the new chip was more difficult. I initially struggled to stencil new solder balls onto its underside—“He’s going to break it,” Farrell warned—but managed to finish the procedure, though I inadvertently fused a few resistors in the process. “Have I been fired at this point?” I asked. “Everybody practices,” Burger diplomatically replied. “You could maybe even still salvage data.”

The final stage of a recovery takes place in the Logical Department, a warren of computer towers where engineers analyze the recovered disk images. One of them, Will DeLisi, looked startled as he turned away from a screenful of digits: “They said ‘perfect copy,’ but it’s gibberish, plain and simple.” When files have been deleted, corrupted, or overwritten, it’s his job to reconstruct them; today, he was searching for pictures that had mysteriously vanished. “This file ends mid-sector,” he said, adding that cheap thumb-drive firmware was probably to blame. “The controllers just spit up on top of the file system.”

Files can disappear in any number of ways, only some of which are irreversible. On many systems, deleting them merely removes their addresses from a registry, freeing the space to be overwritten. (This is one reason that the F.B.I. was able to recover deleted e-mails from Hillary Clinton’s private server.) Similarly, corruption or physical damage might destroy a file’s header, which contains its identifying metadata, while leaving other parts of it untouched. In other words, there are file traces

everywhere, like so many ghosts in a vast bardo, which can sometimes be brought back to life.

Logical data recovery is the most D.I.Y.-friendly kind. A YouTuber called Babylonian, who goes to extreme lengths to solve “trivial mysteries,” got nearly seven million views for a video of him “rescuing” a fan’s cherished Pokémon, tragically scrambled in a Game Boy save-cheating attempt fifteen years earlier. (The fan, now an adult, gets emotional when the Pokémon, a Blastoise, is finally retrieved.) But at larger scales it becomes dizzyingly complex. This is especially true when it comes to ransomware, a form of digital extortion that involves encrypting files and threatening to destroy or publish them.

Ransomware recoveries are DriveSavers’ biggest growth area. The day I visited, engineers were racing to unscramble sixty HDDs belonging to a health-care nonprofit. Time was of the essence, but the attackers, too, had been up against the clock. Ransomware attackers usually have limited time before they’re detected. The slowness of encryption forces them to triage. For instance, they might use scatter algorithms that encrypt every *_n_*th megabyte, or delete backups without “zeroing out”—overwriting with zeroes—the underlying files. All this gives recovery specialists an opening. They can write case-specific code to piece together files from partially destroyed backups, or even infer missing data by identifying patterns of encryption. Ideally, the data can be retrieved without a ransom payment, which, in the case of large organizations, might run into the millions.

The phenomenon has exploded in recent years, with small businesses and municipalities particularly at risk. (Last July, St. Paul, Minnesota, suffered an attack that required the deployment of a National Guard cybersecurity team.) A franchise model allows enterprising hackers to license malware from syndicates. “Literally anyone can sign on as an affiliate through the dark web,” Andy Maus, who oversees DriveSavers’ ransomware recoveries, explained. A.I. has exacerbated the situation, he went on: “You can take an I.T. professional who’s relatively unsophisticated, and suddenly, they can mount a sophisticated attack.” In 2023, the company worked on fewer than fifty ransomware recoveries; last year, the total was nearly three hundred.

Occasionally, even victims who pay their ransoms need data recovery, when the decryptors they “buy” malfunction. Their attackers, anxious to maintain their credibility, sometimes even join them in searching for a fix: “I’ve heard they have excellent customer service,” Farrell said. It’s one of many reasons that DriveSavers’ C.E.O., Alex Hagan—who took over from Jay, his father, in 2023—believes that his industry isn’t going anywhere. “Technology will continue to improve, but as long as humans are involved, there’s room for error,” he told me. “People continue to break stuff.”

The more we entrust to computers, the more they become mirrors of our vulnerability. Each month, DriveSavers receives calls from people facing the loss of their memories, their livelihoods, their businesses, their cryptocurrency wallets. For two decades, the most desperate were fielded by Kelly Chessen, the company’s first “data crisis counselor,” who came to the job from a suicide-prevention hotline. “By the time folks got to us, they’d usually been through several levels of computer work,” she recalled. “There was that element of ‘You’re my last chance!’ ” She talked down I.T. guys sobbing about fumbled company servers and entrepreneurs screaming from the wreckage of their burned-down stores; one woman called because her boss had shot his computer, though, luckily, he’d missed the hard drive. When recoveries failed, Chessen helped callers process their emotions—and often bore the brunt of them: “I can’t tell you how many times I got the whole ‘Well, they got Hillary’s e-mails back!’ ” Because there are no limits on call time, the transition from customer service to therapy was often imperceptible. “I’d tell them, ‘This is a grieving process,’ and you could hear them go, ‘Huh,’ ” she said. “That’s not something they’re used to hearing from a tech company.”

Rarely is data loss more of an occasion for grief than in the aftermath of disasters. The National Transportation Safety Board investigates accidents across the United States. Every year, its vehicle-recorder division processes more than five hundred pieces of evidence from wrecked trains, cars, ships, and planes—not only black boxes but also personal devices. In 2013, photos and a takeoff video from deceased passengers’ phones helped establish that a small plane in Soldotna, Alaska, had crashed because of improperly balanced baggage. Two years later, it salvaged a voyage-data recorder from the wreck of the S.S. El Faro, a cargo ship that sailed into a

hurricane and sank with all hands aboard. “These are sometimes the last records, the last words, the last moments of someone’s life,” Ben Hsu, who leads the division, told me. “But our work is technical. The job is to help determine what happened and prevent it from happening again.” Sometimes data extracted from personal devices is shared with victims’ loved ones, offering an opportunity for closure that is all the more significant in the absence of physical remains.

Last year, Jeff Wong had just returned from scattering his father’s ashes in Hawaii when a glow appeared over the mountains near his home in Altadena. He and his family evacuated—and, the next morning, awoke to the news that their home had been consumed by the Eaton Fire. A fire safe in his office seemed to be intact, though; a few weeks later, he enlisted safecrackers to open it. Nearly everything inside had turned to powder, including a dozen storage drives with digitized family photos. But two inner, portable safes *had* survived, though the drives they contained had partially melted. “You could see the components with plastic fused into them,” he told me. “But they were still shaped like drives, so I had some hope.” After five months, DriveSavers recovered the contents of two of them, with artifacts of the damage still visible in certain images. Missing, however, were most photos of his father’s sojourns across the Pacific after emigrating from China in the nineteen-forties: “They must have been on another drive.”

Whether or not people get their files back, they tend to emerge from the experience of data loss at least slightly changed. Kevin Bewersdorf left New York City for the Catskills in 2016. A filmmaker and visual artist, he yearned for a more grounded life, which he found in the rural town of New Kingston. He embarked on a new career as a full-time contractor and handyman, jobs whose patient intimacy fostered a deep love of the place and its people. “Every day, some little beautiful thing will happen on the job sites—the way the light is shining or a person who stops by,” he said. He made a daily practice of filming such moments, which he saved to an external drive. As years passed, he realized that a film was taking shape.

In November, 2023, Bewersdorf was transferring footage in his blue easy chair when inspiration struck. He reached for a nearby notebook, but his

arm caught the cable linking his MacBook to the drive, which crashed to the ground. When he plugged it back in, the drive didn't even register. He tried to stay calm.

"I pride myself on shunning preciousness," Bewersdorf told me. " 'Oh, my movie, I was gonna make this cool movie'—who cares? There's a lot going on in the world." After trying a few home remedies from Google and Reddit, he resolved to move on. Yet sadness gnawed at him, especially after an elderly neighbor he'd often filmed passed away. A friend recommended DriveSavers, and after agonizing over the price tag he sent the drive in. The files were back by Christmas, and last summer "New Kingston" premiered at the Rockaway Film Festival.



"Obviously this whole thing is silly, but—'shuttlecock'?"
Cartoon by Charlie Hankin

"I had more reverence for what I was doing, which is part of the value of death," Bewersdorf told me. "It's funny, these 'files'—what are they, even? Electrons vibrating in some container. But if they can die, if we can lose them in the way that we can lose the information that makes up a person, then they live." It's a truth reflected by the very language we use to describe digital storage, he went on: "They say you 'save' a file, like it's going to Heaven—the idea of salvation is woven into it. I don't know what digital Hell would be. I'm just saying that digital Heaven is where all the files are."

Yet salvation is never guaranteed. In the summer of 1995, Peter Sacks, then a professor of English at Johns Hopkins University, was nearly done with a book he'd been writing for the past seven years. He always drafted in

longhand but had recently embraced digital revision, typing out his manuscript on a Kaypro word processor while staying with a friend on Martha's Vineyard. When the time came to return to Baltimore, he didn't know what to do with his boxes of handwritten materials. Too polite to impose them on his host, he took them to the landfill, then set out for Logan International Airport.

"There was a sense of unburdening," he told me at his studio. "But I also didn't realize the fragility of the medium I was trusting." The book was on two floppy disks, which he put in a tray at the security checkpoint; upon his arrival in Baltimore, he slotted them into the Kaypro and found that they could no longer be read. There might still have been a chance to save the data were it not for a technical misstep. "You had an option to reformat," he explained. "I erased the whole thing."

Sacks enlisted a friend to search the landfill, and he made a series of calls to the university's I.T. department. But the trash had been turned over, and the specialists said that nothing could be done. The book's loss seemed to him strangely foretold by its subject: the emergence of modernism in art and literature against the backdrop of mechanization, and the fragmentation of nineteenth-century notions of the poetic "I." Now it was Sacks himself whose subjectivity had been shattered. "It was a sense of falling and never really hitting bottom," he recalled. "In some ways, I still haven't."

He fell into a depression and largely stopped writing; although he continued composing poetry and occasional essays, he would never again publish a book-length work of prose. During a residency in Marfa, Texas, he entered a period of "mute wordlessness," taking landscape photos and covering them with lines of Wite-Out. "I was working through the grief of having something disappear," he said. "But that erasure was also opening up a new space that hadn't existed, and that became the field into which I moved."

Sacks is now a highly regarded artist. The walls of his studio were covered with his vibrant, densely collaged paintings. A triptych called "Paradiso" showed a white expanse traversed by ribbons of color, so layered with pigment, textiles, scraps of verse, and found objects that it was almost barnacled. "I'm trying to make something 'digital' in the sense of your fingers," he said, inviting me to touch the work. "The materials are things

that seem to have been worn, torn, burned, and have a duration.” And the paintings began, in part, as a meditation on erasure—a rebuke, of sorts, to a digital regime that had abandoned writing’s tactility.

If he still had the erased floppies, he’d probably incorporate them into a work as a memento mori, he told me. I asked whether he’d even want the book recovered, were such a thing possible. “Bring Eurydice back for real?” he replied. “Absolutely. I’m at peace with it, but not that much.”

Before I left DriveSavers, my iPhone was brought out in a little red bin, like a patient on a gurney, or a body in a drawer at a morgue. It was pronounced unrecoverable. The engineers had managed to revive it, but it wouldn’t accept the passcode I’d given them, though I felt certain I’d remembered it correctly. Nevertheless, I declined to use the company’s solid-state shredder, which extrudes a kind of silicon confetti; to me, its gears were the crocodile jaws of the Egyptian goddess Ammit, who eats the hearts of the damned.

A few weeks later, DriveSavers called about those two hard drives I’d found, which I’d also sent them. One had suffered a fatal head crash, but the other merely had a failed control board and had soon been spun up again. The company sent me a flash drive with its data, and I plugged it in with nervous anticipation—might it contain some unfinished work of my father’s? Perhaps I’d find the jazz opera he’d wanted to write about Frederick Bruce Thomas, a Black émigré from rural Mississippi who’d opened a legendary night club in tsarist Moscow.

Alas, the recovered hard drive was mine. I found instant-messenger logs from high school, alternately mortifying and endearing, and various coding projects, including my browser-based version of the ancient Egyptian board game Senet. (Some things never change.) But there were only taunting flashes of the stories and journal entries I remembered writing; in what felt like a prank played by the ghost of my adolescence, I couldn’t guess the password to a locked file saved as “Thoughts.doc.”

Had everything else been on the other drive? Or had I simply imagined all these precious virtual talismans, my father’s and my own? The cascade of disappointments caused me to doubt my own recollections, as though my

brain were only a bad pressing of some lost digital master. It also brought back the memory of my first data-loss experience.

I was fourteen when my computer crashed in a botched upgrade. The games I'd been coding were gone, as was the scenery I'd designed for Microsoft Flight Simulator. I was inconsolable. My father, though already in pajamas, put on his blue bathrobe and hastened to the studio to operate. He disassembled the machine, which he'd also built, while I hovered nearby.

The recovery operation stretched into the wee hours. He swapped the drive into another computer, which he used to analyze the corruption. Ultimately, he concluded that the files had been overwritten by Windows Vista—an operating system so buggy that it was nicknamed the Visaster. He broke the news with a sad smile and a line from “The Lion King,” delivered by Scar: “Life’s not fair.”

He told me a story about his own father, who'd left when he was young. They were more or less estranged but met occasionally to pretend otherwise. Once, my grandfather announced that he'd found a roll of film with the only extant footage of my father's childhood. He invited him over to screen it, hoping, perhaps, to mend through nostalgia a relationship that had never been whole. But the tape had aged so badly that it disintegrated in the projector, along with their illusory reconciliation.

At the time, I was horrified. A child of the early nineties, whose first, second, and third everything had been meticulously committed to camcorder, I could hardly imagine such a bonfire of beginnings or see that the story was an heirloom infinitely more valuable than the footage it concerned. Now I knew otherwise. It would have been nice to have the voice mails, the diaries, the unfinished music. But some records are most revealing when they're zeroed out. ♦

*[Julian Lucas](#), a staff writer, began contributing to *The New Yorker* in 2018.*

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[Personal History](#)

Tabula Rasa

A project meant not to end.

By [John McPhee](#)

April 20, 2026



Illustration by Seb Agresti

This is the sixth article in the “Tabula Rasa” series. Read Volumes [One](#), [Two](#), [Three](#), [Four](#), and [Five](#).

A Legacy Taste of Cream

In July and August, 1946, I washed the breakfast, lunch, and dinner dishes of three hundred people. This was at Keewaydin, a summer camp on Lake Dunmore, in Vermont. The kitchen had two notable features—a big cast-iron woodstove on which everything was cooked, and a dishwasher that stood up like a blockhouse, designed to receive trays two feet by two with wire-mesh bottoms and sides four inches high. I loaded the trays and shoved them over rollers into the machine’s hot jets of soapy water. That

was the least attractive aspect of the job. The most attractive aspect was the cream.

I got up soon after five in the morning, and first went to a large shed full of split wood and hauled some in a cart uphill to the kitchen. Next I went to the cold room in the icehouse, a small barn full of lake ice. A dairy farmer had put our milk there in ten-gallon cans. Unhomogenized, this was udder-grade milk of the Champlain Valley. The cans, heavy even when empty, were made of galvanized steel and had steel handles on the sides. Full, they weighed nearly a hundred pounds, and it was my job to drag them out of the cold room and up a ramp that reached the kitchen.

That done, it was time for my breakfast, before the camp was awake, and before stirring up a can and ladling the contents into three dozen pitchers. I filled a cereal bowl with cornflakes or shredded wheat. Sometimes the chef had made hot oatmeal. A well-muscled man of forty or fifty, the chef had rough edges. His name was Art Vebber and he ran a tight kitchen. His wife, Margaret, made pastries and desserts. I was fifteen years old and always hungry. I lifted the heavy, mushroom-shaped lid off a milk can and dipped a ladle into the cream. If you have ever tasted heavy cream, this was heavier. Call it viscous. Call it cream that would stand up like mayonnaise, cream that no taste bud would ever forget. It didn't go into the cereal like milk, it went onto the cereal as a layer.

Guys my age worked with me there. Ted Griggs. Jack Haas. We ate together at a table on a small porch. One day, Ted Griggs was eating his cream-covered cornflakes when I said something that made him laugh. Jets of cream came out of his nostrils like spaghetti. Another memorable event occurred on a day when I was dragging a milk can up the ramp and Art the Chef, having completed some errand of his own in the cold room, was behind me. Nearing the top of the ramp, I tripped and fell, and the milk can fell with me. Its top came off and ten gallons of milk went down the ramp and up Art Vebber's leg.

I am writing this eighty years later with almost no sense of the intervening time. Like a musical phrase that will not go away, the taste of that cream is still there, rarely showing itself, but I have learned where to find it. With a three- or four-ounce ball of burrata on a plate, I take a sip of whole milk

followed by some burrata and I'm back in Vermont. The milk seems to be catalytic. It triggers no memory on its own but brings history out of the burrata. Some years ago, my wife, Yolanda, and I spent a month at a retreat on an island in Lake Como. The manager was from Campagna, south of Rome, and she went home for a couple of weekends while we were at the retreat. She came back with mozzarella di bufala, a signature product of Campagna—a mozzarella made with milk of the water buffalo. There is no faster way to get from Lake Como to Lake Dunmore. You don't even need a catalyst. The mozzarella di bufala gets there on its own. Yolanda and I went down to Campagna ourselves one time, and cruised around—Pompeii, Herculaneum, a Greek temple at Paestum—but were ever mindful of a restaurant in Salerno, where we ordered nothing but a large platter covered with a dozen balls of mozzarella di bufala.

The Cobra in the Philadelphia Zoo

Reading Francine Prose's biography of Cleopatra, I was surprised to learn that the alleged asp that came up out of a basket of figs, and struck the queen's breast and killed her, may have been a cobra. Cobras coming up out of charmers' baskets are generally six feet long. That must have been some basket. Some figs. It's hard to believe that anyone could be cool enough to say, "Give me my robe, put on my crown; I have immortal longings in me," when a flat-headed reptile with an oscillating tongue was about to rise up three feet. On the other hand, not everyone has my experience.

I can't remember what grade I was in—seventh? eighth? early adolescence, in any case—but the rest seems like yesterday. Some forty of us and our teachers went by school bus forty-five miles to the Philadelphia Zoo. As we walked from building to building there—from the baboons to the tigers to the tortoises—our ranks thinned out, because some people moved along rapidly and others lingered. In the Reptile and Amphibian House, I lingered. The other kids must have found its inhabitants repulsive or boring, but I was drawn to a cobra that was lying flat out and minding its own business. Soon, from the tile floors, there were no more echoing steps, and I was alone with the cobra, sheet glass between us.

We had made eye contact. I had the snake's undivided attention. And I began to sway. Tilting my shoulders right and left, and right and left, I didn't move my feet or look anywhere but into its eyes. Right. Left. Right. Left. If my motion had been accompanied by music, the music would have been Ravel's "Boléro."

Lah, I am looking at you, my hooded friend,
and I'd like to see that part of you,
lah dah loo lah hoo.

Right. Left. Right. Left. Ravel's première performance caused a sexual riot. Right. Left. Two pairs of staring eyes, in intimate contact. Slowly, very slowly, the serpent's erectile head came up, up, cantilevered from its upper body, its firm, columnar upper body. Right. Left.

Now, we are sensing where the music will go,
in its juvenescent way, lah dah loo lah hoo lah doo lah,
and the right-left sway.

The cobra now was swaying, too. The head was up two feet. The hood was spreading, forming its cupped oval. Right. Left. The head, erect, was up a country metre. Right sway. Left sway.

Smash.

Straight at me, the cobra struck. Its head hit the glass. Its venom was on the glass. I ran out of the Reptile House, looking for my teachers and my class.

The City of Brotherly Loot

In the nineteen-thirties, when I was not yet ten, a chicken farmer named George Duell regularly delivered eggs to us, and he didn't just drop them off—he came into the house, sat down at the kitchen table, and talked, especially if my father was there. We always referred to this visitor as Farmer Duell. He was a heavy, jowly man, who had a way of sitting down that suggested no intention of getting back on his feet. He was a recent immigrant from Germany and he may have sensed that on my father's

maternal side the family name was von Roemer. In any case, the scene that puts him front and center on this page occurred in our kitchen one spring when my father asked him if he had yet filed his federal income tax.

“Vaht?” boomed Farmer Duell. “Vaht? Me get on daht sucker list?”

Farmer Duell’s summation of internal revenue was all I cared to hear on the subject as I grew into and past my college years, when I encountered pieces in magazines—often by writers of the front rank who, to me, were literary gods—whining and mewling about penalties they had to pay as a result of un-American audits. The genre embarrassed me.

This attitude was still firmly in place when, at the age of seventy-four, I went to Philadelphia at the invitation of the Academy of Natural Sciences to receive its “Gold Medal for Distinction in Natural History Art.” The evening was billed as “A Conversation” (with me), and consisted of off-the-cuff responses to questions from an audience of several hundred. With the gold medal, I was pleasantly surprised to find a check for a thousand dollars.

Eighteen months later, I was confused by a letter from the Philadelphia Municipal Court, titled “Code Enforcement Complaint,” and identifying me as “Case 0000374156.”

WHEREFORE, the City of Philadelphia requests this Court enter a fine jointly and severally against each defendant in the Amount Due \$10,000.00, Court Costs \$55.00; TOTAL CLAIMED \$10,055.00.

As far as I could make out, I was the only defendant. With a check for ten thousand fifty-five dollars, I could get out of jail free. But what had I done? To whom? Where? I hadn’t been in Philadelphia since Princeton last beat Penn. I was in the dark, perplexed. This had to be a weird clerical mistake. I don’t even live in Pennsylvania. Where did they get my Princeton address? The letter was as baffling as it was threatening, written in broken-bottle prose by someone who had been trained at a professional school that taught “First, do harm.”

I threw the letter in the trash. A month later, another one came. I was still Case 0000374156, and now, for as long as I failed to pay up, the court

would fine me ten thousand dollars a day. As mystified as ever, I looked up numbers and tried to call. I spent about four hours on the phone, most of it on hold. Finally, a man at the Philadelphia end, responding to one of those calls, asked me if I had been paid a thousand dollars by the Academy of Natural Sciences on December 1, 2005.

Yes.

He said there was no record of my ever having had a Philadelphia Business Privilege License.

No kidding.

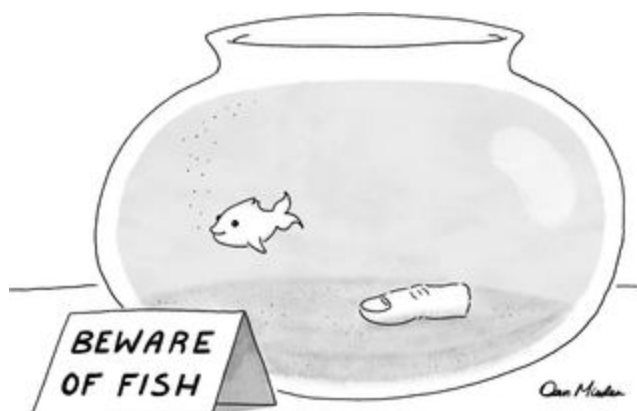
Before the December 1, 2005, event, I should have filed an application and paid two hundred and fifty dollars for a Philadelphia Business Privilege License. By April 15, 2006, I should have filed a Philadelphia Business Privilege Tax return and paid a tax of a hundred and twenty-seven dollars. Since I had not done any of it, the Code Enforcement Complaint had been filed with the Philadelphia Municipal Court.

One cobra strike and one business privilege tax were enough for one lifetime. I vowed never again to go to Philadelphia. Mewl. Whine. For some years afterward, I steadily received notices from Philadelphia demanding returns when my Philadelphia income had been zero, and even demanding returns for the seven years before 2005, years in each of which my earnings in Philadelphia had been zero, as they had been since 1931, the year of my birth.

Philadelphia! My mother's native city! My mother—Quaker daughter of the Quaker daughter of a Chester County farmer, my thee-and-thou mother, who spoke Plain Speech with her own mother, and with her sister Rachel, until the end of Rachel's life. Philadelphia: the city of brotherly privilege tax. Mewl. Whine. Driving south, I used to go through Philadelphia, but never again. Mewl. Whine. Pardon my venom.

Maraschino

I have two friends with a common flaw. They completely fail to comprehend, to sense or savor, let alone appreciate, the bourbon-soaked maraschino cherry. Their names are Jim and Patrick, but we can let that go. They have been editors, writers, publishers of their own and other people's books, and professional consultants at mysterious depths. You would think they would know something, anything, on this topic, but to them a cherry is a cherry, class dismissed.



Cartoon by Dan Misdea

The cherry I'm thinking of is not your Castignano cherry, your Vicenza cherry, your patrician if not patriotic Upper West Side cherry, the fact notwithstanding that it is best described as an al-dente cherry. You just won't find it in a boutique with an unpronounceable name where the world's most expensive maraschinos roll out like grape skins stuffed with perfumed applesauce. You want Aisle 7, north side, top shelf, Pennington Quality Market, or wherever you get your I.G.A. cherries. The larger the jar, the larger the cherry, in generally discernible fractions, so you want the sixteen-ouncer. I.G.A., of course, is the Independent Grocers Alliance, and this is your vox-pop cherry, your socialist cherry, but politics is not why you drown it in bourbon. Texture is why. The national flycaster Ian Frazier, who eats live mayflies so that he can share the experience with rising trout, says the best thing about them is the "chitinous crunch." He could as well be describing a bourbon-soaked maraschino cherry, masticated al dente.

Career Panel

Career Panels, at Princeton University in the nineteen-sixties, were meant to give seniors and juniors guidance in approaching their professional lives. The various panels consisted mainly of alumni who were employed already where the students wanted to be, and were convened in their so-called eating clubs, a form of sorority or fraternity whose naming an editor might have improved.

Future editors were among the students at a club called Dial Lodge one autumn morning in 1962. Broadly speaking, the panel was addressed to the arts, not only the visual arts but also all forms of writing, including journalism. Nine years out of college, I was the regular writer of a section of *Time* magazine called “Show Business.” Ninety-five years old at this writing, I can’t remember the names or affiliations of any but one of the others on the panel, as I could never forget John D. Rockefeller.

Great-grandson of Big Bill Rockefeller, who hustled patent medicines onstage at county fairs, grandson of John D. Rockefeller, who founded Standard Oil, and son of John D. Rockefeller, Jr., this one was fifty-six years old and thirty-three years out of Princeton, from which he had been graduated magna cum laude in—who could imagine—economics. It would snap credulity to say that his career and mine were apples and oranges. Whoever put that panel together must have been on laughing gas. There we were, though, shaking hands, sitting down behind a long table, and trying to be helpful to a roomful of students. No one could say he didn’t belong there. He was the president and founding chairman of Lincoln Center, and the president of the Rockefeller Foundation. A fund he was establishing at the time of the career panel became the Asian Cultural Council, which, according to Wikipedia, has provided grant assistance to thousands of Asians and Americans in the area of the arts.

After the panel ended, there was no limo waiting at the curb for him; he was a Rockefeller, not a movie star. He and I walked across campus to the P.J. & B.—Princeton Junction and Back, the shortest passenger-rail line in the United States. Moderns call it the Dinky. In Pennsylvania Station, he remarked that we should take a taxi together, because he was going uptown, too, and I could get out at the Time & Life Building. At Eighth Avenue and Thirty-second Street, we got into a standing cab. At Fiftieth Street, it turned

right, went a couple of blocks, and pulled over to the uptown curb, my cubicle twenty-five stories overhead. This was 1962 and—it seems incredible—the meter hadn't made it past seventy-five cents. I reached into my wallet and offered him a five-dollar bill. I was offering John D. Rockefeller a five-dollar bill. I have never seen, nor could I ever hope to see, a more benign smile.

Anybody Can Write a Book

If not a book, somebody should write a Profile of Andrew Szanton. He is a former student in my writing class and I don't write Profiles of former students in my writing class. It was a competitive course in the sense that six dozen students, or thereabouts, would apply, and I would choose sixteen. The application was to be accompanied by a fifteen-hundred-word example of the applicant's prose and a letter saying why the applicant wanted to take the course. It was a spring-semester course. Andrew, a senior, applied in the fall of 1984. From his letter, I remember only that he apologized for the length of his prose sample but said its effects would depend on my reading all of it. The piece was called "Coach," and its length approached twenty thousand words.

I read all of it. The protagonist was Andrew's high-school football coach, at Sidwell Friends, in the District of Columbia. Slowly, incrementally, Andrew disassembled the coach, until hundreds of little bits of him were scattered from Rockville to Manassas.

Andrew was unknown to me. I met him on the first day of the spring semester, and within a week formed a first and permanent impression of a quiet, polite, soft-spoken, thoughtful, gentle, and brilliant person. He was paired that day with another student, and their assignment was to interview and profile each other. Across forty-five years, my course began that way. Three days passed. The pieces poured in. Andrew's was about something else. I forget what.

In the first half of the semester, the specific assignment was a factor in each paper due, and Andrew wrote nothing that covered, went into, or even mentioned the factor assigned. I read what he did write and the pieces were

very good. In private conferences about them, I think I did not refer to what was missing, nor did he. In the second half of the semester, my assignments have always been called Free Choice 1, Free Choice 2. I had him there.

Four or five years after Andrew's graduation, I happened to be on the telephone with Sybil Stokes, the wife of the dean of Princeton's School of Public and International Affairs, talking about something or other on the Princeton campus. Out of the blue, she mentioned Andrew Szanton. "Andrew Szanton?" I said. "How do you know him?" Sybil said, "He is my nephew." At this writing, Andrew is forty years out of college. He has successfully pursued an independent (what else?) career writing books for other people—ghosted books, as-told-to books, oral histories—some for clients, some not. His projects have been with athletes, politicians, chief executive officers, the director of a botanical garden, a physician, a Nepalese monk, a theoretical physicist. He did one with Charles Evers, brother of Medgar Evers, the N.A.A.C.P.'s field secretary in Mississippi, who died on June 12, 1963, after a rifle bullet passed through his heart. Andrew Szanton was born in that year. He would become a participant in the Smithsonian Institution Archives' Oral History Program and a teacher of expository writing at Harvard. He is married to Barbara Cannon, M.D., a psychiatrist. They have two children and live in Newton, Massachusetts.

Reminding him that he is a highly skilled writer on his own, I once asked him why he does not write books by Andrew Szanton.

He said, "Anybody can write a book." Absent a function like his, there was not going to be a memoir by Medgar Evers's brother.

For One Person

After her husband died, Betty Constable lived alone in her house on Orchard Circle in Princeton. When autumn came, and winter, she did not turn on the heat. Asked why, she said, "For one person?" Heat six thousand square feet of living space for one person?

Betty Constable was the first coach of women's squash at Princeton University, a job for which she was preëminently qualified. As Elizabeth

Howe, she had grown up in New Haven, Connecticut, and was eleven years old when William Pepper Constable graduated from Princeton. He was the star fullback and captain of Princeton's football team, which lost one game in his three seasons and won the national championship twice. (Freshmen were not then eligible for varsity teams.) Pepper, as he was called, was also Phi Beta Kappa, contender for the Heisman, and the president of his class.

My father was close to this story, because he was the football team's physician. Some years later, when I was teen-aged, he brought home 16-mm. films of Pepper's great games. Over and over, I ran those films on our family projector, watching Pepper Constable (6'1", 191) go off-tackle, shucking Yalies, Harvards, on his way to the end zone. I could make the players run backward as well as forward. Betty Howe, seven years older than I was, had actually been to a number of those games. Moreover, she knew Pepper. Her family and his lived in cities a couple of hundred miles apart, but each had a house on Nantucket. According to my mother, Betty Howe, in her teens, decided that someday she would marry Pepper.

He married someone else first, earned his M.D. at Harvard, and was a flight surgeon in the South Pacific during the Second World War. He also divorced. Seventeen in 1941, Betty forewent college to serve in wartime as a Red Cross nurse's aide. Her mother had been the women's national squash champion in 1929, 1932, and 1934. Betty did not take up the game until she was in her twenties. The year she married Pepper, in 1950, she herself was the national champion. Her principal opponent in those years was Peggy Howe, her twin sister, born in Natick, Massachusetts, minutes after Betty was. They were not identical. Betty was left-handed, Peggy right-handed. Peggy described her own playing style as dainty—at least, in her word, “daintier” than Betty's, of which Peggy used the word “bulldog.” On a squash court, Betty was something like Pepper going off-tackle. Betty and Peggy were in the 1953 national final playing against each other. Peggy was the champion in 1952 and 1953. Betty was the champion in 1950, 1956, 1957, 1958, and 1959—Betty Constable, pleasant, humorous, graceful, formal, practical, sensible bulldog. She was pregnant while she was winning championships and gave birth to two daughters. A third, Liza, was born in 1960, as was my daughter Sarah. They became best friends. Betty's

Princeton squash teams won a hundred and seventeen matches and lost fifteen. Her players called her Mrs. Constable.

In the nineteen-eighties, Pepper developed Alzheimer's disease, the synecdoche in those days for all forms of dementia. As a physician, he had followed the disease to its conclusion and could time his expectations. On a day he chose, when he and Betty were at their house on Nantucket, he went into the ocean and swam in one direction away from the island until he could swim no longer. On a table on their porch, Betty found his clothes, each garment neatly folded, and understood what he had done.

Charlie Ufford

The best squash player I ever played against was C. W. Ufford, Harvard '53. I was not a squash player. He was. But we played in some unusual ways and places. The ocean liner Queen Elizabeth had a squash court, and we played there in September, 1953, on our way to the University of Cambridge. A squash game in those days was fifteen points, three games to win a match. To start each game between us, Charlie would spot me fourteen points. Yet the advantage was all his. He knew what he was doing and I did not. He had been the captain of both squash and soccer at Deerfield Academy, and of those teams, as well as tennis, at Harvard. He was nationally ranked, twice the national collegiate champion. Charlie's credentials as an athlete did not lack range. He was an All-American soccer player. I had come to know him as a 1949 classmate at Deerfield, where I had spent a gap year after deferring my admission to Princeton. He came from Haverford, Pennsylvania, and—according to him—owed a great deal of his hand-eye coordination to a Ping-Pong table at Pocono Lake Preserve, a summer site full of Philadelphia families like his.

Charlie's father, a physics professor at the University of Pennsylvania, had been an instructor at Princeton when Charlie was born, four months after I was, same hospital. In the nineteen-sixties, Charlie became a resident of Princeton, New Jersey, after he married Letitia Wheeler, whom he had met when he was at Harvard, she at Radcliffe. Letitia was the daughter of the cosmologist John Archibald Wheeler, who was one of the greats in the history of physics, specializing in the densest places in the universe, which

he named black holes. Charlie had been through law school and was commuting to a firm in Manhattan. He belonged to a squash-and-tennis club on Pretty Brook Road in Princeton, and, it should go without saying, spotted me fourteen points a game there. Why was he doing this? We were friends. There was no other explanation in the universe.

Did he get any exercise? Some. Relentlessly, he toyed with me, his obvious goal being to prevent both of us from winning. That fifteenth point took forever and ever. If I hit a perfect drop shot, caroming in a corner above the telltale, it came back as a soft high lob, sending me to the back wall, but not hopelessly unplayable, always hanging up long enough for me to get to it by sprinting the length of the court, and with enough space around it for me to do whatever came into my head next. He simply would not lose or win. I had never had so much exercise in so few minutes. We were in our forties then, avoiding, I guess, flab, the voyage on the Queen Elizabeth long behind us, pitching, rolling in the North Atlantic, and playing with an English ball, which ran me even more ragged, because it was soft, unlike the hard rubber of the American ball, and wherever it fell it didn't get up. At his college graduation, Charlie had been awarded the Lionel de Jersey Harvard Scholarship for graduate study at Emmanuel College, Cambridge University, where John Harvard had matriculated in 1627.

My own college was Magdalene, not exactly next door, and I saw Charlie only now and then across the Michaelmas term. Having vowed to myself that I would try to play a sport at Cambridge that was purely English and would therefore augment my experience in the U.K., I went out for basketball. I joined a team that had one English player, one Scot, two other Americans, two Welshmen, a Trinidadian, and a son of the Philippine Ambassador to the Court of St. James. We lacked height. In those years, I topped out at five feet seven. Everybody else was of course taller, but not in basketball's conventional range. We did O.K., travelling the Midlands to various universities, losing to Oxford at Oxford, playing our home games in a building on which big letters by the front door said "Department of Human Ecology." We won more than we lost. We beat the Royal Fusiliers in London. We made it into the national tournament, surprised that there was one.

As the tournament tightened, I got more and more nervous about the height problem. Probably in the dead of night, an inspiration struck. Charlie Ufford! An athlete if ever there was one. Tall. Not by later standards, but six-something and taller than anybody we had. Honed to a fare-thee-well in hand-eye coördination. What difference if the ball was two hundred and twenty times the size of the ones he was used to? I made a recruiting visit to John Harvard's college. Whatever else Charlie was, he was also malleable and ductile. He agreed. Sure. If I wanted him to play basketball, he would play basketball.

I coached him, and gave him stern instructions. He was to crowd the boards, go up and get rebounds. Defensive. Offensive. Rebounds. And when he came down with the ball, he was always to throw it to me. We won a couple of tournament games. Then we faced the United States Navy. Yes. Your eyesight is stable. A unit of the U.S. Navy was attached to the American Embassy in Grosvenor Square, and the happy-go-lucky Brits had put them into their national basketball tournament, putting us out.

Mrs. Pigeoner

One of my daughters left a bag of wild cherries here in June, 2023, and set the clock back eighty-five years. New Jersey forest cherries, bright yellow, blushing red. The colors suggest wind-borne pollen from ornamental trees, or pits carried by birds. *Prunus avium*. Across the street and three doors down, in 1938, such a tree was in the front yard of Mrs. Pigeoner. Belial's daughter out of Evil Moon, Mrs. Pigeoner.

Her tree was rich in cherries that June, and some dropped on our stickball games among parked cars, others on the sidewalk, but most in Mrs. Pigeoner's yard. We went for those blushing cherries in Mrs. Pigeoner's yard. She came out of her house rasping. She had a broom and she chased us with it. She was an old crone. We thought she was more than a hundred years old. She may have been fifty-eight. Whatever she was, she hated kids. She glared at us on the street. And with her sharp tongue and ready broom, she kept us away from her cherries. We were seven years old.

One day, a thunderstorm broke—lightning flashes, powerful wind, and Mrs. Pigeoner’s cherry tree fell across the sidewalk, its fruited canopy in the public domain, aswarm with children, in the middle of the street. We ate up the cherries and missed them in 1939. ♦

[John McPhee](#), a staff writer since 1965, has published more than thirty books, including “[Tabula Rasa, Volume 1](#).”

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How Professional Wrestling Prepared Linda McMahon for Trump's Cabinet

The Education Secretary ran the W.W.E. for years with her husband, Vince, an unstable man who, like her new boss, has a genius for inflaming the crowd.

By [Zach Helfand](#)

April 20, 2026



A former associate said, “Her current role very much mirrors her former role—a big-personality man who believes only his opinion matters and doesn’t care about rules and wants to just steamroll, and has Linda as the implementer.” Illustration by Tim Bouckley

When Linda McMahon was building World Wrestling Entertainment into a multibillion-dollar enterprise, a colleague remembers, she confided that there were two things she'd never do: get into the ring and go into politics. Professional wrestlers have a term for anything staged or put on. They call it a "work." McMahon's husband, Vince McMahon, who exercised visionary—and dictatorial—control over the company's creative side, made it difficult to distinguish between work and reality. But Linda, who ran the business side, didn't traffic in artifice. "She was intuitive, she was respectful, she made you feel valued, she was kind," Donna Goldsmith, a former chief operating officer, told me. "That was very, very different than her husband." W.W.E. personnel told me that McMahon cultivated a maternal air. She and one wrestler used to exchange letters. She signed hers "Mom."

The W.W.E. is a soap opera staged in the ring and shown on television—like "All My Children" if all the children occasionally beat one another with metal chairs. In the late nineties, Vince built a story line around a version of himself. He played "Mr. McMahon," a billionaire owner who disdained the fans, mistreated employees, and coerced female wrestlers into sexual situations. This was ostensibly fictional. "He's the most reprehensible individual on the planet," Vince once said of the character. "Uncaring, a power monger, manipulative." He added, "It's fun, because some of it's true."

Vince wrote his and Linda's adult children, Shane and Stephanie, into the spectacle. Wrestling narratives are cheekily gonzo. There was a plot in which a wrestler named Triple H drugged Stephanie and married her inert body. (They're now married, in reality, and ran the company together.) Vince once wanted his character to impregnate Stephanie's. Stephanie nixed that one. ("Just a little too gross," she has said.) Vince then asked if he could write Shane as the father in the incest plot. By 1998, as the family drama deepened, the absence of the mother character became conspicuous. "Linda didn't want to be a TV performer," Dave Meltzer, who has reported on the company for forty years, told me. "She had to."

Eventually, Linda McMahon came to be "tombstoned" (held upside down and slammed on her head) by a wrestler named Kane, "stunned" (put in a

three-quarter facelock jawbreaker) by Stone Cold Steve Austin, sexually assaulted, cheated on, driven to seek a divorce, lusted over, and sedated. Vince tried to get Shane to slap her in a scene, but Shane refused. Stephanie slapped her, though, and she slapped Stephanie. McMahon's most memorable story arc involved Vince demanding a divorce, triggering a nervous breakdown in the ring which rendered her catatonic. For months, Vince would roll out her limp body in a wheelchair and subject her to various humiliations. The wrestler Trish Stratus, who was kissed and groped by Vince in a scene in front of a vegetative McMahon, has recalled that during rehearsal Linda asked, "If I drool, would that be more effective for my character?"

The circus atmosphere, and the experience working with a creative visionary who has authoritarian leanings, has been good preparation for politics. McMahon, who is the Secretary of Education, is one of only three members of Donald Trump's original Cabinet to survive to his second term. In the first, when Trump surrounded himself with more traditional bureaucrats, McMahon was a steady and effective leader of the Small Business Administration. This time, as Trump has assembled a Cabinet that is more openly obsequious and destructive, McMahon has played the role of a friendly grandmother wielding a hatchet.

McMahon co-chaired Trump's transition team in 2024, and, late in the process, he called her and asked what Cabinet position she might want. "I said, 'I think I would enjoy Commerce,' " she told me, during a conversation at the Department of Education headquarters. Trump wanted her to run Ed. "I said, 'Mr. President, I don't have any background in education.' He said, 'I'm not looking for an education expert.' " What he wanted was to kill the department. McMahon recounted, "He said, 'The goal is that you'll be successful when you fire yourself.' "

A former W.W.E. executive told me, "Her current role very much mirrors her former role—a big-personality man who believes only his opinion matters and doesn't care about rules and wants to just steamroll, and has Linda as the implementer." The open secret in the company was that McMahon's in-ring marriage bore certain similarities to her real one: Vince was a serial philanderer, and has been accused of assault (which he denies).

“I thought, Why is she doing this?” the executive said of McMahon’s involvement in the W.W.E. scenarios. “Isn’t this incredibly demeaning, to have this kernel of truth in your life blown up into a story in which you’re forced to participate?” McMahon likes to remind scolds that wrestling is a morality play. The cheat gets his comeuppance. Her character’s narrative culminated in 2001 at WrestleMania, the annual pay-per-view show. Vince was fighting Shane. He hauled Linda’s catatonic body into the ring, like a sort of Chekhov’s wife, to watch him pummel their child. Just as Vince was about to smash a trash can over Shane’s head, McMahon suddenly came to. The crowd went wild. She stepped forward and kicked her husband in the testicles.

McMahon attributes her ability to thrive among testosterone guzzlers to being an only child. “I was my father’s son and my mother’s daughter,” she told me. She is seventy-seven, and carries herself with a knowing authority that, together with cropped blond hair and an occasional pants suit, once put the wrestler Macho Man Randy Savage in mind of Hillary Clinton. Vince first saw her in New Bern, North Carolina, on a rare visit to church, where she sang in the choir. He was sixteen. She was thirteen. “I was the honors student and the civic leader in my hometown, and Vince was the local badass,” she has said. “There was a little bit of that bad boy aspect that I think was incredibly appealing.” Vince lived in a trailer park; his father was *AWOL*, and he has said that he was physically and sexually abused by family members. To Vince, Linda’s family represented “an Ozzie and Harriet life.” He explained, “There wasn’t screaming and beating. I wanted some of that stability and love.” They married when she was seventeen. She bought her prom dress and her wedding dress on the same day.

At East Carolina University, she studied French and planned to teach. They graduated together—he a year late, she a year early. The night before commencement, they learned that she was pregnant.



"Have you tried turning it off and leaving it off?"
Cartoon by Mick Stevens

Instead of teaching, she took a job in D.C., at the law firm Covington & Burling, where she became a paralegal on intellectual-property cases. She started at the firm six weeks after giving birth. On the drive to work each morning, she sobbed. Vince set out to start a career as a wrestling and stunt promoter. He often had big ideas and an inability to profitably pull them off. He booked Muhammad Ali for a disastrous wrestling bout in Tokyo. He arranged an Evel Knievel canyon jump, but Knievel's parachute deployed early, causing him to pathetically float to the ground; Vince lost a quarter-million dollars. In the mid-seventies, Vince drove McMahon, who was pregnant with Stephanie, to a courthouse to declare bankruptcy. On the way, their car broke down. They arrived in a tow truck. Their house was auctioned off, and their car was repossessed. They owed nearly a million dollars.

They eventually emerged from debt, and McMahon inserted herself more into Vince's business ventures. In 1979, as the author Brad Balukjian recounted in his book on wrestling, "The Six Pack," they leased the Cape Cod Coliseum, a small arena in Massachusetts, and moved into a house nearby with purple shag carpet. They hung a painting of Linda near the entrance. At the arena, McMahon made hundreds of meatballs to serve to V.I.P.s.

By then, Vince had reconciled with his biological father, a successful wrestling promoter. In 1982, he sold the McMahons his business for a million dollars. They called their company Titan Sports. (It was renamed

the World Wrestling Federation, or W.W.F., and then renamed again after a trademark dispute with the World Wildlife Fund.) McMahon initially worked as a glorified office manager. She handled travel arrangements, did the accounting, and oversaw the company magazine, writing schlocky prose under the pen name Linda Kelly. When money ran low, she stopped paying for water coolers. She had an instinct for business. Wrestlers operated as independent contractors, and this allowed the McMahons to avoid paying benefits. McMahon, who had absorbed the importance of I.P. in her legal work, recognized that there was big money in licensing rights, and wrote I.P. ownership into the wrestlers' contracts. "It is an intellectual-property company, no different than Disney," Eric Bischoff, who ran a rival wrestling outfit, told me. In 2023, the W.W.E. merged with U.F.C. in a deal that valued the company at nine billion dollars. "That's largely because of the intellectual property that they own and control," Bischoff said. "And that was Linda's vision."

A key insight of wrestling is that, as in politics, people like being angry among similarly angry people. Wrestling villains are called "heels." There have been Heil Hitler-ing Nazis and aspiring flag burners, and a heel who wore a cap and gown into the ring and recited poetry. Wrestling fans sense that they are looked down on by the cultural élites, but the art has always been appreciated by those who make their living plying the popular id. Zohran Mamdani is a fan, as were Bess Truman, J. Edgar Hoover, and George H. W. Bush. In 1957, Roland Barthes got into wrestling. "What wrestling is above all meant to portray is a purely moral concept: that of justice," he wrote. "The baser the action of the 'bastard,' the more delighted the public is by the blow which he justly receives."

Linda McMahon was indirectly responsible for wrestling's biggest transformation. Wrestlers had always operated under a code of silence, known as kayfabe, that forbade acknowledging that the entire thing was scripted. (The term is, probably incorrectly, thought to derive from a Pig Latin version of old carny slang for "be fake.") Wrestlers were expected to stay in character in public at all times. Authorities regulated wrestling as a sport; this meant taxes, regulations, and safety laws. In the mid-eighties, McMahon broke the code by lobbying state governments to instead treat it

as theatre. Its performers, she testified, were like “the circus or the Harlem Globetrotters.”

The end of kayfabe brought about a strange artistic flourishing—wrestling postmodernism. Josephine Riesman, the author of “Ringmaster,” a biography of Vince, has traced how acknowledging the pretense actually made it more difficult to distinguish truth from fiction. The filmmaker Werner Herzog stumbled upon the W.W.E. around the time of McMahon’s famous groin kick and became captivated. “I had the feeling there was a very raw form of drama emerging,” he told me. “The family saga became such a central part. I think of Vince McMahon showing up in the ring with three blondes with big breasts and taunting his wife, who is in a wheelchair, and apparently blind. And the son accusing his father not of mistreating the mother—but he wanted more money, something like this. It was phenomenal, phenomenal drama.” Artistically, Herzog compared it to early Greek tragedy. He always assumed that, as with theatre, the wife and son were “paid stooges, pretending to be the wife and son.” I told him that these were, in fact, Linda and Shane McMahon. “That makes it even more interesting!” he said. “The marketing of your family for public drama of that vulgarity, it carves into the very texture of family in a way that we have not seen before.”

A pastime of W.W.E. employees was speculating about what kept Vince and Linda together. McMahon once remarked, of her husband, “Some women say they hook their wagon to a star. I hooked mine to a rocket ship.” In the early days of the company, which was based in Connecticut, the family lived in a trailer in West Hartford. Before the first WrestleMania, in 1985, they moved into a mansion in a gated community called Conyers Farm, where they hung a giant portrait of Vince in a V-neck sweater, gazing at the horizon. Linda was the type of person to remember kids’ names and birthdays. Vince was the type to expound on his love of the word “fuck.” (“It’s not just that the word refers to my favorite thing to do.”) He carried on reckless affairs. At one point, Linda discovered that Vince was having sex with his secretary. She eventually confronted him over the cheating. He told *Playboy* in 2001 that he’d been reformed. “The sex was terrific, but from an emotional standpoint, I regret it,” he said. He claimed that he hadn’t strayed for six years.

There were darker allegations. In 1992, a former referee named Rita Chatterton said that Vince had forced her to perform oral sex in a limousine and then raped her. (He has denied this. Vince and Chatterton reached a settlement in 2023.) Most colleagues felt that McMahon stayed married in part because she didn't want to risk the company. "What kept them together? She was in love with him, but they also had the business!" Goldsmith, the former C.O.O., said. "Who are we kidding?" Vince's volatility could be both maddening and intoxicating. "Some people thought Linda was an idiot for putting up with this, and some people thought that she was just being very, very loyal," another colleague said. "She loved him because he was a force of nature."

The business also needed her. In the early nineties, the F.B.I. began investigating the company for widespread steroid use, and the government later brought charges against Vince. Linda shrewdly cleaned it up. Vince won the case at trial, though Linda was reportedly left in tears when an exchange in court revealed another Vince affair. The scandal raised her status. She was named company president. "They needed a softer public face," the former executive told me. "It's a lot harder to be brutal to Linda. She comes across as a sweet mom with a warm Southern accent. Why would you want to beat her up?"

McMahon could move in more dignified circles than her husband could. The couple threw an annual holiday party at the Conyers Farm mansion. Guests recalled mingling with Lowell Weicker, Connecticut's longtime senator and governor. (McMahon was also on lunching terms with his eventual gubernatorial successor Jodi Rell.)

Vince still exerted autocratic control. Employees avoided even sneezing in his presence. (He hated sneezes. "He doesn't like anything he can't control," Stephanie said.) Some recall him cutting down McMahon at board meetings. But it could be difficult to tell who was dominating whom. "Their relationship was much closer to mother and child," Riesman, the "Ringmaster" author, told me. "He was the idiot savant. She could be harsh but could forgive him and take him back." In 1997, McMahon was named C.E.O. The company was planning to go public, and she was better suited to deal with Wall Street. She could embody seriousness and maturity, even

while discussing the wrestling nonsense. On earnings calls, she fielded questions on such topics as the potential negative business effects of “the necrophilia story line.”

Vince’s psychosexual writing tendencies only intensified. He oversaw a story line in which Eric Bischoff—the rival executive, who later joined the W.W.E.—breaks into the family home and violently kisses Linda. “Vince wanted it to look very forceful,” Bischoff has said. The scene was shot at the mansion. Vince watched on a monitor, grinning. Bischoff found the whole situation bizarre. “Vince was fucking crazy,” he told me. “I couldn’t take it, honestly, and I’d spent many years working with crazy people.” He said he imagined that McMahon must have been thinking, “ ‘Wow, this guy’s in my house, and my husband wants him to basically assault me.’ But Linda just immediately made you feel at home. They were making lunch when I showed up, and she asked if I wanted a sandwich. You felt like you were part of the family.”

For most of Tom Cole’s adolescence, he worked for the W.W.E. as a ring boy, setting up and taking down the wrestling rings. He began when he was eleven or twelve, having been recruited by an announcer and supervisor named Mel Phillips. “My mother was an alcoholic and my father was never around,” Cole recalled, years later. “Mel was like a father figure.” Cole said that Phillips kept a black book containing the names of ring boys across the country. “Mostly it was kids with broken homes,” he explained.

In 1992, Cole, then twenty-one years old, and another ring boy told the San Diego *Union-Tribune* that Phillips had molested them. They said that he groped their feet for hours at a time. (Phillips would lock the kids into wrestling holds.) Sometimes he rubbed their feet on his penis. (Later, other ring boys alleged that Phillips had forced them into oral sex, ejaculated on them, and attempted to have penetrative sex with them; the McMahons have denied knowledge of the actions.) Cole later accused a W.W.E. executive named Pat Patterson of groping his butt, and an executive named Terry Garvin of turning on pornography and asking to perform oral sex on Cole during a work conversation.

When the story broke, the three men left the company. According to one account, the McMahons let Patterson go personally, at the mansion, and

both Vince and Linda cried. (Patterson was reinstated soon afterward.) Vince held a series of damage-control phone calls with Phil Mushnick, a sports writer with the *New York Post*. Mushnick later testified in a deposition that Vince told him, “We had known for some time that Mel had a peculiar and unnatural interest and attachment to children.” Vince said that they’d fired Phillips before, years earlier, but had subsequently rehired him “out of the goodness of our hearts.” He framed this as a joint decision: “We brought him back with the caveat that he steer clear of children.”

Cole threatened to sue the company. At a meeting with the McMahons in New York to discuss a settlement, Cole’s attorney left the room several times, leaving him alone with the McMahons. Cole recollected that Linda seemed compassionate. “I thought having her present and a mother’s instincts were invaluable,” the company’s longtime lawyer, Jerry McDevitt, later said. Cole said she told him that she believed him, and that she wanted to help. He remembered her saying, “I consider you in a sense like a son. I want to look at it that way. I want you to come to me with your problems.” Cole opened up. At a later meeting at W.W.E. headquarters, according to Cole, the McMahons sought the names of other potential accusers with whom he, along with his brother Lee, was communicating. At the McMahons’ coaxing, he gave them access to his brother’s answering machine. (Vince denies this.) His lawyer had sought a monetary settlement, but Cole, who’d left the company, said that he just wanted his job back. The McMahons agreed, and also gave him fifty thousand dollars in back pay. Linda McMahon and Cole also made a separate agreement: he’d be paid as an employee but would return to school, as McMahon wanted. “I talked to this young man as I would my son, and told him how supportive of him we would be,” she later recounted. He signed a document that she’d prepared, agreeing that his employment was contingent on his academics.

As the journalist David Bixenspan, who has reported on the ring-boy allegations, has detailed, Cole enrolled at a community college. McMahon corresponded with his professors. Cole found that he was still traumatized by the abuse and had a hard time concentrating. He asked McMahon if he could drop out and resume working for the company. She told him to stick with it. Cole stopped attending class. He failed. His transcript was sent to McMahon. “I was very disappointed in your performance,” she wrote to

him. “At this point we believe that we have done everything we can. Therefore, this letter is to advise you of your termination with Titan Sports, effective immediately.” She concluded, “The opportunity of a lifetime is a terrible thing to waste.”



Cartoon by Roz Chast

McMahon subsequently told a reporter that she didn't believe Cole had been sexually abused: “I think Tom is a very confused young man.” She said that Phillips did have a foot fetish but that she considered it an overblown joke. Cole was left deeply conflicted. He later said, of the McMahons, “There are so many people's lives that they destroyed or they had a fundamental part in destroying.” He went on, “Linda McMahon, I wish I could say she was a nice person. Sometimes she gave me that feeling and sometimes she didn't. I don't even think there's a word, how I feel. I don't know what I feel about Linda McMahon. Disappointed.” After he was fired, Cole applied for unemployment. He said that McMahon turned up at the courthouse personally to contest it.

Cole later found a good job. He got married and had three daughters. In 2010, McMahon was running for Senate. Maggie Haberman and Ben

Smith, reporting for *Politico*, contacted Cole, but he hung up on them. The next day, McDevitt, the W.W.E. lawyer, issued a statement on Cole's behalf: "I can truly say without hesitation I'm thankful for how Linda handled my situation. . . . I'm sending a check to Linda's campaign fund this evening." According to Tom's brother Lee, Cole just wanted the situation over. He had pulled his life together and didn't want to be part of a media frenzy. In 2021, Cole died by suicide. A week before, he'd texted Lee, "You need to tell my story."

When Donald Trump was a kid, his favorite wrestler was Antonino Rocca, though Trump called him Rocky Antonino, and when classmates tried to correct him he insisted that he was right. One can see why wrestling appealed to him—the crowd is everything, the rules mean nothing, and the referees are so feckless that they often get knocked out and everyone laughs. In the late eighties, Trump hosted WrestleMania IV and V at the Trump Plaza in Atlantic City. The shows bombed, but Trump enjoyed himself. The wrestler Bret Hart remembered Trump almost falling out of his chair when Hart appeared to crack his face on a metal turnbuckle. "He believed it," Hart told me. "He couldn't believe I didn't get killed."

Trump courted the McMahons. He invited them to a Rolling Stones concert, saying, as Linda has recalled, that he "wanted a chance to be with the greatest promoter in the world." For someone seeking power, as Trump was, Vince was a role model. The former executive told me a company joke about two particularly fawning, incompetent staffers: Vince kept one around "because if Vince said, 'Here's a gun, I want you to shoot that guy,' he'd do it," and the other "because if Vince gave him a gun and said, 'Go shoot yourself,' he'd do it." Lowery Woodall, a professor at Millersville University who studies wrestling, told me, "It's hard for someone who's used to any other business model to understand the power that Vince had. Trump could look at him and say, 'This is a man who has the level of power and control that I admire or aspire to.' " Vince fascinated Trump. "He's a fantastic guy—one of the best ever," Trump reflected recently. Once, there was a wrestling scene in which Vince's limousine exploded on the air. It was obviously staged, but Trump reportedly called the office to check that Vince was O.K.

In 2007, Vince cast Trump as a recurring character. Like the McMahons, he played a version of himself. Vince laid on the flattery. He wrote the Trump character as Mr. McMahon's foil: the defender of the fans, who was even richer than Vince. Their ongoing feud was called the Battle of the Billionaires, even though it's unclear if there was even one billionaire between them at the time. Each man staked a wrestler, and the winner would shave the loser's hair. Trump was supposed to be the good guy, but, even after the W.W.E. arranged for money to fall from the rafters when he appeared, the fans were slow to take to him.

The Battle of the Billionaires concluded at that year's WrestleMania and got great ratings. (Trump won, and sheared Vince.) The night netted the men five million dollars. Each pledged his share to charity. Neither gave details on the donations, but the McMahons made contributions totalling five million dollars to one charitable organization: the Donald J. Trump Foundation. In 2013, the McMahons inducted Trump into the W.W.E.'s hall of fame. In a speech, Vince said, "When you think about it, second only to me, Donald might very well be a great President."

Other politicians have courted the wrestling vote. The W.W.E. has aired promos from Hillary Clinton ("When it comes to standing up for the American people . . . I am ready to rumble") and Barack Obama ("Do you smell what Barack is cooking?"). But Trump actually appreciated the form. "He fully understood the story-line development," McMahon told me. "He found incredibly intriguing the interaction with the audience. The audience knew exactly when to boo the bad guy, when to cheer for the good guy." Sam Nunberg, an early campaign aide, met Trump at a wrestling match. "He loved the sensationalism, the drama, the fantasy," Nunberg has recalled. "I would say to him, 'We're going to be the W.W.E. of the primary.' "

By the time Trump ran for President, in 2016, Linda McMahon was a powerful conservative donor. She had run for Senate twice, in 2010 and 2012, as a moderate blue-state Republican. (She had opposed the elimination of the Department of Education—an idea that she called radical.) She was a tireless retail campaigner. "She went to the towns with ten people," the manager of an opposing campaign told me. "There's a

political animal in her that loves this stuff.” Chris Shays, who lost to her in the 2012 Republican primary, was less impressed by her grasp of policy. “She was just as ignorant as in the first campaign,” he told me. “She hadn’t learned, and she hadn’t cared to learn. She wasn’t interested in the issues. She just appeared to be interested in the office.”

McMahon spent almost fifty million dollars on each campaign—a record at the time. She was still married to Vince, and they kept up appearances as a couple, but they were no longer living together. On the eve of the 2010 Senate election, Vince ran a W.W.E. scene that opened with him in a coma. When a doctor at his bedside mentioned McMahon’s campaign spending, Vince suddenly awoke: “Fifty million dollars on *what?*” She lost both races by twelve points. A person who helped manage an opposing campaign told me that in some ways McMahon’s investment paid off. Spending that much on identical double-digit losses signalled a commitment to the G.O.P. cause and an abundance of capital. “What would a hundred million be for us? Like a thousand dollars?” the person said. “Afterward, she was highly sought by Republicans.” In 2016, McMahon criticized certain Trump campaign tactics. “Some of the comments that have been made, I think, are quite deplorable,” she said. But she knew a rocket ship when she saw one. “Something about her views an unstable and monomaniacal man as a useful tool,” Riesman, the Vince McMahon biographer, told me. “I don’t think she sees herself as submissive to these men.” By the election, she’d become one of Trump’s biggest donors.

As McMahon ascended in Washington, Vince remained in Connecticut. In 2024, a former W.W.E. employee named Janel Grant sued him, claiming that he had pressured her into a three-year sexual relationship. At various points, she alleged, he injured her with dildos that he named after male W.W.E. wrestlers and sent her messages including “I will rape U.” In one instance, she said, she was coerced into having sex with Vince and another executive, while Vince defecated on her. In another instance, she begged the men to stop assaulting her, but Vince told her, “No means yes.” According to Grant, Vince distanced himself from her only when Linda McMahon found out about the relationship; Vince told Grant that, if it became public, McMahon would divorce him. (Both Vince and the other executive have denied the accusations. A lawyer for Vince said, “Janel Grant’s claims may

be designed to grab headlines but they are factually unfounded and legally deficient.”) The *Wall Street Journal* found that Vince paid at least twelve million dollars in hush money to women over a sixteen-year period, including when Linda McMahon was the C.E.O. In 2024, Vince left the company, and McMahon, through her attorney, said for the first time that she and Vince were separated, though they have not officially divorced.

Max Stier, who runs the nonpartisan Partnership for Public Service, said that during Trump’s first term people sometimes asked him if Trump had a single good Cabinet secretary. He’d point to McMahon. At the S.B.A., she earned a reputation as a skilled manager of talent. Robb Wong, who worked at the agency under six administrators, told me, “We made bigger, better strides under her than under any other leadership. She was the greatest boss I’ve ever had.”

When it became clear that Trump had lost the 2020 election, McMahon, along with two high-ranking White House staffers, Brooke Rollins and Larry Kudlow, arranged an Oval Office meeting with him. They wanted his blessing to start a think tank to carry on his agenda, but they were vague on what it should accomplish. “I’m not even sure there were specifics,” Kudlow told me. Other efforts to intellectualize the Trump movement have run into problems, in part because one of Trump’s political skills is a certain strategic flexibility. But McMahon was not interested in publishing white papers. “I’m not a policy wonk,” she told me. She considers herself an executor. She told Rollins that their idea couldn’t be just a think tank. “It had to be a ‘do’ tank,” she said. They called it the America First Policy Institute.

The A.F.P.I. laid the groundwork for a second Trump Administration. McMahon and Rollins hired more than a hundred and fifty staffers. They drafted hundreds of executive orders for Trump to sign should he regain office. Quietly, they challenged the influential Heritage Foundation when it came to maneuvering to staff a second Trump Administration. The groups pushed similar policy. Heritage had Project 2025; the A.F.P.I. had a similar, though less specific, blueprint. “The efforts were really complementary,” one person who worked at the A.F.P.I. told me. But the A.F.P.I. played a savvier political game. Heritage’s leader, Kevin Roberts, made himself a

central part of the Presidential campaign, and Project 2025 became electorally toxic. Trump was forced to denounce it. McMahon had a career's worth of lessons in the virtues of bombast, and also in the dangers of it. "We didn't think publicity would help arrive at a better project," the A.F.P.I. veteran told me.

Trump believes that working on a transition before an election is bad luck. When he won, the A.F.P.I. had already assembled an Administration-in-waiting, one that didn't have Project 2025's baggage. In Trump's first year, Heritage and Project 2025 still exerted a major influence, but the implementers tended to be alumni from the A.F.P.I.: Kash Patel, Kevin Hassett, Pam Bondi. Seven Cabinet secretaries came from the think tank. More than eighty A.F.P.I. staffers, about half the organization, went into the Administration. (Last year, RealClearPolitics found that, of a hundred and ninety-six policies drafted by the A.F.P.I., more than a hundred and fifty were advanced or enacted in Trump's first hundred days.)

At the institute, McMahon ceded policy to others. Before launching the group, she and Rollins visited Texas to enlist the billionaire oilman Tim Dunn as a founder. Dunn isn't well known nationally, but he is the most powerful man in Texas; in 2023, *ProPublica* reported, two-thirds of all campaign donations to the state Republican Party came from his political organizations. Dunn has expressed the view that Christians should dominate society. Texas's first Jewish Speaker of the House has said that, in a private meeting, Dunn told him that only Christians should hold leadership positions. (Dunn has denied this.) For years, his main political project was legislation that siphoned public-education funds to private schools via vouchers. "I call him a theo-oligarch," Glenn Rogers, a former Republican state representative, told me. Rogers is deeply conservative, but, like many rural Republicans, he was a public-education supporter. Dunn targeted him, and in 2024 he lost his seat. "He desires to eliminate public education and replace it with a private-education system that uses his version of the Christian religion," Rogers said. (Dunn did not respond to a request for comment.)

Dunn wielded his influence through a think tank called the Texas Public Policy Foundation. For years, its president was Rollins. Kel Seliger, a

Republican legislator who represented Dunn's district, told me that Dunn was using the A.F.P.I. to duplicate the model nationally. "It is a right-wing political organization designed to fulfill the goals of certain very wealthy people," Seliger told me. "That doesn't make it a think tank. When the thinking can be fairly extreme and only in one direction, that's not a lot of thinking."



"There's nothing to be scared of—your mom and I are right down the hall in separate rooms and I might actually be going to a bar."

Cartoon by Zachary Kanin

When McMahon took over the Department of Education, she staffed it with A.F.P.I. people. "A.F.P.I. dominates education policy in the federal government," Jim Blew, a founder of the Defense of Freedom Institute, who helped prepare McMahon for her confirmation hearing last February, told me. The think tank had successfully operationalized a second Trump Presidency; it's unclear what will happen to it when he leaves office. "A very open question is if they're even around in three years," Blew said. "It may be that it continues, but I don't know."

The Department of Education exists, to a large extent, to distribute education funds authorized by Congress. Conservatives, who prefer that the money flow directly to states, have always hated it. "Eliminating it has been a conservative goal since it was created," Lindsey Burke, the author of Project 2025's chapter on education, told me. For Republican Presidents, this has mostly been rhetoric. Ronald Reagan campaigned on killing the department, but he left it intact. Blew, who was an Assistant Secretary at Ed under Betsy DeVos, said that two recent moves, by Obama and Joe Biden, changed the calculus. The first was Ed's reinterpretation of Title IX rules,

which mandated that universities hold students accused of sexual assault as culpable if it was more likely than not they'd committed the act, and broadened the definition of gender-based discrimination to include transgender students. The second was the cancellation of student debt, which was seen as a giveaway to young liberals. Blew said that there has always been an argument for eliminating the department on efficiency grounds: "Why do we need so many people working in this department when all they're doing is sending money?" Now, he told me, there's a more important objective. "I don't know how to articulate this, but a lot more of it is about power," he said.

During McMahon's confirmation hearing, she found herself in the odd position of persuading senators to approve her to lead a department that she pledged to destroy, while assuring them that the authority to do so was not hers but theirs. "The whole hearing right now feels kind of surreal to me—it's almost like we're being subjected to a very elegant gaslighting," Senator Maggie Hassan said at the time. When McMahon was asked whether schools that taught Black-history classes were in violation of an anti-D.E.I. executive order, she responded, "I'm not quite certain." At the hearing, she was flanked by her kids and by two parents'-rights activists. One of them, Tiffany Justice, a founder of Moms for Liberty, was recently asked by *ProPublica* how many children she imagined attending public school in the future; she responded, "I hope zero." McMahon watched her confirmation vote from the Ed building, in the Secretary's office. Three hours and one minute later, she sent an e-mail to the whole staff with the subject line "Our Department's Final Mission." She wrote, "This is our opportunity to perform one final, unforgettable public service to future generations of students." Less than a week later, half the department had received layoff notices.

McMahon told me that, a few weeks into Trump's second term, he called her to complain about the latest national reading and math scores. The test results, part of an assessment called the Nation's Report Card, have stagnated since the pandemic. "It's embarrassing," Trump told her. He tasked her with finding out why. The slump could have a variety of causes, including smartphones in classrooms and *COVID*. But McMahon and Trump both immediately cited the low scores as the reason the department

needs to go. It may be difficult to determine, using their own metric, if their overhaul succeeds. In February, the department's Institute of Education Sciences, which administers the assessments, was gutted by Elon Musk's Department of Government Efficiency. *DOGE* cut the I.E.S. staff by ninety per cent.

Education veterans told me that the department certainly has bloat and inefficiencies. Many complained about time-wasting technology platforms. The department maintains a library that gets no visitors most weeks. A personal trainer was reportedly paid a quarter-million dollars a year. But some conservatives were dismayed by the wanton destruction of I.E.S., which has a budget of less than a billion dollars. "The cuts were so ham-handed and so blunt," Frederick Hess, a senior fellow at the American Enterprise Institute, told me. "The Nation's Report Card is hugely cost-effective. You save almost nothing by cutting these kinds of statistical enterprises, and you threaten to do a lot of collateral damage."

DOGE did McMahon the favor of swinging the first sledgehammer. "Betsy DeVos, rhetorically, was more ardent about blowing up the department," Hess said. "But suddenly *DOGE* took a wrench and just started breaking a whole lot of stuff, and it created an entirely different environment for McMahon to operate in." The Education Department is the smallest Cabinet agency by number of staff. When Trump's term began, the agency employed about four thousand people, a tenth of a per cent of the civil workforce. McMahon's layoffs eliminated entire offices. Dozens of employees were fired for attending a 2017 diversity training that had been approved by DeVos. The department has encountered legal challenges to the firings. It has also asked some employees to return from administrative leave, seemingly after it was unable to perform critical functions. One employee I talked to had been laid off and brought back twice. After the second time, the employee received a letter in the mail saying that the original layoff had been rescinded: "And then forty-eight hours after that they sent us an e-mail saying, basically, 'Just kidding, we're rescinding the recision.' " The employee was on paid leave for most of the past year. In 2025, the department spent about thirty million dollars paying people not to work.

Alongside the lack of personnel, some vital functions have slowed to a crawl. “The cuts are devastating in a way that’s hard to fully encapsulate,” Rachel Gittleman, the president of the union representing the department’s employees, told me. “We were already operating on a shoestring budget.” Layoffs slashed offices that dealt with English-language acquisition and those that worked with poor, minority, and rural districts. “Part of the reason why there’s such a big target on our backs is who we serve, and who we serve are the people and locations that have historically been left out of mainstream education,” Gittleman said. The agency has reportedly cancelled or delayed more than a billion dollars of grants for programs like school desegregation and disability services. Miguel Cardona, the Education Secretary under Biden, told me, “They’re hurting the students who relied most on this Administration to improve things. The rural communities and the red states are being impacted more so than even the blue states.” But many people on the right were giddy. “I don’t even know that we anticipated it would go as fast as it has,” Erika Donalds, who runs education policy for the A.F.P.I., said. “I mean, less than a week after Linda McMahon was confirmed, half the department was gone. She doesn’t play around, obviously.”

One of the hardest-hit arms of Ed was the Federal Student Aid office, which administers \$1.7 trillion of loans. In the last quarter of 2025, a million people defaulted on their student loans. Colleges have reported issues accessing essential loan-servicing platforms and getting in touch with the F.S.A. Some people with student debt have been unable to make qualifying payments, because of technical problems. An attorney told me that she’s had clients who have permanent disabilities, and are entitled to have their loans cancelled with proper medical documentation. “You send in a doctor’s note, they don’t look at it, and then it gets voided because they waited too long and your doctor’s note is out of date,” the attorney said. “It’s either nefarious bad-faith practices or just complete idiocy.”

Max Stier, of the Partnership for Public Service, has been struck by McMahon’s metamorphosis. “The Linda McMahon of 2017, at least as I personally heard her, would not have bought into the idea that the way you improve the situation is you destroy your own workforce,” he told me. “Any competent leader would see that as insane.” He credited the flip to

Trump's changing priorities. "In Trump One, they didn't understand the processes of government," he said. "In Trump Two, they have disdained and destroyed those processes." McMahon is one of only a few who have thrived in both Administrations—likely because of her ability to execute on both visions.

Of course, with Trump, the priority is often theatre. McMahon is familiar with organizations built around an increasingly unstable man who is a genius at spinning story lines that inflame the crowd and damage enemies and institutions but, if you think too hard about them, don't necessarily add up to a coherent narrative. Trump has issued an executive order calling on McMahon to kill the Education Department, but doing so requires sixty votes in the Senate—for now, an impossibility. Observers have put forth several explanations for her approach. One is that she is a loyal soldier; another is that she's just an optimist. Inside her office, she displays a glass tumbler inscribed with the words "Shut It Down." Lindsey Burke, the Project 2025 author, who is now McMahon's deputy chief of staff, told me, "If you're ever in a meeting with her and you say, 'If we shut down the department,' she'll interrupt and say, 'Not if—when.' She believes it." (When I expressed skepticism, McMahon told me, "I fully do expect this to be successful.") Cardona said that harming public education could open the door to increased privatization; McMahon successfully pushed to pass a federal tax credit, similar to the voucher system in Texas. Others have noted that, if McMahon can't kill the department, vandalizing it would still be useful. A congressional aide who works on education told me, "It's like she's orchestrating a crisis so that they can say, 'Look, we have to get rid of the financial-aid office. It's broken. It doesn't work.' Well, they broke it. It worked." Hess, of the American Enterprise Institute, thinks that McMahon hopes to neuter the department for any future Democratic President. "It's like bombing the Iranian nuclear program last summer," he told me in January. "It sets them back three years, four years. The next Democratic Administration would have to spend significant time and energy rebuilding."

McMahon acknowledges that she was never an education expert, and those who work with her say that she's an eager student. Still, it's difficult not to attribute at least some of Ed's chaos to a Secretary deciding to dismantle a

department before she fully understands how it functions. At times, she comes across as a skilled administrator whose subject-specific knowledge is cobbled together or incoherent. “She doesn’t know anything about things like student loans, so she flubs a lot,” a former F.S.A. staffer said. On Fox News, she once forgot the name of the law for students with disabilities. In April, at a summit on educational innovation, she repeatedly referred to A.I.—as in artificial intelligence—as “A1.” (“A school system that’s going to start making sure that first graders, or even pre-Ks, have A1 teaching in every year, that’s a wonderful thing!”) In September, while attempting to explain how a federal ban on D.E.I. programs squared with her view that curricula should be set locally, she swerved into a discussion of combatting racism. “We do that so well on a local level without it being mandated and ruled,” she said.

In late 2024, Max Eden, a former member of the Trump White House, proposed a higher-education agenda for McMahon. The Gaza protests had been galvanizing for Republicans, who, even before October 7th, had viewed universities as captured by radical thinking on race and politics, rife with grade inflation, and intolerant of conservatives. “To scare universities straight, McMahon should start by taking a prize scalp,” Eden wrote. “She should simply destroy Columbia University.” Eden outlined how, by crippling universities over charges of antisemitism, McMahon could also achieve larger goals. “If you can’t get the Republican votes to shut down the department, make the Democrats resent it so much they want to shut it down, too,” he explained later.

The main driver of the Administration’s battle with universities has been the new Joint Task Force to Combat Antisemitism. It has had Cabinet-level members, including Bondi, Robert F. Kennedy, Jr., and McMahon. Early on, the task force met every week. It has focussed most zealously on Ivy League schools. In April, the *Times* reported, Trump raised the idea of cancelling Harvard’s federal grants, which add up to about nine billion dollars. “What if we never pay them?” Trump said. “Wouldn’t that be cool?”

McMahon has an ability to bluster transparently while keeping a straight face, and this has been useful during negotiations. In May, she wrote a letter

to Harvard that had such distinctive locutions (a math program was “embarrassing,” a plagiarism accusation “humiliating”) and unorthodox capitalization (“why is there so much HATE?”) that there was widespread speculation it had been written specifically for, or perhaps by, Trump. But McMahon can also speak reasonably with college presidents. A member of the task force told me that McMahon comes in when negotiations reach an impasse. May Mailman, who last year coordinated the White House’s higher-education policy as a deputy for Stephen Miller, told me that McMahon made a different impression from other, more fervent Administration figures. “She’s a friendly, sociable, normal person,” Mailman said. “We’ve got so many bad cops in this Administration that even a firm hand gets to be the good cop.”

Mailman said that McMahon valued higher education. “She doesn’t want to necessarily destroy institutions,” Mailman said. “There are probably people in this Administration who would just straight up say we’re interested in shutting down Columbia. I don’t think Secretary McMahon is saying she’s *not* in favor of that. It’s more ‘Choose your own adventure, Columbia.’ ”

McMahon’s approach to antisemitism differed sharply from those of past Administrations. Traditionally, discrimination investigations have been the purview of Ed’s Office for Civil Rights. The O.C.R. was not always unpopular on the right; it was once led by Clarence Thomas. But many conservatives saw an overreach in the Title IX changes of the Obama and Biden eras. McMahon’s cuts decimated the O.C.R. Of its five hundred and seventy-five employees, only sixty did not receive layoff notices; most are either gone or are on leave. Seven of twelve regional offices were shut down. “It seemed designed to do maximum damage,” a high-ranking former O.C.R. official told me. “They went after some of the largest, most productive offices with the most expertise on antisemitism.” When the Chicago office, which had about fifty lawyers, was closed, all of its cases, totalling in the thousands, were assigned to a single lawyer in Denver. The office already had a backlog, which has now grown to about twenty-five thousand cases. Many involve access problems for, or harassment of, students with disabilities. Ninety per cent of the seven thousand cases that the O.C.R. “resolved” between March and September of last year were

dismissed, an increase from an average of seventy or eighty per cent under Biden.

A few varieties of cases have seen an uptick in resolutions: there have been thirty-one settlements for anti-white and anti-Asian discrimination, and four for allowing transgender athletes to compete in sports. Meanwhile, McMahon's department has resolved no cases of sexual harassment or assault. "It would be noteworthy if a single office didn't resolve one in a year, much less the entire agency," the high-ranking former O.C.R. official said. Beth Gellman-Beer, who ran the Philadelphia office, told me, "You have, what, nine transgender athletes countrywide?" (The N.C.A.A.'s president said a year ago that there were fewer than ten.) "And the Administration says the reason they're focussing on this issue is the safety of women. But if they're really concerned about women's safety, why are they not processing sexual-harassment cases?"

The O.C.R. layoffs cleared out many of the most experienced investigators of antisemitism. The void was filled by the antisemitism task force. In its major settlements with universities, the Administration has shortened the investigation stage and pushed for broad, often unrelated remedies. The task force overrode a settlement that the O.C.R. had reached with Brown University over alleged incidents of antisemitism, and instead withheld federal funding until Brown agreed to increase teaching and research about Israel—"The remedies are constantly conflating Israel and Judaism," the former O.C.R. official said—and pay fifty million dollars to workforce-development organizations. "That's perfectly great and admirable, but it's got nothing on God's green earth to do with antisemitism," the official said. Gellman-Beer said that the skeleton staff at O.C.R. likely wouldn't have the capacity to monitor whether universities are complying with existing settlements. "Some of those were the worst cases I'd ever seen in my career," Gellman-Beer told me. "In antisemitism cases where we found horrendous violations, we suspect that nobody's monitoring it."



*"I just said hi to be polite, Ethan."
Cartoon by Carolita Johnson*

The antisemitism task force has had headline wins. It has initiated three antisemitism settlements, with Northwestern, Brown, and Columbia. But the O.C.R. has settled none. (In Biden's final year, there were some two dozen settlements.) At times, it can appear that the task force is most interested in other issues. Its leader, Leo Terrell, a Baptist civil-rights lawyer—who once shared a post on Twitter from a former leader of a white-supremacist group asserting Trump's ability to revoke Senator Chuck Schumer's "Jew card"—has promised, "We're gonna bankrupt these universities." The task force has about twenty people. The White House has released the names of only about half the members, and just one is Jewish. When I asked the member if there were other Jews on the task force, the person could not say for sure. "Honestly, I just don't know the religion of every member," the person said. Gellman-Beer told me, "It feels like 'The Wizard of Oz.' You pull back the curtain and nothing's there. It's all bluster. And I don't disagree with the Administration when they say antisemitism on campus is a problem. I think it's a huge problem. I just think they're doing a huge disservice to Jewish students."

One of McMahon's deputies said that the legal challenges to the layoffs had frozen the O.C.R. for longer than anticipated. McMahon told me, "We do need to hire and bring back some lawyers." She envisioned that, after the final mission, the Department of Justice could potentially handle school-discrimination cases. "I have no worries about that whatsoever," she said. But the former high-ranking O.C.R. official said that this shows a misunderstanding of how the two agencies work. "The D.O.J. decides

which case is going to advance the law or set precedent,” the official said. “They litigate a handful of cases in the civil-rights education section.” The O.C.R. is required by law to address every complaint it receives. “There’s no picking and choosing. Every desperate mother who comes to us gets help. So it’s really apples and oranges, even though it seems on its face to make sense. It’s just that Linda McMahon has no idea what she’s talking about.” (Asked for comment, Madi Biedermann, a department spokesperson, said that my general characterization of McMahon was “built on anonymous smears and recycled secondhand gossip.”)

In September, McMahon convened an all-staff meeting to begin implementing the department’s dissolution. Her strategy involved a series of what are called I.A.A.s, or interagency agreements—deals to move entire offices to other Cabinet departments. “It’s really operating like a merger,” McMahon told me. “It’s not just ramming something somewhere. It’s very thoughtful.” The moves are technically provisional; only Congress can make them permanent. “We’re doing it piecemeal and as a proof of concept,” she said.

During the meeting, McMahon announced some of the offices that were moving, and where they were headed. “Interspersed were these rambling stories,” someone who attended told me. Elementary education would move to the Department of Labor, she said, and she talked about visiting an elementary school where a class used virtual-reality goggles to climb an A.I. Mt. Everest. “The pinnacle of the story was one of the students falling off of Mt. Everest and dying,” the attendee said. “I guess the takeaway was that technology in schools is good.”

The I.A.A. strategy was laid out at length in Project 2025. “It’s the highlight of my career to work on this,” Burke, the author and deputy chief of staff, told me. She said that she was motivated by bureaucratic waste, liberal overreach, and poor test results. “We’ve spent three trillion dollars since the department became operational, and, to quote Karoline Leavitt, kids can’t read or do math,” she said. The department claims that forty-seven cents of every federal dollar given to states is wasted on regulatory compliance, and Burke and McMahon plan to release more federal money as direct block grants to states, rather than filtering it through Ed. But Balkanizing the

department won't eliminate much red tape. Margaret Spellings, the Secretary of Education under George W. Bush, has said that it would "make it much more complicated for states." Federal education funds, by law, come with mandates and restrictions. A central idea for the department is that it's more efficient for one agency to insure compliance than to foist the responsibility on fifty states individually. Cardona explained, "Sending it back to the states sounds nice, until it costs more taxpayer money at the local level to do what the federal level could have done."

McMahon said she hopes the I.A.A.s will convince Congress that the department's breakup is feasible. She said that she was "very closely in touch" with the Senate's Health, Education, Labor, and Pensions Committee about the implementation. But McMahon has not responded to calls from members of the committee to testify about the moves.

So far, the department has announced ten interagency agreements. Each has its own challenges. The staffer who worked in Federal Student Aid, which is being moved to Treasury, told me, "The data is such a hot mess, and it's such a privacy disaster. How do you move forty million subprime loans with records quite literally in bunkers in Nebraska on microfiche?" The agency has floated the idea of transitioning special-education services to Health and Human Services—the department, McMahon pointed out, that oversaw special education before Ed existed. Nicole Neily, the founder of Parents Defending Education, who sat with McMahon's family at her confirmation hearing, told me, "We are hearing concerns from families who have special-needs children: Will their needs be met? Will this be more complicated?"

The first office transfers were to the Department of Labor. Burke told me that the moves have been effective. "Money has gone out the door on time," she said. But at least one grant program has been delayed, in part because of problems with Labor's technology systems. Staffers have described their days as a dark bureaucratic comedy. Colleagues who work together at Labor are now spread across five different areas. There are dead mice on the floor. Initially, many couldn't access Labor's network. They had to pester colleagues whenever they needed something printed. One person told me about staffers at one Labor office asking "if there's any benefit to their

working conditions, to their jobs, to their work streams, any benefit at all. Literally, all they could come up with was the cafeteria.” Education couldn’t secure parking for all staffers at Labor, so the department paid for a special shuttle to ferry them across the National Mall. Burke told me, “There are things like that where we are coming up with solutions where there are—I wouldn’t even say problems, but where there are day-to-day changes. We are only about a half a mile from the Department of Labor, so it’s pretty close!” The shuttle started out as a standard bus, but hardly anyone used it. The department replaced it with a light-blue Mustang.

McMahon often speaks about her legacy. She reminds staffers that hers will be the department’s closure. She told me that another part of her legacy will be touring the country to leave behind a “tool kit of best practices for states,” a kind of goodbye gift from Ed. On another occasion, she has spoken about her legacy being literacy; she has promoted programs of science-based reading that have produced surprising turnarounds in states like Mississippi. But her goals sometimes come into conflict. Much of the research behind science-based literacy was coordinated by I.E.S., the office that was gutted last year.

McMahon told me that another priority is patriotic education. She was distressed by polls showing that a majority of young people say they don’t love their country. She favors telling America’s history “warts and all,” but said that kids should come away feeling proud to be American. “Are we perfect yet? No,” she said. “Are we the best in the world? Yes.” She has been travelling across the country on what she called the “History Rocks!” tour to promote patriotic curricula. I recently accompanied her on a visit to the Chicago Hope Academy, a Christian private school.

She sat in on a class learning about Ida B. Wells and Jacob Riis, and brought a wall-size replica of the Declaration of Independence for the students to sign. In the hallway, a few kids whispered to her that they’ve been watching wrestling their whole lives. McMahon is no longer involved with W.W.E. Though Shane was once seen as the heir apparent, Vince ultimately designated Stephanie and her husband, Paul Levesque, the wrestler known as Triple H, as his successors. Vince has retreated from the public. He is occasionally rumored to plot a comeback, or a new wrestling

venture with Saudi backing. Last year, he was involved in a police chase that ended when he crashed his Bentley into another car at a hundred miles an hour. (He was cited for reckless driving and entered a pretrial diversion program.) A couple of months later, he threw himself an eightieth-birthday party at Gotham Hall, in midtown Manhattan. Attendees were required to surrender their phones. As a party favor, he gave everyone a bust of his own head.

After touring the school, McMahon led an assembly centered on American-history trivia. (Q: What treaty ended the French and Indian War and transferred control of Illinois to Britain? A: The 1763 Treaty of Paris.) It was strange to think that a future history lesson might include some W.W.E. factoids: Trump, McMahon, Jesse (the Body) Ventura. The Rock is always rumored as a Presidential aspirant, and Kane, who “tombstoned” McMahon, is now the mayor of Knox County, Tennessee. McMahon has pointed out that America’s wrestling fascination isn’t new—Abraham Lincoln was an accomplished free-for-all wrestler. The students, who were mostly Black and brown, many from poor families, all seemed excited to have her there. As propaganda goes, the patriotic programming was benign. It would not have seemed abnormal had it been led by another Education Secretary and not the purported final one.

After a couple of hours, McMahon got ready to leave to visit another Chicago school, this time with Erika Kirk. Before she left, I asked her if she saw any contradiction between the event and what she called Ed’s final mission. Did using the weight of the department to push a project she cared about make an argument for the utility of the department? “I don’t think so,” she said. “You would have another agency secretary who might come do it. There are always other dignitaries.” ♦

An earlier version of this article misstated the year of Donald Trump’s first Presidential campaign.

[Zach Helfand](#) is a staff writer at *The New Yorker*.

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[Onward and Upward with the Arts](#)

The Action-Film Director Who's Taking On Michael Jackson

Antoine Fuqua has built a career on movies with irresistible heroes. Now he's telling the story of the King of Pop.

By [Kelefa Sanneh](#)

April 20, 2026



Fuqua's new film is a calculated risk. "The only way you're going to change anything—you've got to win," he says. Photograph by Ramona Rosales for The New Yorker

At an early screening of "Michael," the new bio-pic based on the life of Michael Jackson, there was silence for a moment after the credits rolled, and then someone exclaimed, "That was fucking awesome!" It was a good omen, although in fairness this was not an unbiased audience. A couple of dozen people had gathered at a sound stage on the Universal Studios lot, in California, for some last-minute trouble-shooting, and so everyone in the room was invested in the film's success.

“Michael” was designed to be an international crowd-pleaser—the kind of film that executives hope will drag audiences away from their small screens and deposit them in front of big ones, where they can watch and sing along and even dance, if theatres permit it. There was no dancing on this night, unless you counted the projected receipts waltzing through the minds of the people involved. The movie’s lead producer is Graham King, an Englishman who also produced “Bohemian Rhapsody,” about the rock band Queen, which made more than nine hundred million dollars at the box office upon its release, in 2018. King has been working ever since then to bring a Michael Jackson film to theatres, and now only technicalities remained. He suggested that the crowd noise be increased during one of the concert scenes. (The movie has lots of concert scenes.) “Those of us that have been lucky enough to be at a Michael concert, it was fucking chaos,” he said. “You want to *feel* that.”

One of the people listening was an imposing but soft-spoken guy dressed in black, with a baseball cap nearly covering his eyes. His name is Antoine Fuqua, and for the past few decades he has been among Hollywood’s most successful directors, if not its most celebrated ones. Fuqua is known for films about tough guys on tough missions—especially “Training Day,” the 2001 movie he made with Ethan Hawke and Denzel Washington, who played a cop so deliciously crooked that audiences almost forgot to root against him. Fuqua’s filmography also includes “Olympus Has Fallen,” about terrorists attacking the White House, and the “Equalizer” trilogy, in which Washington plays an avenging angel who finds good reasons to do bad things, such as dispatching an enemy by shooting him through a different enemy’s eye socket.

Fuqua likes to say that he specializes in stories about “men under pressure,” and in this sense, at least, “Michael” represents a logical continuation of his life’s work. In other ways, it is a departure: a film built not around gunfights and chases but around re-creations of musical performances. At the Universal Studios screening, Fuqua mentioned some moments when he wanted the music to fade away, the way old Motown songs often did, leaving listeners wanting more. (His older cousin Harvey was a doo-wop singer who became an executive at Motown Records.) But many of his suggestions were subtler: he wanted to make sure that a scene in a New

York office had enough New York sounds in the background, and he worried that a few moments of automated dialogue replacement—where actors re-record their lines in a studio—didn't quite fit the tone. Mainly, though, he seemed happy. "It's awesome, man," he said quietly. "I enjoyed it."



In the new film, Jackson is played by his nephew Jaafar, with a faintly familiar smile and highly familiar dance moves. Photograph by Glen Wilson / Lionsgate

Fuqua's low-key approach is both a natural expression of his personality and a shrewd stratagem to reassure people around him that everything is under control. Fuqua is in many ways a Hollywood outsider: a Black man from Pittsburgh who honed his skills by shooting music videos and commercials in the nineteen-nineties. Yet something about his manner seems to put people at ease. This is an important skill for anyone who, like Fuqua, aims to make big and broadly entertaining films, and therefore needs to persuade executives to fund them and stars to appear in them. "Slow is smooth and smooth is fast," Fuqua likes to say, echoing both an old military adage and a line delivered by Mark Wahlberg as an extraordinarily accurate assassin in Fuqua's film "Shooter."

"Michael," which was made in coöperation with Jackson's estate, has an enormous built-in audience, although it also carries significant risk. Jackson died in 2009, and by the end of his life he was a notorious figure: by his own admission, he had close and sometimes physically affectionate relationships with teen-age and pre-teen-age boys, some of whom accused him of sexual assault, which he denied.

In discussions of people like Michael Jackson, some defenders insist on distinguishing between the artist and the art, but a bio-pic is necessarily about both. Jackson's sublime pop-soul confections—"Billie Jean," "Rock with You," and countless others—remain extraordinarily popular, and the people with the strongest attachment to this music tend to share an attachment to its creator. "Michael" is not an ambivalent meditation on the complicated relationship between goodness and greatness but an unabashed celebration of its subject, based on the bet that, a decade and a half after Jackson's death, audiences are ready to celebrate him, too.

This past November, when the trailer for "Michael" was released on YouTube, it was viewed more than a hundred million times in the first twenty-four hours—a promising sign for Lionsgate, which, with other companies, has invested something like a hundred and fifty million dollars in the film. The title role is played by Jaafar Jackson, the son of Michael's brother Jermaine, with a shy smile that's faintly familiar and frenetic dance moves that are strongly familiar. But, to the extent that "Michael" is about a man under pressure, that man is Joe Jackson, the star's domineering father, played by Colman Domingo with an intensity that would not be out of place in one of Fuqua's more combat-driven films.

In his career, Fuqua has worked to make himself difficult to categorize; not long after the success of "Training Day," he went to Ireland to film "King Arthur," a battlefield epic starring Clive Owen and Keira Knightley. His goal, often, has been to give audiences movies that feel like thrill rides, but nowadays he talks more about the responsibility to tell stories about Black people in particular. He fought hard to make "Emancipation," a 2022 slavery drama starring Will Smith. And he tends to describe "Michael" less as a potential blockbuster than as an act of historical reclamation. "Michael's too important a character for our culture to just walk away from," he told me.

Fuqua's résumé includes seventeen features and half a dozen documentaries, along with film and television projects for which he served as producer or executive producer. ("The Terminal List," in which Chris Pratt plays a renegade Navy *SEAL*, will release its second season on Prime Video later this year.) But he has never been nominated for a major award,

and, though he lives outside Los Angeles, he is much more comfortable working out at his local boxing gym than appearing at industry events. Still, his profession occasionally requires self-promotion, which is how he found himself walking through Park City, Utah, on a bright January morning, heading to a promotional panel at the Sundance Film Festival. Fuqua is tall and broad and looks like a former football player, although in fact his sport of choice was basketball: he earned a scholarship to West Virginia State, a historically Black college, and then transferred to West Virginia University.

When Fuqua arrived in Utah, “Michael” was nearly finished, and he was taking a break to focus on a very different man under pressure: Nelson Mandela, the subject of his new documentary “Troublemaker,” which was having its première at Sundance. On the street, Fuqua was stopped by autograph collectors clutching posters for “Training Day” and “The Equalizer.” He signed them quickly, then retreated into a makeshift greenroom on the second floor of the Filmmaker Lodge. There he met his co-panelist: Billie Jean King, the tennis trailblazer, astonishingly sharp and trim at eighty-two. “It’s an honor,” she said, and Fuqua bowed respectfully. He gets along particularly well with athletes, perhaps because he admires them so much; he says that one of the most difficult things he ever did was accept that he was not going to play professional basketball.



Cartoon by Edward Steed

Onstage, Fuqua and King, who was promoting her own new documentary, talked about the link between sports and activism. Fuqua once directed a documentary about Muhammad Ali, and King shared her memories of getting to know him: “He’d go, ‘Billie Jean King, you’re the queen.’ ” Fuqua had been pleased to discover, during the research for his film, that Mandela was an amateur boxer. He liked the idea that a liberation hero who is often memorialized in America as an icon of nonviolence was in reality a fighter. “The only way you’re going to change anything—you’ve got to win,” he said.

Fuqua grew up in Pittsburgh, where his father was a foreman at an H. J. Heinz factory and his mother worked for Volkswagen and for the city health department. The decisive event of his childhood involved, fittingly enough, gunfire and a panicked dash. When he was fifteen, he says, he and a friend were shot at by a mechanic who mistook them for thieves; he ran through a

nearby alley before realizing that blood was seeping into his imitation-leather jacket, and the next thing he knew he was in an ambulance. “We lived in what people might say is the hood, but there wasn’t shooting on a regular basis,” his mother, Mary, told me. “There’s no way to protect your child in a situation like that.”

The bullet passed through Fuqua’s arm without much damage, but after the shooting he found himself drawn to the safety of movie theatres; he was fascinated by steely protagonists, like James Cagney’s vicious outlaw in “White Heat.” In college, when he wasn’t playing basketball or studying engineering, he dreamed of becoming a director, and in 1987 he moved to New York to see if it was possible. He worked a series of production-assistant jobs, where he picked up some ideas about how to run a set, and also about how to say no. On one shoot, for a TV commercial, he was assigned to scrub a section of street with a broom and a bucket, so that it would look better on camera. He quit P.A. work that day, resolving to scrape together money to make a short film: a surreal gangster melodrama about a drug dealer haunted by his guilty conscience. “Very ‘film student,’ ” Fuqua says now, even though he never went to film school.

Eventually, Fuqua moved to Los Angeles and found his way into Propaganda Films, an ideal place for an aspiring filmmaker. The agency, co-founded by Steve Golin, was known for making music videos, but over time it assembled perhaps the era’s most impressive roster of directors, including Michael Bay, David Fincher, Spike Jonze, and Mark Romanek. Fuqua was just about the only Black director in the office, and he developed a specialty in Black music, with a knack for creating vivid little movies on tight budgets. Steve Golin’s brother, Larry, a screenwriter, was close with Fuqua and admired his ability to honor the prime directive of music videos: the star must look cool. “We used to tease him about silk pajamas and diamonds and champagne glasses,” Golin recalls. “He was very skilled at giving the labels what they wanted—but upgraded.” For Prince’s song “The Most Beautiful Girl in the World,” Fuqua put the singer on a small stage, serenading a variety of women as they sat for portraits, their faces transformed by his Princely glow. The song became a Top Ten hit—the last one of Prince’s career.



"Training Day," with Ethan Hawke and Denzel Washington, gave Fuqua partners who were as serious-minded as he was. Photograph from Warner Bros. / Everett

Fuqua's reputation for working with Black musicians brought in work, but he worried that it also limited him. His clients seemed to get much lower budgets than their white counterparts in bands like Aerosmith did. "I would see these videos, man—they're huge, they got helicopters," he told me. "And I'm getting forty thousand dollars, maybe thirty thousand."

Ultimately, though, this reputation was what helped him break out of his niche. The producer Jerry Bruckheimer had a new movie called "Dangerous Minds," about a white teacher in a Black and Hispanic school, and he needed someone to direct a video for the soundtrack. Bruckheimer sent Fuqua the song: "Gangsta's Paradise," by an emerging rapper named Coolio. Fuqua imagined a video featuring Coolio and the movie's star, Michelle Pfeiffer, on an unglamorous set—no silk pajamas required. Bruckheimer suggested that he call Pfeiffer and ask her to join the shoot. Fuqua remembers being slightly intimidated: "I was, like, 'You want me to call *Michelle Pfeiffer*?' " But Pfeiffer told me that she considered herself lucky to have been asked. "I was very flattered, because the last thing I thought of myself was that I was cool in any way," she said.

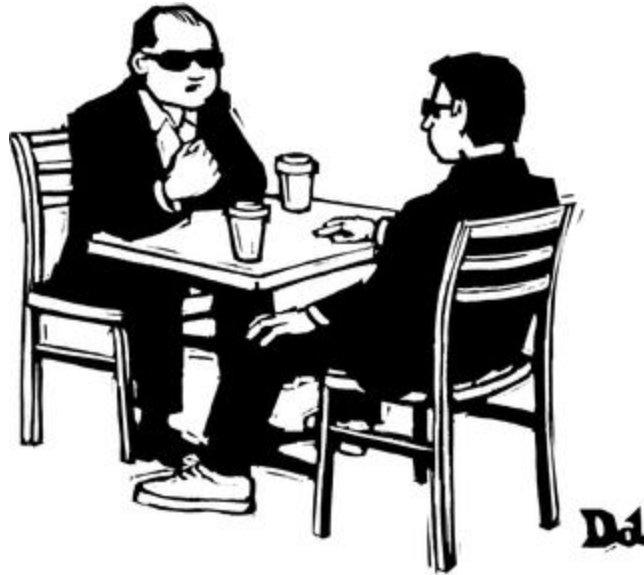
They shot late into the night, with Pfeiffer and Coolio facing off in what looked like an interrogation room. (Coolio scowls; Pfeiffer looks stern and—objectively speaking—cool in a black leather jacket.) The video helped the song become a hit, which helped the movie become a hit, and all of it established Fuqua as a stylish and streetwise director, equally comfortable with movie stars and rappers. Soon afterward, he resolved to stop making music videos entirely; while figuring out his first feature film, he would

concentrate on television commercials, because the pay was better and racial typecasting was less of a concern.

One of the best indicators of Fuqua's early reputation is a recording of an interview with the rapper Tupac Shakur, from 1995, a few months after "Gangsta's Paradise" was released. Shakur was talking to Monster Kody Scott, a much feared member of the Eight Tray Gangster Crips. Scott had written a best-selling memoir, "Monster," and he was excitedly telling Shakur about plans to adapt it into a film. "The director is Antoine Fuqua, a young brother," Scott said. "A straight-up cat—like us." Fuqua was spending long hours at Propaganda's headquarters, watching fellow-directors at work in editing bays, but in his downtime he had got to know a number of figures from the city's gang culture. Anne-Marie Mackay, an executive at Propaganda, remembers marvelling at his ability to move between worlds. "He could deal with the most dangerous situations and come out unscathed," she recalls.

"Monster" was supposed to be Fuqua's début, but he couldn't secure funding, so he signed on to direct a different kind of gangster movie: "The Replacement Killers," a trans-Pacific crime drama set in Los Angeles but starring the Hong Kong actor Chow Yun-fat. It took Fuqua a few years to find his way. He still winces at the mention of "Bait," a little-loved comedy starring Jamie Foxx, whose character is at one point moved to declare, "Oh, my nuts! My balls. My balls."

In time, though, Fuqua found partners as serious-minded as he was. As he began work on "Training Day," he met Ethan Hawke at a hotel bar in L.A. to recruit him to play an earnest rookie cop named Jake Hoyt. "We talked for hours," Hawke told me. "We got so feverishly passionate discussing 'Apocalypse Now,' a total stranger interrupted us to ask if we were O.K."



"It's not about making lemonade. It's about getting even with whichever bastard gave us lemons."
Cartoon by Drew Dernavich

The script, by David Ayer, was ruthless and unsentimental, and it gave Fuqua a chance to combine the stylized imagery he had used in videos with his own interest in moral fables and the code of the streets. He shot some of the film in South Central Los Angeles, relying on his neighborhood relationships to cast extras and to keep the peace. As he tells it, he called a meeting of influential figures, including Cle (Bone) Sloan, a gang member who had recently been released from prison. (Sloan later directed a documentary about the history of street gangs, which Fuqua produced.) "I said, 'I'm going to do this movie with Denzel, and I'm bringing it to the hood,' " Fuqua told me. "Every hood was, like, 'Come on through.' Latinos, the Blacks, the Bloods, the Crips. I had no issues."

It helped, of course, that he had Washington. The two men attended the same Pentecostal church, but they didn't know each other well when Fuqua pitched him a role in "Training Day." They have now made five films together, which have grossed about eight hundred and thirty-five million dollars, making them one of the most bankable duos in Hollywood. At various times in our conversations, Fuqua compared Washington to Miles Davis ("You've just got to know that sometimes he's going to do his thing") and Muhammad Ali ("You can give some instructions, but he's still going to be Ali"). Washington's glowering intensity matches the purposeful mood

that Fuqua likes to evoke: viewers get the pleasurable sensation of watching a man who refuses to be distracted or dissuaded.

In “Training Day,” of course, Washington’s character, Alonzo Harris, is a bad guy: probably worse than the criminals whom he abets and, when it’s convenient, dispatches, and definitely worse than Hawke’s character, who is assigned to be his partner. (The forthright contrast between Black vice and white virtue seems, perhaps, even more transgressive now than it did back in 2001.) The film takes place over the course of one very overstuffed day, during which it gradually becomes clear that Alonzo has got himself too deep into trouble to get out again; he is finally surrounded by gang members determined to enforce local standards of justice. In one version of the script, Alonzo managed to escape, but Washington and Fuqua decided against it. “To justify Alonzo Harris’s living in the worst way, he had to die in the worst way,” Washington once said in an interview. During the climactic scene, his character bellows, “King Kong ain’t got shit on me!,” and his delivery is so commanding that the line is often remembered as a declaration of invincibility, rather than as the last gasp of a doomed man.

In some ways, “Training Day” was misleading: it was a film built around a charismatic villain, made by a director who proved to be more interested in heroism. One of the only figures in Fuqua’s filmography who resembles Alonzo is Suge Knight, the real-life hip-hop executive known for his bullying—and sometimes violent—approach to business and life. In 2018, Fuqua made a documentary called “American Dream / American Nightmare,” in which Knight tells his own story, uncontradicted, so that viewers can make up their own minds about how wicked he really is.

Most of Fuqua’s features are anchored by men more like Robert McCall, Washington’s character in the “Equalizer” films, whose skills and moral code are both superhuman. “He’s St. Michael, stepping on the Devil’s head,” Fuqua said. “And sometimes that’s necessary.” The first “Equalizer” film was a remake of a nineteen-eighties television series that starred the English actor Edward Woodward as a suave former intelligence agent turned vigilante. Washington’s version of McCall is disciplined but damaged, and possibly afflicted with something like obsessive-compulsive disorder. “He needed things to be together, and to fit, because *he* wasn’t

together, and things didn't fit," Washington said, around the time the first film was released. "He's not just some mindless super guy who goes around, you know, kicking butt. He's struggling." In one famous scene, the camera zooms in on Washington's eye as he surveys a room full of Russian gangsters, taking inventory of the possible weapons: a gun, a knife, a glass tumbler, a corkscrew. "Sixteen seconds," he whispers, and he starts a timer on his watch before methodically reducing the room's living population to one. "I'm sorry," he says, even more quietly, once his bloody work is done, and the apology allows viewers to make believe that the violence is a necessary evil, instead of the whole point.



"What he does is deceptively complicated," one executive said about Fuqua. "People take for granted how good he is." Photograph by Ramona Rosales for The New Yorker

One of Fuqua's favorite directors is Akira Kurosawa, whose film "Seven Samurai" was reimaged by John Sturges as the classic Western "The Magnificent Seven." Those two films are commonly described as

meditations on the futility of violence in a world where justice takes the form of endless attacks and reprisals. Fuqua remade the Western in 2016, filling the cast with big names: he reunited Washington and Hawke, and added Chris Pratt and Peter Sarsgaard. After a chaotic climax, Fuqua gives viewers an unambiguous message, delivered in voice-over by the woman who had recruited the belligerents:

Whatever they were in life, here at the end, each man stood with courage and honor. They fought for the ones who couldn't fight for themselves, and they died for them, too. All to win something that didn't belong to them. It was magnificent.

This was not a subtle conclusion, but it reflected Fuqua's preference for clarity: his films are full of well-lit faces, crisp sounds (like the racking of a pistol), and sharp moral lines. "I would love to tell a story about a diabolical motherfucker—but he's got to be unapologetic," Fuqua told me. "You're either on *this* side of things, or you're all in on *this* side. There's no gray." The tension in his films usually comes from finding out whether and how his protagonist is going to succeed, not from wondering what kind of person he really is. In 2009, Hawke starred alongside Wesley Snipes and Don Cheadle in a Fuqua film called "Brooklyn's Finest," a sprawling cop thriller. "I remember Richard Gere coming to set and saying it had been a long time since he'd been in a room with that much testosterone," Hawke told me.

Over the years, Fuqua stayed so busy that he sometimes seemed to be running his own studio. Unlike the director Tyler Perry, whose devotion to telling Black stories inspired him to build a parallel version of Hollywood in Atlanta, Fuqua has always been intent on succeeding within Hollywood itself. Depending on his mood, he can seem either proud or distressed that he's not always thought of as a member of the industry élite. "You don't need to shake everybody's hand," he told me one afternoon. "As long as you're doing quality work, and you're being a gentleman about it, then you're good." But he is also intensely aware that his work tends not to win recognition. "This time of year *kills* me," he said. It was March, and many of his peers were getting ready for the Academy Awards, which have generally ignored his films. The major exception is "Training Day," for

which Washington won Best Actor. Accepting the trophy, Washington hailed Fuqua as “a brilliant young filmmaker, African American filmmaker.” Peering out at the audience, he added, “I don’t know where you are, Antoine—love you.” Fuqua was sitting near the back of the theatre, unseen not only by Washington but also by the television cameras. “Some of the reporters didn’t even know I was the director,” he recalled. “It wasn’t popular, being a Black director back then.”

Fuqua thought he had another chance at acclaim a few years ago, with “Emancipation,” a Will Smith film inspired by nineteenth-century photographs of a man who had escaped slavery exhibiting the scars on his back. It was an Apple Studios production, with a budget of more than a hundred million dollars, and Fuqua persuaded the venerable cinematographer Robert Richardson to serve as the director of photography. This was despite Richardson’s aversion to the local fauna in Louisiana, where much of the movie was shot. “I do not appreciate either snakes or alligators,” Richardson told me. Like many collaborators, he came away impressed by Fuqua’s ability to gently persuade people around him to do things they might initially oppose, such as bringing a crew to a remote location in the rural South. (The shoot was initially supposed to take place in Georgia, but Fuqua and Smith moved it, to protest new state voting laws that they described as “reminiscent of voting impediments that were passed at the end of Reconstruction.”) Richardson told me that Fuqua’s knack for getting his way reminded him of other directors he had worked with: Oliver Stone, Martin Scorsese, and Quentin Tarantino. “There’s not one of those four that you can honestly say no to,” he said.



Fuqua's music videos—including one in which Coolio squared off with Michelle Pfeiffer—helped establish him as a stylish and streetwise director. Photograph by Lester Cohen / Getty

The greatest asset that “Emancipation” had was its star—at least until the moment during the editing process when bewildered friends began calling Fuqua to ask, “Is this real?” Smith had slapped Chris Rock onstage at the Academy Awards, and was suddenly one of the most despised actors in America. Fuqua considered trying to broker a summit between the two men, but eventually he decided that it wasn’t his business, and that there was probably nothing he could do to rescue the film. Reviews were mixed, and Smith could not effectively promote the movie; everyone he talked to wanted to know about the slap, and he never settled on a compelling explanation. “It was almost like people were angry at all of *us*, for making it,” Fuqua told me. “Whether it would have went to the Academy Awards or not—I always have that in my mind.”

Fuqua did not always think of Michael Jackson as someone whose story he was meant to tell. “Early on in my career, I probably would have said, ‘I don’t know if that’s me,’ ” he told me. He remembers that, back when he was first establishing himself, someone mentioned the opportunity to direct a Jackson video. “It was huge, but I wasn’t running towards it,” he said. In the nineties, hip-hop was toughening up the sound of American popular music; Jackson, fey and theatrical, seemed increasingly distant from the cultural mainstream. In time, though, Fuqua came to see Jackson less as an anomaly than as an archetype: strange, but not much stranger than the show-business world he had been forced to navigate since childhood.

If Fuqua thought that a bio-pic about a pop star would be less gruelling to make than a slavery drama filmed in a Louisiana swamp, he was wrong. The film is built around music, and Jackson's lyrics do not neatly tell his life story; there is no evidence that he ever told a would-be street fighter to "beat it." Perhaps more significantly, Graham King, the producer, needed approval for the music from the Jackson estate, effectively giving it veto power over the project. A Michael Jackson movie without Michael Jackson songs was unlikely to be a global blockbuster.

Production was delayed by the 2023 strikes in Hollywood, but "Michael" remained one of the most highly anticipated films on the release schedule, as well as one of the most carefully guarded, with King and Fuqua saying little about their plans. When shooting finally began, Fuqua thought that he'd found a way to deploy the adrenalized style he's known for. He shot a surprising action sequence: a reënactment of the 1993 police raid on Neverland Ranch, Jackson's home and personal amusement park, on the far outskirts of Santa Barbara. After searching the premises, officers had examined and photographed Jackson's body, to compare it with descriptions from Jordan Chandler, a thirteen-year-old boy who had accused Jackson of touching his penis during one of their sleepovers. Chandler's family sued, and Jackson settled for about twenty-three million dollars; afterward, Chandler stopped cooperating with prosecutors, and the investigation was closed.

The raid marked the end of the era in which Jackson's eccentricity—his morphing appearance, his obsession with animals, and above all his love for children—seemed like something to chuckle about. In 2005, Jackson faced ten charges related to the alleged abuse of another thirteen-year-old. Though he was acquitted on all counts, the allegations threatened to overshadow his music—especially after the release, in 2019, of "Leaving Neverland," a documentary that told the stories of two more alleged victims. Amid widespread reconsideration of prominent people accused of wrongdoing, some wondered whether Jackson might disappear from playlists.

It turned out, though, that it's much harder to stop listening to Jackson's songs than it is to stop watching Woody Allen's films or "The Cosby Show." Part of the problem is that his influence is so huge; the Canadian

singer known as the Weeknd has become one of the most popular performers in the world with his moody, artful update of Jackson's music. On Broadway, "MJ the Musical" has been running for more than four years, encouraging theatregoers to let their love of Jackson's hits outweigh concerns about his life. And, though his songs have been mainly absent from television ads, the animated film "The Bad Guys 2" used "Bad" in a trailer last year. The legal fights aren't over; a case against Jackson's estate, filed by the two primary accusers from "Leaving Neverland," is scheduled to go to trial this fall. But it has now been more than fifteen years since Jackson's death, and the public outrage seems to be fading, perhaps because Jackson is increasingly viewed as a troubled figure from the past, rather than a troublesome figure in the present.

Fuqua hadn't planned to downplay the controversy that engulfed Jackson in his final decades. Instead, he envisioned a film that might have read as a provocative defense of its subject. Describing the scene of the raid, he told me, "I shot him being stripped naked, treated like an animal, a monster." Fuqua is not convinced that Jackson did what he is accused of doing, despite the number of accusers (five) and the fact that Jackson publicly talked about sharing his bed with boys. "When I hear things about us—Black people in particular, especially in a certain position—there's always pause," Fuqua told me. He mentioned the facts of Elvis Presley's life, suggesting there was a double standard. (Presley met his future wife, Priscilla, when she was fourteen, and she moved to Memphis to be with him at seventeen.) He was skeptical of some of the accusers' parents, particularly Chandler's father, a dentist and sometime screenwriter named Evan Chandler, who was recorded threatening to insure that Jackson was "humiliated beyond belief." (Evan Chandler died by suicide in 2009, a few months after Jackson's death.) Fuqua stressed that he didn't know the truth of the allegations against Jackson. But, he said, "sometimes people do some nasty things for some money."

Fuqua does much of his work at home, in his pool house, where he likes to watch old films as he researches new ones, and where everybody knows not to bother him if the door is closed. Movies are now the family business. In 1999, he married the actor Lela Rochon ("Waiting to Exhale"). His son Brando is an aspiring director who attends the University of Southern

California, and his other two children work for his production company—Asia, his daughter, appears briefly in “Michael,” playing the actress who plays Jackson’s girlfriend in the “Thriller” video.

When Fuqua needs to preside over meetings, he drives to Santa Monica, where he rents office space in a post-production studio. In one room, the walls are decorated with posters from his many films, including both hits (“Olympus Has Fallen”) and misses (“Tears of the Sun,” a Bruce Willis war story set in Nigeria). Fuqua is a linear storyteller, whose best movies are distinguished by momentum, and by what Hawke calls the “musicality” of his shots. “When his camera is rolling, I always hear the soundtrack,” Hawke told me. Jamie Marshall, who worked as an assistant director on a number of Fuqua’s films, was struck by his ability to insure that actors never feel rushed, even when the producers start to sweat. “He’ll rehearse for eight hours, everyone’s freaking out, and then he shoots the scene, bangs it out in an hour and a half,” Marshall said. Fuqua’s facility helps explain both his continued success and, perhaps, his relatively low profile. “He’s a shooter in the oldest sense of the word—the set pieces, and the choreography around it,” one executive who has made films with him said. “What he does is deceptively complicated, because he elevates genre, and he does it so seamlessly. People take for granted how good he is.”

Even as Fuqua was finishing “Michael,” he had begun work on a very different kind of bio-pic: “Hannibal,” a Netflix film with Denzel Washington in the title role. The racial identity of the historical Hannibal, who led the armies of ancient Carthage against Rome, does not map neatly onto modern categories: he was Mediterranean, possibly resembling present-day inhabitants of the Arab world. But Fuqua’s Hannibal is recognizably Black—an African insurgent taking on a European empire. “It’s incredible what we can achieve,” Fuqua said. “Ninety thousand men, thirty-seven elephants, and all the supplies that had to go with all that, over the Alps. That’s a hell of a campaign.”



Colman Domingo plays Jackson's father as a kind of antihero, whose determination to help his sons succeed turns into something darker. "You get seduced by the money and the power," Fuqua says. Photograph from Lionsgate

One recent afternoon, Fuqua convened a meeting at his office to figure out how, exactly, this campaign would be brought to life. Richardson, the cinematographer, was there, and so was Sled Reynolds, who since the nineteen-eighties has been one of Hollywood's most accomplished animal wranglers. Reynolds was dressed in a safari hat, as if prepared to wrangle any animal that happened to wander in off the Santa Monica Freeway. "The first thing we've got to get into is the elephant of it all," Fuqua said. He was preparing to scout locations in Italy, which meant he needed to scout some elephants, too.

Reynolds suggested that the inventory was low in local zoos. He guessed that there were seven or eight elephants in Italy, and "none of them have tusks." They discussed the possibility of prosthetic tusks, or even digitized ones, and considered whether it was important for Hannibal's elephant, like its rider, to be recognizably African. (Asian elephants are smaller, with differently shaped heads and ears.)

Fuqua had created hundreds of pages of storyboards, specifying countless details, but he knew that the success of "Hannibal" would ultimately depend not just on verisimilitude but on how cool its hero looked as he trudged off to war. "Whatever we do with the elephants, they should look *massive*," he said.

In 2024, after principal photography on "Michael" was finished, Fuqua got some shocking news from Graham King. Jackson's settlement with the

Chandler family turned out to include an agreement that forbade the estate to participate in depictions of the events around Chandler's allegation. The film that Fuqua had made was essentially unreleasable—not because Fuqua was too critical of Jackson but, in a sense, because he was too eager to defend him.

Fuqua thought about abandoning the project, but ultimately agreed to reconceive it instead. Even if he couldn't engage with the accusations, he could still defend Jackson, by reminding audiences of all that he endured during his rise from overworked child star to over-worshipped pop phenomenon. In the film, we see Jackson rehearsing with his brothers and visiting sick children in the hospital; often, we see him alone, kept company only by a rather uncanny digital facsimile of his chimpanzee, Bubbles. The revised "Michael" ends in the late eighties, with Jackson triumphant and his reputation intact. Instead of chronicling his downfall, Fuqua merely chronicles his rise—and, you might say, his emancipation. It is, as King calls it, a "nostalgia journey." Jaafar Jackson, who had never acted before, told me that Fuqua sometimes approached him after a take to deliver reassurance, saying, "Wherever you are right now, stay in that zone."

"Michael" might be Fuqua's first feature since "Training Day" with a villain at its center. The villain, though, is not Michael Jackson but his father, Joe, whose determination to get his boys out of Gary, Indiana, turns into something more poisonous. "At some point, you become diabolical," Fuqua said. "You get seduced by the money and the power." In conversations with Colman Domingo, Fuqua emphasized that Joe was also a strong, if flawed, avatar of African American fatherhood. "We talked about Black men who grew up pre-civil rights, and what the responsibilities were for them to raise their children, and what they were up against," Domingo told me. In the film, Michael Jackson spends much of his time reacting to the strictures and provocations of his father, who tells him, "Nobody else will understand you, outside this place." The dark message of the film is that this might be true.

If "Michael" succeeds, it will be because theatregoers are too enthralled to dwell on this possibility. Fuqua and King are considering a sequel, which might use some of the incendiary footage that they have already shot. For

now, though, a tortuous contractual process has led to a film that is surprisingly straightforward: a story of triumph where the tragedy exists only in the subtext, and in the unspoken possibility that a brilliant and sensitive boy, growing up in fear of his father, might turn out to be not just a victim but a perpetrator, too.

Even with no scenes related to the allegations of abuse, “Michael” has exposed divisions within the family. Jackson’s daughter, Paris, said on Instagram that the movie “panders to a very specific section of my dad’s fandom that still lives in the fantasy,” and she has blamed the estate for not realizing earlier that the Chandler story line might pose legal problems. (John Branca, a former lawyer for Jackson and an executor of his estate, has an additional relationship with the film: he is a character in it, portrayed by Miles Teller as one of Jackson’s most effective protectors.) The New York *Post* recently reported that, at a preview screening, Michael’s sister Janet “criticized everything, from the performances to the makeup.” (Janet Jackson, pop royalty in her own right, asked not to be included in the film.)

When the film opens, on April 24th, Jackson’s obsessive fans will have a chance to render their own verdict, and so will what remains of the moviegoing public. A few weeks ago, *Deadline* reported that advance ticket sales suggested “Michael” might have an even bigger opening weekend than “Bohemian Rhapsody” did, and so far any public backlash to the concept of a pro-Michael Jackson film has been muted.

Fuqua can’t pretend not to care about how well “Michael” does at the box office, but he has constructed his career to insure that he stays busy, no matter what. On the day that he had to make final changes to “Michael,” he was in New York, after a trip to Italy to scout locations for “Hannibal.” He saw a few things that could be improved—the lighting of Michael’s boyhood home in one scene didn’t quite match the lighting in a different one. But, a few hours later, sitting in a hotel lobby, he seemed pleased that his work was finished. “I came back, went upstairs for a minute, washed my face,” he told me. “That’s it. There’s nothing else I can do.” ♦

[Kelefa Sanneh](#) has been a staff writer at *The New Yorker* since 2008. He is the author of “[Major Labels: A History of Popular Music in Seven Genres](#).”

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Shouts & Murmurs

- **[Escape Rooms for Middle-Aged People](#)**

By Charles Yu | Work as a team as you and other dads chat about pro sports, college sports, kids (and their sports), while avoiding eye contact, politics, and any hint of vulnerability.

[Shouts & Murmurs](#)

Escape Rooms for Middle-Aged People

By [Charles Yu](#)

April 20, 2026



Illustration by Luci Gutiérrez

Work Dinner

Solo challenge. Estimated time: two to three hours. Using a Negroni and up to two glasses of Malbec, get through pre-appetizer chitchat, group ordering, salad, entrées, dessert, all the way to the Uber ride home, without oversharing or otherwise saying anything that will result in an emotional hangover the next morning. Pretend to care about your senior manager's "really funny story" while making sure you obtain at least one crostini before Bob grabs his third. Navigate a series of short, overlapping, half-shouted conversations across the table while trying to remember the names of peoples' kids and dogs and not being derailed by the weird vibes emanating from that one woman in Marketing who always wears a turtleneck. Expert mode: same challenge, no wine.

Thursday-Afternoon Budgeting Zoom

Group challenge. Estimated time: one hour. Test your hand-eye coordination and deception skills by maneuvering open windows on your desktop background, answering e-mails and texts and looking at Instagram, all while appearing to be engaged. Extra points for unmuting to chime in occasionally with enthusiastic agreement. Automatic fail if at any point the audio from a pop-up ad blares extremely loud for half a second while you're unmuted, requiring everyone to pretend they didn't hear it while trying to guess who it was.

Playdate for Dads

Work as a team alongside three to four other dads, progressing through a series of short conversations about pro sports, college sports, kids (and their sports), while avoiding eye contact, politics, and any hint of emotional vulnerability, and each of you drinking a beer as quickly as possible without being obvious about it. Final challenge: make open-ended plans to grab lunch sometime, knowing it won't happen until your spouses schedule another thing that forces you all together again. Successful completion is driving away, in your own separate cars, unaware that you are each listening to the National or James Blake and maybe even crying a little, you don't know why, doesn't mean anything, just sometimes feels good to cry a little, O.K.?

Friend-Group Scope Creep

Couples' challenge. Ideal for introvert-extrovert pairings. Work together with your partner to set boundaries on your friend group. Develop a strategy to selectively accept or turn down invitations while avoiding hurting anyone's feelings and not filling up your entire calendar with events that you're going to feel anxious about. If you're the introvert, navigate intra-couple tension with your partner over the right amount of elective, non-work socializing with people who, seen one way, are effectively strangers but, seen another way, are just humans looking for connection. To escape this room, you'll need to answer the central riddle: Where does it end? Friends of friends? Friends of friends of friends? And so on to infinity? Is everyone a potential friend? You like them, you really do, but at some point, there is a limited number of holiday cards in your standard order. And also, you have only so many chairs.

4 a.m. Thoughts

Solo challenge. Estimated time: one to three hours. Use breathing, mindfulness, gratitude, distraction, pretending you might get up and go for a run, any coping mechanism available, to escape your own head and get to sunrise without spiralling. Bonus points if you don't wake up your spouse. Extra challenge: don't look at your phone.

Cutting Each Other Off

Couples' challenge. Estimated time: one to fifty years (if you're lucky). Work as a team to develop habits of patience, attentive verbal communication, listening all the way to the end of someone's sentence, and not jumping in as soon as you think you know what they're going to say, or becoming distracted by a text, or thinking about what you're going to say while they are still talking. Bonus: completion results in a deep, sustaining love for your partner.

Warming Earth

Group challenge. Starting now, work with other nations on a collective-action problem.

Samsāra

Let yourself sit with a series of unanswerable questions. Hard mode: in the endless cycle of desire, self-absorption, and suffering, seek ways to live with kindness and compassion.

Escape Room

An actual escape room, your H.R. manager's idea of a fun team-building exercise. Before dismissing this activity or just trying to get through it, recognize your tendency to view nearly everything as a situation from which to extricate yourself as quickly and painlessly as possible. Take a moment to appreciate your co-workers, even Bob and turtleneck lady. In khakis and fleeces with the company logo, stay in the moment, work as a team to get to the outside, where your ultimate reward awaits: a glass of Malbec and a basket of cold fries. ♦

Charles Yu is the author of four books, including "[Interior Chinatown](#)," which won the National Book Award for Fiction.

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Fiction

- **[“Ordinary Wear and Tear”](#)**

By Thomas McGuane | She broke Carl’s heart, he thought, but she’s not breaking mine.

[Fiction](#)

Ordinary Wear and Tear

By [Thomas McGuane](#)

April 19, 2026



Illustration by Alain Pilon

Carl backed the car down the ramp, and, with little effort, Jed slid the boat off the trailer and into the river, where it tugged gently on the rope and slapped on the current. Carl parked the car and trailer, and came back to the bank carrying the oars. He was crisply dressed in khakis, a tattersall shirt, and a belt that displayed nautical signal flags. Jed, lean, nearly gaunt, with widespread blue eyes, wore a Seahawks sweatshirt with the sleeves cut off and flip-flops. He wondered why Carl thought he needed to be so spiffy. Carl took the oars as the river carried the boat downstream. It was a cloudless September day, with a dusting of snow at the higher elevations. The cottonwoods were just changing color and stirred in the morning breeze. This was a new river, the Ruby. Last month, they'd gone down the Gallatin, which had had too many rapids for their limited skills, and they'd barely avoided a wreck. They didn't fish or take their phones, just chatted as they floated along, a monthly summary. In the winter, they snowshoed in nearby hills or watched football.

Friends in childhood, they'd had an uninterrupted companionship until Carl went to boarding school, a place Jed called a breeding ground for suits. Carl's parents had been separating for the second time and had thought it best to get him out of the house and avoid a custody fight. They reconciled soon after, but let him come home only for holidays. He had fought to stay in town, where Jed and his other friends were, but eventually adjusted to boarding school and became a star lacrosse player, a game he'd never encountered before. Jed had attended the local Catholic school, though not for religious reasons. He had been adopted, from a hospital in North Dakota, by a Methodist couple, who thought the public school was full of drugs and casual sex and who referred to Catholics as Papists. Jed found the catechism baffling. His parish school, staffed by nuns, was a small island in a sea of Protestants, from the "Bible churches" in strip malls to Carl's family's church, St. Andrew's, presided over by Father John Oliver, who had been a missionary in Ecuador and returned with a souvenir blowgun, a modest knowledge of the Chicham languages, and a beautiful Shuar bride, Nunkui. Nunkui had grown obese and diabetic on American food, which affected her reproductive health, and Father Oliver often lamented the fact that they had been unable to "multiply." Jed asked Carl if he thought Nunkui had shrunk Father Oliver's head. "You can't possibly know how not

funny you are,” Carl said as he watched wild geese along the bank complaining about their intrusion.

[Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.](#)

Carl’s parents took him on educational vacations during school holidays. One year, while they were in Chichén Itzá, Jed and two friends broke into their house and drank up the liquor, favoring the fruit-flavored bottles, Cointreau and Grand Marnier. None of it stayed down for long. The incident was investigated by the police and written up in the paper as a burglary. Terror made the culprits conceal their ghastly hangovers, which their parents treated as the flu. Jed wanted to confess, at least to Carl, but lost his nerve. Carl’s parents offered a substantial reward, but no one buckled and the break-in remained unsolved. Carl’s mother said, “They shall live with this crime forever.” Jed often ate at their house and joined in speculating about the culprits, trying to frame Gary Fjelstad, a bullying upperclassman. But he was nervous. Carl’s mother complained that he tore his napkin into little balls, which she found uncouth. When they ate Salisbury steak, she challenged him to spell it and called him “Buckwheat” when he failed.

Carl went to Pomona College to get away from his home town and his parents, but it only made him love them more. Jed attended the state university and lived off campus, indulging in a cavalcade of liaisons. He needed R.O.T.C. in order to meet his college expenses. By the time Jed got out of the National Guard, where he crewed on helicopters, Carl was already on his way to a comfortable life. Jed got a job at a title company. Two eligible bachelors.

Shirley Crane arrived from Albuquerque with her parents, who bought the savings-and-loan building on Selfridge Street and turned it into luxurious condominiums that were well ahead of local markets. The family lived in one of the units while making plans for an R.V. campground. Carl’s father had died when Carl was in college, but his mother was available to despise these new people, whom she found shabby. Carl still called her Mummy.

“Gorgeous,” Carl said, the first time he and Jed saw Shirley standing on the diving board at the city pool. “Tawny,” Jed said. Carl soon announced that

he'd fallen for Shirley. Jed considered this preëmptive. He said, "I noticed you were sizing her up. I didn't realize it was a thing." Carl married Shirley Crane after a very long engagement, long enough for Shirley to adapt to his mother, who, believing Shirley a danger to her son, fecklessly monitored their courtship, but failed to survive their honeymoon, felled by a "massive" stroke in her greenhouse.

Carl's mother had snubbed Shirley's parents at the wedding, recoiling from the father's loud sports jacket with exaggerated disdain. Shirley's mother now made no secret of the fact that they were glad she was gone, which left Shirley in an awkward position as she tried to support Carl in his bereavement. He couldn't conceal his grief, and it was months before his mourning subsided.

The newlyweds had travelled all the way to the Dodecanese for the honeymoon, but only Shirley went for a swim. Carl struggled with the time change, and asked Shirley why the locals were all milling around. When they got back and moved into Carl's family home, Shirley threw herself into becoming a wife, doggedly working her way through her late mother-in-law's "Joy of Cooking" and transforming herself into an Irma S. Rombauer fangirl. Clearly, Carl and Shirley loved each other, but Carl's work ethic and his financial striving made their marriage other than Shirley had expected. It was as though marriage were something Carl had needed to get out of the way, a view that explained the couple's meagre intimacies. Shirley admired Carl's discipline and met the long solitary days with obsessive volunteering, counselling battered women and cleaning cages at the animal shelter. Carl worried that her work with mistreated women would place him under suspicion. And, channelling "Mummy," he called her friends at the animal shelter "empty nesters with rubber gloves." Carl visited the shelter just once, and peered at the animals while holding a Kleenex to his nose. Shirley wanted to rescue a dog, in particular a Corgi mix named Drew. Carl hugged her and said, "No." She asked him to consider two very small dogs, Sparkle Plenty and Sister Hooch. "No and no." She pushed him away. He raised his arms. "Now what did I do?"

To compensate for his position on the dogs, he asked Shirley if he might visit the women's shelter so that they could display their own affectionate

and violence-free marriage. “Otherwise, the gals might conclude I’m battering you—something I’ve never considered, as you know,” he said, following this with a joke about batter being the basis of pancakes.

That’s all I need, Shirley thought. The idea was soon forgotten. Shirley had spent years “pulling men’s hands off my ass” but had found them meek when rebuked. She’d never been abused but she heard stories at the women’s shelter that amazed her. When her disgust subsided, she was angry. “If you find the perpetrator,” Shirley said, “get a rope, get bombs, get rat poison.” The women so liked Shirley that they forgave her for not knowing what she was talking about.

Shirley’s exuberant nature balanced Carl’s placid ways, but the marriage turned out to be too much work, and it didn’t last. Carl was sure that his kindly and thoughtful nature, his good manners and solicitous demeanor were way more than enough—until the moment when Shirley announced that she’d had all she could stand. “Was it something I said?” Carl inquired. Jed was touched by this obtuse response when Carl described it on the river. He had long sensed that Shirley was adrift. Carl said, “This whole thing has been a real eye-opener. Oh, well, back to the drawing board.”

Podcast: The Writer’s Voice

[Listen to Thomas McGuane read “Ordinary Wear and Tear.”](#)

Shirley’s father, well-versed in litigation, brought in a real killer, a lawyer from Albuquerque. Shirley got more than enough money to buy a condominium in Kauai, where she’d spent several happy years in her teens while her father fleeced his partners. The condo was discounted as a result of one of her father’s bankruptcies. Shirley had her future to consider, but the move surprised Jed anyway. “Did you just roll over and play dead?” he asked Carl.

“Don’t be snide. I wanted to make sure she’d be O.K.” Jed saw right through this.

The river narrowed and turned to the right. They picked up speed for a pleasant stretch and swept quite close to the rocky shore, so close that they

spent a moment under branches while the shoreward oar tapped on the stones and flushed a pair of sandpipers.

Carl announced, “I married the daughter of unscrupulous developers and paid the price.” It didn’t sound at all like Carl. It was something his parents might have said. Still, Carl wasn’t entirely their product and enjoyed his anomalies. He had a complete set of David Bowie albums and a black cowboy hat. Jed teased him with Bowie imitations—“Bladder control to Major Tom,” and so on. Things could have been worse. There were no children. Jed knew that they were two kind people who were unsuited to each other, hardly a hanging offense. Carl’s ambivalence and grief caused him to make all sorts of ugly remarks, which he’d regret once things settled down. “She’s no dope. She’ll land on her feet.”

“Carl, honestly.”

“She’s in a phase. I’d take her back but she’d need to crawl on her tongue.”

Carl looked stricken, even a little crazy. He began to question everything: he drank more than usual, at least by his temperate standards, and was constantly in church, grilling Father Oliver. Jed told him he’d be better off going to the gym. But Carl was a believer and accepted what Jed called “the whole enchilada.” Jed’s own early indoctrination had evaporated, except maybe the fear of a damnation he hardly believed in, but there it was, a tincture. He wouldn’t have had even that if Sister Calista hadn’t often referred to “the charred doors of Hell,” a phrase that resurfaced in Jed’s mind at indiscreet moments.

Jed was not at all curious about his biological parents. Because of his raw-boned frame, crooked teeth, and blue eyes, he assumed that they were hillbillies. His remote and quarrelsome adoptive parents had left him with an aversion to both marriage and religion. His belief that getting married was a dim thing to do in the first place was likely behind his detached view of Carl’s marital failure. Military service had confirmed Jed’s bachelorhood perhaps as much as the example of his adoptive parents had. He had the dubious standing in town of someone who’d slept with more women who had gone on to marry and start families with other men than anyone else. He keenly admired the children of those women, as though he’d had a hand

in their lives; he even kept track of their birthdays. He'd chat these young mothers up, hoping to get a reminiscent smile out of them. It was a pleasant way to live, and new talent arrived regularly.

They passed a cornice that poured swallows overhead. Carl watched them as they spiralled above, but neglected to notice a man fishing from the bank and accidentally rowed across his line. Carl raised his hands from the oars and apologized, but the angler shook an enraged fist. Carl found that merely interesting and said, "Wow!"

Jed said, "Let's go back and whip his ass. I'm old-school."

Carl chuckled. "Jed, Jed, Jed."

These were usually such contented days on the river. They often saw deer come down for a drink and, once, a wolf stared at them over the body of a fawn. They passed a marshy side channel filled with duckweed and blackbirds. Jed thought Carl was hogging the oars, but he wouldn't give them up.

"I'm sublimating through exercise. I wish Shirley well and I'm resigned to her building her cheeseball with my money. Smart girls prepare for rainy days."

"She made out like a bandit." Jed didn't know why he would say this.



*"I wish we hadn't built so close to the highway."
Cartoon by Frank Cotham*

“It rains on bandits, too,” Carl said. “I’m fine with it. Why aren’t you? How else could she afford a condo in Kauai?” Jed decided against saying that the condo might not have been so affordable if her father hadn’t bankrupted his partners.

At the head of a grassy island, a cluster of teal took flight and whistled over the boat. On a day like this, a day of cloudless skies and sparkling foothills, it was not easy to stay on message or relieve tension. Carl was playing his plight for laughs, but his pain was evident. Jed wanted to leave it at that.

“You just need time.” Jed yawned.

“I imagined some residual good will between us, but Kauai makes it clear that she means to move on. I guess they have great weather there. But I don’t think our winters were the problem.”

“She knows she has a lot of years left.” Jed leaned back to watch a hawk overhead, a harrier.

“I’m not tracking her. If she wants to fuck some Polynesian in Kauai, I’ll buy him a war canoe.”

“Oh, dear me.”

Jed was finding Carl’s agitation disturbing. He looked wild-eyed. There was little doubt that Carl had provided Shirley with a life style that most would find dull. Shirley had hoped to learn to ski but Carl had said she’d only break a leg. As for travel, better to read about it; otherwise, it was just sightseeing. He had suggested that she work at his office if she wanted to keep busy, but she had declined. “You have a secretary!” she said, surprising Carl with her indignation.

“Evidently, she wanted more,” Jed said, wondering when this dirge would end.

“Don’t they all? Whose side are you on?”

It was a relief for both of them to laugh heartily at this.

“My mother, God rest her soul, would have liked Shirley if only she’d had more time. We were arguing about having kids. Shirley didn’t want to and she was getting loud. I raised my hand to stop it and said, ‘Halt.’ She accused me of trying to resolve marital disputes with hand signals. Mummy would have loved that. Sarcasm was her favorite.”

Carl carried the anchor up into the streamside willows and Jed put the cooler on the sand. He opened one of the sandwiches and said, “Find these at Ptomaine Gardens?”

“Next time, you get them. It’s hard to shop for a fussy eater.” Carl opened his sandwich to examine its contents, then said, “I don’t know why you’ve had so many girlfriends. Don’t you get sick of it?”

“It’s never the same. The housewives can be quite timid, but the divorcées buck like goats.” Carl held his head and moaned. Jed had thought guy talk would cheer him up. “You should try it. You squeeze them and it’s fun.”

“What in the world do you get out of it?”

“You just never know. Sometimes it’s a thrill. Sometimes it’s customer golf.”

“I don’t understand.”

“I don’t understand your checkered quest for monogamy.”

“I have hope. It doesn’t sound like you do.”

Their bantering boat trips would go on forever, unless Carl learned that Jed had slept with Shirley within days of the divorce being final. Shirley had been sitting on a bench in the park, watching young people sword fighting with lacrosse sticks that Carl had donated. It was as if she were having a last look at her life in this town. Jed spotted her as he took a shortcut to his office. Her arms were stretched across the back of the bench. She didn’t see him coming.

“You look sad.”

“Oh, it’s you. I’m just watching the kids trying to figure those things out.”

Jed’s heart was racing. “I hope we can stay in touch.”

“I do, too. I’m not proud of how this ended.”

“I assume you loved Carl.”

“I still do. He’s so good. I just can’t live like that.” Jed wondered why Carl was such a poor husband but such a great friend. Maybe the two things were connected.

Jed gazed at her, as if to express that he shared her wish for Carl’s well-being. She held his gaze. They took separate routes to Jed’s house. He would long remember Shirley’s slumberous voice, saying, “Don’t rush. I’m enjoying you.” But, if the occasion was something that Jed liked to replay in his mind, Shirley appeared to want to forget it. She left for Hawaii as soon as she could. The animal shelter threw a nice party with dogs, the women’s shelter a private, even covert farewell that brought Shirley to tears. Jed was left wondering if he’d fallen in love. Maybe he had: he was quite lighthearted about the end of Carl’s marriage. It seemed to him that his dalliance with Shirley was not unlike the time he broke into Carl’s family home with his friends and got sick on Carl’s parents’ liquor. I get it, he thought. I’m going to Hell.

The condo in Kauai looked like a clean break. Even Jed was bothered by it. Carl pretended to shrug it off: “I’ve got a law firm to run.” (He’d hired a young intern from the law school he’d attended, so now it was a “firm.”)

Jed said, “Shirley and I were great friends. I hope to see her again.”

“Be my guest,” Carl said.

“I have been,” Jed replied. Carl assumed Jed meant the sandwiches. To avoid misunderstanding, Jed pointed to them and cautiously took a bite.

Shirley had wanted to take Drew to Kauai with her. The dog had been in the shelter for more than a year and was ready for adventure. But in order to

avoid a long quarantine she had to leave the dog with Carl until many requirements were met. She understood Carl's issues with dogs and warned him that Drew could be very opinionated. Carl accepted, clinging to this last connection to Shirley.

Drew was suspicious of Carl and at first declined to eat, but Carl kept moving through the process, towing Drew on his leash to be microchipped or to acquire a health certificate from a veterinarian, whose face Drew licked. Carl wished that Drew felt the same way about him, but wondered if the licking was sanitary. Carl scheduled two rabies vaccines, thirty days apart, arranged for a proof-of-tick-treatment certificate and a rabies-antibody test. He took pains filling out the animal-import form and mailed it to Shirley at Bali Hai condos, in Kauai. By then, Drew and Carl had become quite used to each other.

The flight to Kauai over Christmas was no picnic, with gruesome layovers. Jed had told his office he'd be travelling. Carl was out of town—Jed didn't know where. Shirley's condominium was in a neighborhood that was undistinguished but pleasant, with ocean air. Carl had shown him a picture of it on his phone, one of several brown cottages near the water. Jed had memorized the details—the palms on either side, the crooked walkway, and the red door, which Shirley barely opened to him. A pelting tropical rain had begun to fall, bouncing around the landing. She suggested that he call first next time.

Next time! What about the four-hour layover? She broke Carl's heart, he thought, but she's not breaking mine.

It wasn't true. He clung to a memory of Shirley flinging herself across the bed to check her phone while he gazed ruefully at the wet spot. In some way, he enjoyed the unrequited infatuation, kind of a buzz. Women were tyrants! He vowed to keep the mortifying boarding passes. Better to remember the whole damn thing as a one-off. This brief moment in Shirley's doorway was a bruising encounter, and he was soaked.

No flights out until the next day. Home seemed across the planet and filled with guileless citizens with strong Western values who would never find themselves in Kauai for unethical reasons. The stucco motel would have to

do. It was out of the rain, and he could work on his flight booking. He asked the desk clerk if he could borrow the dryer. “No.” He’d have to hang the clothes. He thought to try Shirley on the chance she’d kept her old number. Staring out the window at the sheeting rain, he dialled. She answered.

“Why didn’t you ask me in?”

“Carl is here.”

His face grew hot. He felt the skin on his back prickle.

“I see. Where is he now?”

“Some motel in town.”

“You don’t know which one?” Jed cried.

“Hey, Jed, take a hint.”

He called the front desk and asked if they had a guest under Carl’s name.

“We don’t share that information. It’s the law.”

“Of course! Just like the fucking dryer. Why did I ask?”

“The use of the dryer is not protected by law. The names of guests are.”

Jed wondered how he’d come to this, taking abuse from some jailhouse lawyer at the front desk. He’d rarely been homesick for his town but he was now. The old trees, the playgrounds, winter days at his office, breakfasts at the drugstore with friends. He should just move on and book a flight. He looked at options on his phone. He grabbed a motel scratch pad with a picture of a pineapple, but the first thing he wrote was “Shirley.” He hunted in vain for non-stops. His thoughts were all over the place, and included the prospect of a layover in Honolulu with an escort service. He’d tried that once and been sent an attractive surgical nurse named Joan. It was too embarrassing, so they just went to dinner. Joan commented on what she called his comical lack of self-awareness. Shirley could have said the same thing, instead of telling him not to rush when he was already rushing.

He called her. “Shirl, I’m so sorry to bother you again, but this could get awkward.”



“It’s for you.”

Cartoon by Michael Maslin

“No shit.”

“I’m just gonna scoot. But, of course, it would be best if I didn’t bump into Carl. What’s he doing here, anyway?”

“We’re in discussion.”

“Ah, nice. I’m touched by his determination. He’s a great guy.”

“Make your reservation. I’ll do what I can to arrange a clean getaway. And never again confuse a slip with a real event.”

“No, ma’am!”

“Bye, now. Don’t be ugly.”

He had to get out of the room and decided to go once the sun was setting. Walking along the beach and kicking at shells, he met a couple from Indiana enjoying the last light of the day. “I’m from Indiana, too!” he told them. It was a pointless fib but it helped his anxiety. The couple looked rural and Jed wanted to talk about agricultural things. His title company increasingly managed farmland that was going to other uses. But the Hoosiers were obsessed with the new Colts quarterback and the drug

problems of the team's owner and, besides, they seemed troubled by Jed's restlessness. They moved along, eyes fixed on the water as though something might soon happen there.

When it was dark, Jed left the beach and walked beside the road bordering the sea, wondering why the locals needed so many pickup trucks. How did they even get them there? He began to feel as if he was being followed but didn't look behind him to check. When he pulled his phone out of his pocket, he saw that he had missed a call. Shirley. He listened to his voice mail. Her voice was subdued; he couldn't tell if she was being sultry or just careful not to be overheard. The message was clear. Carl had just left. Jed dismissed the idea that he could visit her with impunity. He knew better.

Tomorrow he'd be inching his way home. No first class, but he had an aisle seat. He'd scan the crowd at the Honolulu airport in case Carl had missed his connection and was craning at the display board to find his new gate number. For a moment, he felt solidarity with Carl. Why was Shirley such a problem for both of them? Her blunt decency was hard for guys like them. Why had Jed's little flutter with her mattered so much more to Jed than to her? Why did it still trouble him?

"Old pal," Carl said, "we're restating our vows. At least, I hope we are! Shirley's a flight risk!"

"Let's assume once was enough." If not, Jed thought, I could pop back to Kauai.

In a small town, it's hard to get people to the same wedding twice. Jed had hoped to recruit some showstopper to accompany him for the occasion—to give Shirley second thoughts?—but couldn't find anyone willing to go along. It was a modest affair at St. Andrew's, with business friends of Carl's, baffled but loyal friends of Shirley's. Her friends from the women's shelter seemed to trail the ghosts of the thugs in their past. One was a real looker but not keen to enter some charade with Jed, whose big smile put her off. When he flirted with a schoolteacher he knew—"Well, well, well"—she gently knuckled him in the ribs and told him to get a life. The principals were at the altar now. Father Oliver wore a retro surplice and added sly details about the previous wedding to his homily. Jed wondered how the

beaming cleric felt about being dragged through this again. No doubt he viewed it as pure spiritual affirmation. Jed watched Shirley's lips as she repeated her oath. "May the Force be with you!" Father Oliver concluded.

Jed wondered if the wedding guests considered him less successful than Carl. Probably they did, and, if their values were entirely pecuniary, shame on them. For a moment, Jed felt in pitched battle with his oldest friend, his suit still rumpled from the first wedding, while Carl was crisp, stylish, and formal. Jed was starting to feel that he couldn't live with this—not the erotic memory, which had hardly faded, but the guilt, which was growing. He feared that it would have to be resolved or he'd be on the horn with *Re/Max* looking for another town.

Carl led the celebrants out as though they were a platoon. Shirley stayed inside with her friends from the animal shelter and a sampling of battered women. Jed walked toward them and the friends fell away to accommodate him. Did they know something? Jed felt strange and uncomfortable, and thick-tongued as he intoned, "I truly think this is the best thing for both of you going forward." He was surprised at his own orotund phrasing. Shirley looked at him for a long moment, bemused at this awkward solemnity, and told him to fuck off.

Jed was taken aback. He said, "Ah," as Shirley joined the rest of the wedding party out front. People were driving away. It was like a drag race. Carl was waving to the departing cars, married again and filled with hope. Jed admired his guileless enthusiasm as the guests shot off, this bit of drudgery out of the way. Father Oliver raised a hand to wave, his cowboy boots squarely planted. Never before now had Jed felt his betrayal so powerfully. Carl was loved in the community, even by those who considered him a sap for lending money to people who came to him with sketchy sob stories. A real Christian, they said out of the side of their mouths. Carl's housekeeper had had him co-sign a big note at Stockmens Bank, then left town with a handyman who was not her husband. Carl said that he understood her desperation, referred to her as a "poor thing," and wrote it off. Jed told Carl that he would have followed her to the gates of Hell to get his money back. He hated it when people treated Carl like a

sucker and ran up his receivables. “People think you’re a soft touch,” Jed said.

“Oh, probably I am.”

“It’s open-wallet surgery.”

“I know, I know. But, hey, that’s funny.”

The second marriage of Carl and Shirley lasted less than ninety days; it was over before she’d even begun to think about selling the condo. Carl was spared the pain of embarrassment, as he seemed incapable of it. But Jed’s guilt was eating at him. He could scarcely think what it would take to resolve it. This anguish surprised him. He tried without success to see his betrayal as merely something he’d gotten away with.

“What’s this?” Carl said, leading Jed down the corridor to his office. Jed didn’t return the wave of Carl’s secretary, Jenny, even though she had gone to high school with him and they had shared each other’s company out by the cellphone towers in inclement weather back then. “You made an appointment to see me? What on earth!”

“I’ll be quick,” Jed said. Carl stopped for a moment, looking at Jed in concern, but then led him into the office, closing the door. A sign on his desk said “*THINK OR THWIM*.” Jed sat facing Carl, gazing around at the pictures without seeing them. He was determined to come clean. “I have something I want to tell you.” This was the hardest thing Jed had ever done, but he had no choice. “I have to get this off my chest.”

“Stop right there! We knew you broke into the house. Mummy figured it out in a New York minute. We forgot about it long ago. You should, too.”

Jed sat quietly, unrelieved even when Carl began to laugh. He stared into his lap while Carl went on to summarize some personal news. He was trading in his Taos for a Tiguan, and Shirley already had another companion. “I call him Tarzan, but Shirley’s happy. So . . . so, that’s good.”

“Carl, that’s not what I came to tell you.”

Jed told him what he'd done, blunt and without details. "I'm sorry." The two sat in silence. Jed couldn't look up. He let it sink in.

Carl spoke, his voice level. "We never had a chance. You ruined my marriage." Jed knew that this was not the time to say that the marriage had already ended. "I don't understand why you did it."

"Neither do I."

Jed had never seen this expression on Carl's face. Carl looked down, tapping his thumbnails against each other. "I need to think about this. I heard you were in Kauai. I thought it was a courtesy call. What did you make of the island?"

Jed's attempt to speak came out wrong. "A poor man's Maui." What could that possibly mean?

"I visited the Breadfruit Institute." Carl sounded robotic. "All about global food security. I'm not a beach guy. What do you actually care about, Jed?"

"Not enough, maybe." Jed stood. "May I give you a call?"

"Sure, Jed, give me a call."

A day later, Carl phoned Jed to propose a formal discussion. He said that he wanted to put this behind them. His disquieting voice hadn't changed. He told Jed to meet him at the vestry in St. Andrew's on Tuesday morning. Father Oliver would stand by. "Be there." It was a command.

Jed's relief was palpable. He hung up the phone and gave a little fist pump. He dared to think that the friendship could be saved. Nothing else in his life had lasted so long or ever would again.

It was the last snowy day of the year, wet spring snow. Jed started toward the church from his house, a long walk that would allow him to collect his thoughts. He paused at the corner of Cottonwood to watch a children's snowball fight. Only one girl, in a Wonder Woman snowsuit, could really throw, and it was unclear if they'd chosen sides. A small black dog with a

bandanna around its neck tried to catch the snowballs. Jed watched as long as he could but kept an eye on the time. Maybe the children were unable to choose sides. There were five of them, and the odd number would make for awkwardness. Jed stalled to consider this, but he had to get going and stop spinning scenarios. A deputy sheriff pulled alongside him as he walked, calling, "Jed, want a ride?" Jed said he needed the exercise and resumed, avoiding parts of the sidewalk under branches laden with snow. Puffed-up birds adorned the overhead wires. In the morning sun, the street seemed to sparkle.

Father Oliver stopped him on the sidewalk in front of the rectory, coatless, with his arms crossed. "Jed, it would be best if you just go home. Let me work it out with Carl now. We'll get him some help."

"Can't I just go in?" Jed bridled at Father Oliver's stern gaze.

"You wouldn't be safe."

"I wouldn't be safe? What are you talking about?"

"Just please take me at my word. It's a bad idea. Carl told me what happened and, if I may say so, Jed, I pray that one day you will find redemption."

As Jed crossed the park, he felt put upon by Father Oliver taking up Carl's grievance. His indignation was a relief. He stopped by the swings to greet an old girlfriend, Cathy Chitham, with her handsome toddlers. He didn't remember her married name, something Polish. He rested his hands on the children's crowns as she pushed her sunglasses back with a finger. "How am I holding up?" she said.

"You never looked so good."

"Oh, funny. I suppose you'd know," she said. Jed was aghast that, in front of these beautiful children, she was leering. It had been a hard day, and he was in no mood to plunge into her gaze. Cathy wore a light sweater. Jed asked if she was cold and she said, "Oh, Jed, give it up."

“I’ve just been told by a man of the cloth that I’m a bad human being.”

“I already knew that! I’m not surprised you never married, given all the antics. It’s lucky that you don’t know what you’re missing.”

“I like being alone with my faults.” That was true. Jed knelt to say goodbye to the toddlers, who were trying to figure out who he was. “You take good care of Mommy, O.K.?” No reply from them. Jed found them nearly as bland as their mother.

Cathy said, “See you around.”

Jed thought, Yep, says it all. The children continued to peer at him as he walked up the empty street toward home.

In the following days, Jed noticed Carl watching him from a distance, and one night he thought he heard him on the porch. He could see a silhouette from his darkened bedroom. He declined to find out more and waited for the figure to depart before returning to a restless sleep.

Carl received a citation from the state bar association noting his “tireless advocacy for indigent rights,” a baffling accolade, which Carl accepted cheerfully without suspecting that it was the result of an intervention by two lawyer friends who’d learned that Carl was, as one of them put it, “on his way to the rubber room.” Carl sought advice about ordinary life from his secretary, Jenny. It was good to have someone normal at hand. He began to return to the office in order to talk to her, and soon fell in love again. Jenny was forthright about his previous nuptials. She said, “If Father Oliver knew shit from Shinola, he would have talked you out of both of those marriages.” Thanks to Jenny’s guidance, Carl stopped conferring with Father Oliver, whom she described as “medieval.” Carl’s faith had once been a consolation in his life. His secretary’s stark remarks made him turn to her instead. Carl asked where the indigents in town were, and she said, “We don’t have any.” Then, recalling the award from the bar association, she added, “I mean, they’re careful to stay out of sight.” She visited Carl at his home or stayed over, then moved in. People in town began to notice a renewed spring in his step, and were pleased to see his improvement.



Cartoon by Roland High

Jed and Carl bumped into each other, at the bank, the gas station, and the grocery store. Jed found Carl's cordial greetings fishy. Shirley had never claimed Drew, and now Carl rarely went anywhere without the little dog. Jed recommitted himself to his work, trying to understand trends as the town changed. His relations with his neighbors may have been formal, but they had begun to check the lights at his house to make sure he was O.K.

Carl accidentally ran over Drew in his driveway and was not seen in his office or elsewhere for nine days. Knocks on his door went unanswered. The cold was extreme, the Alberta Express. Jed scraped his windshield and got in his car. He drove to Carl's office, where he found Jenny, at her station with her usual crocodile smile, still wearing her hat. Her forehead wrinkled at the sight of Jed.

Jed asked, "What should I know?"

"He ran over Drew."

"I heard."

"The dog was the only reason he forgave you."

"That's hard to follow, but sure."

"Carl loves me." Jed thought that this was probably true. Still, it landed with a thud.

"I heard that. It's wonderful, but why doesn't he come to work?"

“When he lost the dog, he got mad at you again, and I didn’t want to hear about it for one more minute—the betrayal, the quote shattered friendship unquote.”

“He said that?”

“Jed, your zipper problems have caused so much heartache in this town.”

Jed thought to stay silent this time on the subject of the eager volunteers, even about the steamy hours at the cellphone towers, where opportunity had illuminated the frosty nights. Of course Jenny’s right, he thought. I’m an absolute pig.

“Maybe Carl thought Drew was a stand-in for Shirley.”

“That hurts, Jed.” Tears filled her eyes. “Perhaps it’s true. I hope it’s not.”

“I didn’t mean to upset you. You could buy him a dog—”

“Why, sure. Or how about a parrot? Or a horse?” Jenny stood, a handful of papers crushed in her fist. Jed quietly excused himself and returned to the snow. He started home, then stopped. It was clear. He’d go and see Carl. He had to.

He had not gone past Carl’s house all winter. He remembered the side window that he and his friends had broken. The replaced glass didn’t match the other panes. Where had those friends gone? Moved away, most likely. Jed wondered if he should be grateful that his dreary job had kept him here. It wasn’t really a question.

He smiled painfully at the security camera and knocked. Carl answered the door in his bathrobe. “I’ve been expecting you,” he said.

Maybe Carl would shoot him. It might be welcome, though he imagined it would hurt.

“How’s biz?” Carl asked as he placed a pod in the Keurig machine.

“My secretary earns the only reliable living.”

“As it should be,” Carl said. He led Jed into the living room, where they sat before a rock fireplace with a gas log, and, above it, a painting of a wagon train, a woman in a bonnet driving the oxen. It hadn’t been there when Jed was last in the house. It must have been a reference to Carl’s pioneer family. What an eyesore. “Jenny and I are getting married,” Carl announced. “We’ve been close since I don’t know when. It’s time to act. In a way, I’m grateful that you disrupted my life. It’s been a long way around the horn, but I’m with the right girl now. We have no secrets.” Carl paused and Jed didn’t speak. “I’m at last coming out of a very dark place. Yes, I’m moving toward the light.” He stared into his coffee for a moment, before lifting his eyes and holding Jed’s gaze. “Jed, I’ve waited all this time to tell you to your face that I hate you.”

“I understand.”

That was it. Carl saw him to the door, clutching his bathrobe as the snow blew in. Jed stopped when it shut behind him. Was this, finally, the end? Still, they had the long years of friendship to overcome this mishap. Jed felt it was inevitable that they would eventually reconcile.

Jed read about the wedding and wondered how Father Oliver could have performed the ceremony with a straight face. He had lost his indigenous wife to diabetes and was no longer a social presence in the community, now rarely beaming from the front of the church with indiscriminate benevolence. Carl and Jenny’s sparsely attended wedding was felt to be the end of an era by those who noticed it. The follies that had been cheerful topics for the town had dried up. The principals were starting to look old. At first, people thought Jenny had taken on airs, but she was one of them, and, in the end, they wished she were more pretentious and had a place in Arizona.

Kauai had long since gone from being a subject of gossip to a travel destination, and several neighbors vacationed there, returning with anomalous souvenirs from the Pacific Islands or brochures from the Breadfruit Institute. Global food security was a new topic in this comfortable town.

Carl's practice—"a big frog in a small pond"—suffered as people now travelled to seek services. A modest trauma center was all the town had to offer by way of medical facilities, and Carl's office rarely took on cases beyond the town limits. His many friends in the bar association recognized that he could again use some help and arranged for him to fill a district-court vacancy. They'd known him since law school and agreed that he was solid. The court's residency requirements meant that Carl and Jenny would have to move to Helena—or else decline the position and face a straitened future in a place that seemed to be dissolving. They sold the house, took the furniture and the wagon-train painting, and moved away.

As Jed ate breakfast at the drugstore counter one summer morning, he remembered that it was Carl's birthday. He thought to make it an occasion and wandered past Carl's old home. A tricycle and a trampoline stood on the lawn. A dog barked behind a window.

Jed moved along, hoping to bump into someone he knew. ♦

*[Thomas McGuane](#) began contributing fiction to *The New Yorker* in 1994. He is the author of "[A Wooded Shore](#)," among other books.*

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Was Raphael the Runt of the Renaissance?

Many have called him boring, a peddler of simpleminded beauty. At the Met, a blockbuster exhibition restores his standing.

By [Zachary Fine](#)

April 20, 2026



“La Muta” (ca. 1503-05). Art work by Raphael / Courtesy Scala / Ministero per i Beni e le Attività Culturali / Art Resource

It’s rare that history offers up a simple diagnosis of cultural decline, but we happen to know the exact moment when all of European art headed for ruin. According to the critic John Ruskin, the disaster was called Raphael. The

Renaissance master, whose name is only ever sighed in the same breath as Leonardo and Michelangelo, supposedly traded truth for beauty, and ended up destroying both. His work was dull and vapid, a “tasteless poison,” Ruskin said. Just think of all those vacant Madonnas, structurally perfect compositions, and obedient daydreams of antiquity. A modern eyeball can handle only so much before it starts to derange itself in search of a single painterly quirk or sliver of personality.

I had some of this antipathy knocking around in my head before seeing “Raphael: Sublime Poetry,” a show in the works for eight years, at the Met. The good thing about exhibitions of scale, featuring hundreds of objects and once-in-a-century levels of rarity—this is the first major Raphael show in the U.S., a herculean undertaking by the curator Carmen C. Bambach—is that it’s almost impossible to be unchanged by them. Either the crust of your resistance thickens, or it crumbles in the face of genius. In this case, my experience was much stranger. I found an artist so spongelike in his adoption of other styles, so dispersed in his influence on other artists, and so mythical in his stature that I could barely form a clear picture of him.



"Portrait of a Young Boy (Presumed to Be a Self-Portrait)," ca. 1500. Art work by Raphael / Courtesy © Ashmolean Museum

Like all great myths, Raphael's is full of symmetries. He was born on Good Friday in 1483 and died on Good Friday in 1520. Given that he lived in the center of Christendom, this wasn't an insignificant coincidence. Even though he died at the age of thirty-seven, reportedly from having too much sex—not from a venereal disease or a fantastic sex injury but literally from an excess of lovemaking—people often preferred to believe that he died at thirty-three, for its Christly associations. His most influential biographer, Giorgio Vasari, said that Raphael was the beneficiary of his mother breast-feeding him instead of handing him off to a wet nurse, and a recent biographer concurs: "This welcoming maternal breast was undoubtedly one of the factors that helped the future artist." Ah, yes. Undoubtedly.

The more concrete circumstances were no less auspicious. Raphael's father, Giovanni Santi, was a well-regarded painter and poet in Urbino, a court town that revolved around the palace of Duke Federico da Montefeltro. The

Duke, a lover of the arts, drew the twin currents of Quattrocento painting into his fiefdom: the geometry and the structural intelligence of the Italian manner, as represented by Piero della Francesca, who brought his talents for linear perspective to town not long before Raphael was born; and the fetish for detail in the Flemish manner, as represented by Rogier van der Weyden and Jan van Eyck. Raphael's father soaked up both traditions and ran a bustling artist's workshop, or *bottega*, in a building connected to the family home. As a child, Raphael would have learned not only how to create charcoal from willow twigs or how to handle a brush made with hog bristles; he would have seen the rigid hierarchies of the *bottega*—who fetched the water and ground the pigment in the porphyry stone, who conceived of the design for paintings, and how competing personalities were orchestrated toward a single aim. Raphael's father could manage people below him but also, as a courtier who wrote an entire epic about the life and exploits of Duke Federico, flatter the powerful above him. These were two talents he imparted to his son. Even the most complimentary appraisals of Raphael, which celebrate his multimodal genius—painter, draftsman, architect, poet, surveyor of antiquities—also mention his exquisite social tact and career climbing. He wasn't just a brilliant artist. He was the politest apparatchik of the High Renaissance.

When we meet Raphael in the show, he's a young lad wearing a cap. A drawing from around 1500, presumed to be a self-portrait, depicts him with a bit of steel in his eyes. Often regarded as a draftsman first and a painter second, Raphael gives us evidence here to see why. Note the control and tightness of the hatched lines on the cheek, and the way the mark loosens with the locks of hair right next to it, like wind rushing around a building. The darkened edge of his face seems almost gouged into the page, lending a drawing that would otherwise be light and sweet a more interesting mortal heft. By the age of twelve, Raphael had lost both of his parents, and by the age of seventeen he was already a *magister*—a master painter—taking on a private commission for an altarpiece. He wasn't done learning, though. Even after his apprentice years, he toiled in the workshop of his mentor, Pietro Perugino.

Perugino isn't a household name today, but at the tail end of the Quattrocento he was considered by some to be the best painter in Italy.

Before Raphael made it to Florence, around 1504, and had his mind rearranged by the work of Leonardo and Michelangelo, Perugino was his North Star. The exhibition has a number of the teacher's paintings and drawings, which clue you in to how Raphael picked up his "minute style," as Vasari called it. In Perugino's "Saint Augustine with Members of an Augustinian Confraternity" (ca. 1500), notice the crisp little fingers of the faithful, who are shrunk to denote their lesser importance against the big Augustine in the center, with his impressively forked beard. Perugino's compositions tend to be clumsy in their parallels—two people on the left, two people on the right—and the skin typically looks like candle wax. In the sixteenth century, people started to sour on his work. Paolo Giovio, a physician and a writer, called Perugino's imagination "sterile." Michelangelo, never one for niceties, said he was just "inept."

It's easy to use Perugino as a foil to Raphael, but I'm not convinced that Raphael ever fully rehabilitated the stiffness out of his master's bodies. The faces, in particular. It's as if the candle wax becomes subcutaneous, the skin softened and more graceful but concealing an inner brittleness. Raphael's admirers often say that he was "the only painter of his generation capable of revealing the souls of the men and women whom he painted," or that he was a wizard at conveying "psychological presence." They're either overstating the case or looking at the work of a different painter. Raphael could certainly extract feeling from the architecture of a body and the distribution of its weight, but the majority of his faces, even the most artificially expressive ones, are unburdened by anything like a psychology. That might sound like a recipe for bad painting. Oddly, it isn't.

One way to tackle the show at the Met is to go from start to finish, diligently combing through all two hundred and thirty-seven pieces by Raphael and his wider circle. Another is to carve the show closer to the bone, skipping over the contextual padding and focussing on the hundred and seventy-five pieces by Raphael. The third option—and don't tell the curators I'm suggesting this—is to cut straight to the octagonal chamber in the center of the exhibition, which has five of Raphael's society portraits, all of them masterpieces. Along the way, you should pause to pay homage to "The Alba Madonna" (ca. 1509-11), a perfect circle of pastoral sweetness, and absorb any drawings that catch your eye, but, if you're on a

tight schedule, an hour concentrated with the portraits is worth more than an hour spread thinly across the rest of the exhibition.



“Portrait of Bindo Altoviti” (ca. 1515-16). Art work by Raphael / Courtesy National Gallery of Art, Washington



“Portrait of a Young Woman with a Unicorn” (1505-06). Art work by Raphael / Courtesy Galleria Borghese; Photograph by Mauro Coen

There are two paintings on the left side of the octagon: “La Muta” (ca. 1503-05) and “Portrait of a Young Woman with a Unicorn” (1505-06). Both are very exciting. “La Muta,” or “The Mute,” shows a woman sitting in front of a black void. There’s no historically justifiable reason to call her “the mute,” but Leonardo did write that a painter should capture the mind of a subject via the “gestures and the movements of the limbs, and these should be learned from mute persons, who better actualize them than any other sort of men.” The woman is crossing her hands over her lap, a pose that Raphael may have cribbed from the “Mona Lisa”—he and Leonardo were both in Florence between 1504 and 1508—but the focus of the painting, the point toward which the whole composition plunges, is a single finger. It connects with the bottom of the canvas, as though the sitter is pressing an invisible button.

Odds are that the sitter is Giovanna da Montefeltro della Rovere, who was around forty years old and recently widowed. If that’s true, the entire psychological burden of the piece has been distilled into that one strained

digit. Cover the top half of the painting with your hand, and you'll see that Giovanna's flat expression bears no relation to the action of her extremities. By removing the face as a theatre of psychology, Raphael puts an unusual pressure on the rest of the painting to communicate and produce feeling. My favorite detail is the red ribbon on Giovanna's right shoulder, which fastens her sleeve to her dress and floats over the darkness. For some reason, it reminds me of Christ's loincloth in the paintings of Rogier van der Weyden, rippling against a block of color. There are so many exquisite, Netherlandish, hyperreal details to admire in the piece—the shadow of Giovanna's necklace, the enamel decorations on her cross, the frizz of her hair—but there's something about the ribbon that feels like a banner of heartbreak. Even when he emptied out a facial expression, Raphael could produce an ache of sadness with just a few accessories.

All of Raphael's portraits in the octagon are quite distinct—the palette ranges from emerald green and cinnabar to earthy browns and bone black—but there is one bizarre consistency. To recast a three-quarter-length body as a pyramid, a favorite Renaissance shape, Raphael repeatedly files down the shoulder blades and turns their supporting muscle into a long sloping line, which dives from neck to arm. In theory, this could be a standard beauty modification, like Ingres tossing a few extra vertebrae into a naked back. But Raphael botches the foreshortening and engorges the left trapezius to make it seem closer. The result looks a bit like the internet sensation the Crooked Man, who exercises his left trapezius and nothing else. (Don't look it up.) The situation is particularly severe in "Portrait of a Young Woman with a Unicorn." I was so distracted by her trapezius that I kept forgetting she was holding a baby unicorn.

Shipped over from the Galleria Borghese, in Rome, the portrait is the most bracingly odd thing in the show, and well suited for modern eyes. The title says it all, except that the unicorn is more like a lapdog with a horn and the young woman, if it is indeed Laura Orsini della Rovere, is around thirteen, which likely makes this a betrothal portrait, meant to advertise her beauty and her dowry. For more than two centuries, she was overpainted as St. Catherine, the unicorn hidden under a torture wheel. Now the unicorn is back, cutely neighing, its mouth as open as Laura's is closed. It could be a double-edged symbol of virtue and vice, of chastity and unheeded pleasure,

but it could also be a bit of heraldry, to highlight Laura's family ties. The underdrawing, seen with the help of infrared reflectography, shows that Raphael did some last-minute idealizing of her face (as he did with "La Muta," whose double chin disappears in the final version). Dante, Petrarch, and Boccaccio had already spun the Renaissance fantasy of the *bella donna*, with her golden tresses, blue eyes, and pale skin. Laura Orsini is true to type.

Raphael clearly had a thing for blond hair. Laura's coiffure is dealt with lavishly, but I don't think I've ever seen a painter show off so much as in Raphael's portrait of Bindo Altoviti (ca. 1515-16), a dashing young banker whose golden coils roll down his neck with absurd levels of silkiness and precision. Painted a decade after Giovanna and Laura, Bindo isn't served open-faced and evenly lit; Raphael has him look over his right shoulder, from shadow to light. The painting is about a hundred times more erotic than the other two portraits and at least twice as erotic as "La Fornarina," Raphael's nude of a woman he possibly slept with. Just look at Bindo's neck, exposed by a parted curtain of hair, the feathery wisps of sideburn, the plump lips, the green eyes. On multiple visits, I've had a sort of paranormal experience with Bindo's right eye, in the middle of the canvas. The longer you stare, the more Cyclopean it becomes, so that it starts to levitate, like a jewel, up and out of the painting. The floating eyeball makes this either my favorite piece in the show or one that I need to stay away from.

When Raphael left Florence for Rome, in 1508, he arrived right on time. Pope Julius II was in the process of restoring the Eternal City to its imperial splendor. A lover of rare antiquities, the Pontiff had commissioned work from the architect Donato Bramante, who liked to scurry around town and measure Roman ruins. Bramante was from the Duchy of Urbino, and he recommended his fellow-Urbinate Raphael for a fresco project in the Stanza della Segnatura, a room in the papal apartments. It was specifically in these frescoes, according to John Ruskin, that the gangrene of modernity set in. By putting religious and profane art together—a picture of Christ on one wall and Apollo on another, both equalized in their prettiness—Raphael triggered centuries of decadence. That's just one opinion, though. Another person might see the Stanza della Segnatura as the height of humanism, a

celebration of ancient philosophy over patristic theology, as in “The School of Athens,” Raphael’s most famous work.

The immovable paintings create a problem for any Raphael exhibition that’s not in the Vatican. The way the Met has chosen to deal with this is to toss the Vatican frescoes onto all four walls of a side room via projector. Because the images rotate at a screen-saver pace, my advice would be to focus on the preparatory drawings and cartoons, which are like sparks thrown off some great, beautiful machine. Although I can appreciate “The School of Athens,” with its leisurely construction-site ethos—Socrates and friends lounging around an enfilade of vaults, open to the sky—I’m partial to “The Fire in the Borgo,” one room over at the Vatican. The composition is pure chaos, which is a relief after so many paintings of classical restraint. Raphael arranges more than forty bodies across at least five centers of action, using all kinds of columns, arches, stairs, and loggias to visually slice and dice the space for narrative ease. To encompass the story, about a miracle from 847, when Pope Leo IV stopped a fire with a blessing, Raphael brings you into the fresco through the unshod feet of a woman in agony and leaves you near the very back, with a tiny and serene Leo IV. (Notice how Raphael uses the wind—in hair, in clothes—like invisible twine, wrapping different parts together.) There is no full cartoon of the fresco, but the Met does have a small red chalk drawing of its most poignant moment: a son carrying his father out of the flames.



“The Miraculous Draft of the Fishes,” from the fifteen-forties or the fifteen-fifties. Art work by Jan van Tieghem / Frans Gheeteels after Raphael / Courtesy Patrimonio Nacional

The final crescendo of the exhibition will seem a tad strange without context—it's three enormous tapestries (or, rather, second editions of tapestries) that Raphael designed with the assistance of his studio. Woven in wool, silk, and gilt-metal-coated thread, the first set was commissioned to decorate the walls of the Sistine Chapel, and its cost was astronomical. It contributed to the bankruptcy of the Roman Curia and effectively added gasoline to the Protestant Reformation. (Martin Luther, born the same year as Raphael, visited Rome in 1510 and was appalled by the extravagance of the Pope's tastes.) The artistic value of the tapestries is that, like "The Fire in the Borgo," they show Raphael as an ingenious organizer of visual narrative. In "The Miraculous Draft of the Fishes," birds wheel in the sky, a puff of smoke rises from a chimney in the background—and yet, within this single moment, a multipart story is unfolding, with Christ telling the apostles to cast their net, the apostles hauling fish from the water, and Peter throwing himself at Christ's feet. Like a proto-Chrisopher Nolan film, Raphael collapses the second into the minute into the day, and then doubles the scene over itself through a reflection in water. All of this is captured in thread.

When Raphael died, a hundred torches were carried by painters at his funeral, and he was buried in the rotunda of the Pantheon. People were so eager to venerate his remains that skulls of his magically multiplied. Goethe saw one in Rome and swooned over its handsome bone structure, saying that it looked exactly like the kind of skull in which a "beautiful soul could comfortably meander." (It wasn't Raphael's.) The hero worship was eventually punctured, though, and in the nineteenth century Leonardo and Michelangelo would become the twin heads of Renaissance art genius. The nail in the coffin was the Pre-Raphaelites. Raphael has the rare distinction of having an entire aesthetic movement named after a desire to go back to a time before him.

What makes Raphael so difficult to appreciate is that his greatest talents are, in a way, invisible. A brilliant composition isn't as tangible as a single body rippling with muscle or the sfumato of an earlobe; it's an interrelation of parts. When the art historian Erwin Panofsky waxes about the composition of Raphael's "Madonna di Foligno" (1511-12), describing the "well-balanced two-dimensional pattern and an equilibrated distribution of plastic

bodies in three-dimensional space,” he ends up sounding like a structural engineer. It’s hard to explain the beauty of the space between things. And supposedly Raphael managed the bodies in his workshop just as well as he did those in his paintings. He went around with a posse of some fifty-odd painters, and his very presence could dispel bad moods and bring out the best in people. That kind of popularity and radiant goodness produces a lineage of artists but doesn’t have the crowd appeal of a lone genius who invents a flying machine or pulls a seventeen-foot sculpture out of a block of marble.

Ruskin said that the only thing clear about Raphael’s compositions was that “everybody seemed to be pointing at everybody else, and that nobody, to my notion, was worth pointing at.” It’s a moving insight on his achievement, in a way. Think of all those heavenward looks in Raphael’s drawings and paintings, such as the man at the center of the Oddi Altarpiece (ca. 1503-05), in which a raised chin can be a medium of transport to somewhere else in the painting, or somewhere above it. Or think of those empty faces which have abandoned their emotion only to have it picked up in a single finger or a ribbon. It’s an art of grace notes and subtleties, of in-betweens and elsewhere. Raphael’s legacy isn’t one masterpiece but so many mysterious crumbs of greatness scattered in sketches and designs, in oil paintings and frescoes. How lovely it would be to see them. ♦

[Zachary Fine](#) is the Kim-Frank Postdoctoral Fellow in Criticism at Wesleyan University.

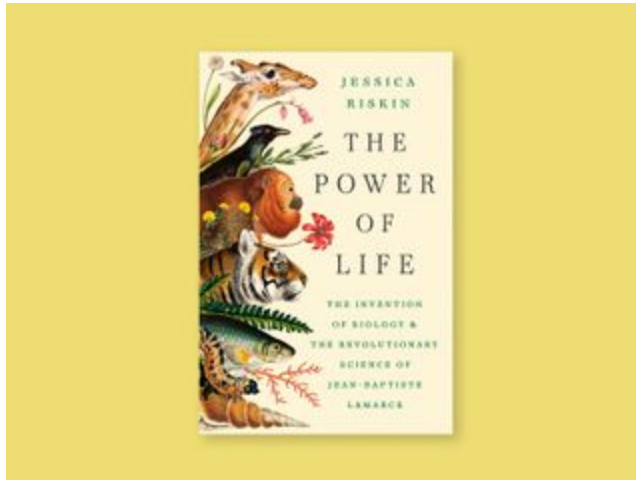
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[Books](#)

Briefly Noted

“The Power of Life,” “How It Feels to Be Alive,” “Go Gentle,” and “Exemplary Humans.”

April 20, 2026



The Power of Life, by Jessica Riskin (*Riverhead*). The subject of this engaging biography is the eighteenth-and-nineteenth-century naturalist Jean-Baptiste Lamarck, who is often ridiculed as a faulty precursor to Darwin. Long associated with the idea that giraffes developed long necks because they stretched to reach trees (even though giraffes, Riskin points out, barely figure in his writings), Lamarck was in reality a complex thinker working in an age of upheaval, who introduced the radical concept that “living things are in a continual state of self-transformation,” and popularized the term “biology” itself. In a time when science’s boundaries were less stable, Lamarck’s poetic theories had significant influence, and its traces can even be detected in contemporary epigenetics.



[How It Feels to Be Alive](#), by Megan O’Grady (*Farrar, Straus & Giroux*). Moving between memoir and criticism, this essay collection documents O’Grady’s lifelong fascination with works of art that refuse easy interpretation, beginning with the painter Agnes Martin’s “Friendship.” O’Grady goes on to examine pieces by artists including Carrie Mae Weems, Barbara Kruger, and Pope.L, whose performances, O’Grady writes, obliterated “the distance between the spectacles we’re supposed to look at and those we’re supposed to look away from.” Threaded throughout are recollections of O’Grady’s youth in Kansas, where museum exhibitions that she encountered disrupted the visual monotony around which she grew up.

[What We’re Reading](#)



Illustration by Henri Campeã

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[Go Gentle](#), by *Maria Semple (Putnam)*. This comic novel is narrated by Adora, a divorced, middle-aged philosopher who lives in Manhattan as part of what she calls a “coven”: a cluster of three accomplished single women who all purchased apartments on the same floor of a famed Beaux-Arts building. The women plan to support one another as they grow old so that each can “go out in a blaze of independence,” but Adora’s course changes when she falls for an alluring man and embarks on a hard-charging escapade that’s equal parts screwball comedy, international-intrigue caper, and feminist comeuppance story. The novel swings between the trivial and the dire, and in her bleakest moments Adora leans on the Stoics for guidance, thinking, C’mon, boys, don’t fail me now!



[Exemplary Humans](#), by *Juliana Leite, translated from the Portuguese by Zoë Perry (Two Lines)*. Natalia, a lonely Brazilian centenarian, anchors this searching novel. “The problem with living too much,” she reflects, “is that

you witness a world that is being erased right in front of you, person by person.” Natalia, with nowhere to be and no one to see, recognizes that “the past is the only future,” and so she dwells on her life—on her roles as a daughter and a schoolteacher, as a wife and a mother, and, most important, as a political dissident who resisted Brazil’s military dictatorship. At the heart of Natalia’s account is the question of how one continues to exist. The book ventures an answer, one found in its very form: by transmitting memories, both our own and others’.

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[Books](#)

In Defense of the Moderate

In an era that prizes passion, “reasonableness” gets caricatured as political cowardice or bloodless neutrality. A new book says it’s exactly what we need.

By [Nikhil Krishnan](#)

April 20, 2026



Radicals on the left and the right hold a shared contempt for compromise and difference-splitting. A new book helps explain why this contempt is corrosive. Illustration by Javier Jaén

You don’t want me negotiating for you. I am inclined to fold before the slightest friction and am always the first to blink in a staring contest. These habits may come from my being congenitally risk-averse but also from an overdeveloped capacity for charitable interpretation, for constructing what rationalists online like to call “steel men.” Whatever arguments management might think up for laying me off, I’m sure I can come up with better ones. Thank goodness for those hardened union reps who take muscular pleasure in holding the line and wouldn’t dream of conceding that management could have a case. Where would we pushovers be without the

pushy to defend us? Waiting with exquisite patience in the breadline, that's where.

By all accounts, being a milquetoast is a sort of vice—cowardice masquerading as prudence. But in Aristotle's typology, where virtue is a mean between two opposing extremes, the opposite of a vice tends to be another vice. Courage and resolution are to be distinguished from my sort of cowardice as much as they are from the reckless bravado of the zealot or the mulishness of dogmatists incapable of recognizing when the other side has a point. Anyone who thinks the only alternative to being a victim is to be a victimizer is missing some important possibilities.

[What We're Reading](#)

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Have we a word for this virtue? The Stanford philosopher Krista Lawlor believes that we do. In “[Being Reasonable: The Case for a Misunderstood Virtue](#)” (Harvard), she writes wisely and imaginatively about what separates the virtue of reasonableness from the vices it can be confused with. The distinction is more than an academic nicety. At a time when political life tempts us to treat compromise as capitulation, her argument amounts to a defense of the habits that make common life possible.

Unlike some other terms that philosophers use, the adjectives “reasonable” and “unreasonable” are part of our daily language. A thousand couples, at this very moment, must be accusing each other of failing to be reasonable. A hugely popular forum on the British parents’ website Mumsnet is called “Am I Being Unreasonable?” But the highest-stakes appeals to reasonableness have always been in the law.

Lawlor’s book opens with an account of the [tragic shooting of Yoshi Hattori](#), a Japanese exchange student in Baton Rouge who was killed after

he approached the wrong house for a Halloween party, in 1992. The question before the jury was whether the fears that had led the homeowner, Rodney Peairs, to fire his gun were “reasonable.” The jury voted to acquit Peairs of manslaughter. Lawlor is not convinced they got it right.

What question did the jurors think they were being asked? Legal scholars have disagreed. “The average Louisiana homeowner in Peairs’s situation could have thought Hattori posed a very real threat of death,” the law professor Cynthia Lee has argued. Like many people, she apparently takes the term “reasonable” to mean “average” or “typical.”

Lawlor finds that troubling. The average person might be prejudiced, and what could be more unreasonable than prejudice? Even if Peairs’s fears were, as the jury’s verdict suggested, typical for his environment, they weren’t reasonable in a deeper sense, the one that Lawlor’s book develops and defends. “People can make mistakes, but being concerned to get it right about value and being reliable in tracking it—that, on my hypothesis, is the heart of reasonableness,” she writes.

It’s no surprise that the notion of the reasonable plays a central role in the law. Certain statutes explicitly appeal to what’s reasonable—exasperating those who find the standard hopelessly indeterminate. Montana once had a traffic law that required drivers to operate their vehicles “in a careful and prudent manner at a rate of speed no greater than is reasonable and proper under the conditions existing at the point of operation.” One frustrated motorist, in 1996, prevailed on the Montana Supreme Court to declare that law “void for vagueness,” because it failed to “give a motorist of ordinary intelligence fair notice of the speed at which he or she violates the law.” The traffic code was appropriately amended to specify maximum speeds.

Yet Lawlor notes that the amended law nonetheless retained a reference to reasonableness. How could it avoid doing so? Could a traffic code provide explicit limits for every possible set of road conditions? Lawlor mischievously imagines what one might look like: “If four inches of snow, go fifteen miles per hour, if six inches, go ten miles per hour, unless there is fog, in which case . . .” Asking drivers to be, quite simply, reasonable, rather than literal-minded sticklers, “is a time-honored way for the law to handle novel situations,” she observes.

“Being Reasonable” is that attractive and unusual thing, a small book on a big subject. Lawlor writes with the pleasing air of someone keen to be understood by a wide range of possible readers. Philosophical theories are summarized in the plainest of plain English, with jargon thoughtfully rationed and examples taken from the most everyday of situations: siblings wondering whether to move their elderly father to an assisted-living facility, friends recommending movies to one another, a hyper-competitive Sunday-softball player steamed by a loss. Her academic interlocutors, no less than the fictional and real people in her illustrations, are unfailingly treated with a charity that exemplifies the virtue she’s writing about.

Lawlor draws a sharp line between being “rational”—the skill used to achieve one’s own goals—and being “reasonable,” an essentially social quality. Consider the notorious “Dictator Game,” beloved by behavioral economists. In this game, a Proposer is given a sum of money and invited to choose in what proportion to split it with a Receiver. The Receiver is not allowed to reject the offer, so a purely “rational” player—that is to say, a self-interested one—would keep the entire sum.

In a study conducted by the psychologist Igor Grossmann, participants agreed that it was perfectly rational for the Proposer to keep all of the money. Yet they considered Proposers “reasonable” only if they offered a fair split—usually around forty or fifty per cent. For Lawlor, this result supports her larger assertion: in ordinary usage, reasonableness names a different mode of thought than rationality does—it treats other people’s claims as having standing.

To be reasonable is to have the capacity to recognize that we aren’t the only ones making judgments of value; other people, too, are evaluators, and their claims on the world also have weight. A master of hardball negotiation might be a rational man, but he is unreasonable if he refuses to recognize the needs and perspectives of others when negotiating. To be reasonable, Lawlor thinks, is to see your point of view as one of many—while avoiding the slide into pliancy, the endless perspective-taking of the pushover.

“If you are reasonable,” Lawlor says, “you are open to the possibility that what matters to the other person does matter.” To be “open to the possibility” requires discernment: you have to be able to decide when what

matters to the other person does, and doesn't, have a legitimate claim on you. Reasonableness, in her formulation, is a "critical-minded assessment of the concerns of others and an open-minded readiness to change one's own concerns."

What would it look like, at the limit, to be without such a capacity? Inevitably, Lawlor reaches for a Nazi. Hannah Arendt's well-known account of [the trial of Adolf Eichmann](#) contained, among its other penetrating descriptions of the defendant, this diagnosis: "The longer one listened to him, the more obvious it became . . . an inability to think, namely, to *think* from the standpoint of somebody else." Arendt hit on the word "banal" to describe his iniquity, but here she roots it in an aberration: a lack of the most ordinary of human abilities.

Lawlor's most compelling metaphor, borrowed from R. Jay Wallace, a philosopher at U.C. Berkeley, is that of a "landscape of value." Each of us moves through a world strewn with figurative mountains and molehills, continually assessing what matters more and what matters less. Mapping that terrain is a social practice. We learn from one another, and we convey our judgments through "costly signals," claims that require explanation and defense, rather than "cheap signals" shouted to advertise tribal allegiance. Reasonable people are disposed to signal coöperatively. That is, they assume responsibility for their judgments and grant others standing to challenge them. They're constantly updating their maps based on what they hear from travellers navigating the same space.

One of Lawlor's examples concerns the (literal) mountain climber Ed Webster, who, having experienced bouts of anoxia, turned back from Mt. Everest's summit when he was just three hundred feet from it. He decided that he'd rather relinquish the chance at glory than jeopardize his life. Some mountaineers may have regarded the retreat as a failure of nerve. Even so, the decision tracks value in a way others can recognize. Choosing life over glory is reasonableness in action.



“Which two people on this conference call are discreetly messaging each other about you?”
Cartoon by Jon Adams

Webster’s decision has one feature that makes it easy to classify as reasonable: it was his to make. No one else had to live under the shadow of its consequences. Although the decision was exercised against a background of possible disagreement, it didn’t require that disagreement to be resolved. Those who considered Webster a failure by some mountaineer’s code could have expressed their disdain, but they knew that Webster was free to make his own choices.

The word we have for the point where this freedom ends is “politics.” Politics, with all its mechanisms, its conflicts, and its institutions, exists because people—even, somehow, reasonable people—disagree. But they must live and act together anyway, under institutions that govern human beings despite their disagreements. That’s a gentle way of saying that those institutions must be prepared, at times, to coerce. It is one thing to chart a landscape of value for yourself; it is another to do so for a society whose members will be bound, often resentfully, by the resulting map.

Lawlor’s book contains chapters devoted to politics, but her inclination to reach for examples of the reasonable and unreasonable that any reader will intuitively share serves her less well here. The question of whether

reasonableness has a place in politics does not have an obvious answer. A suspicious reader, all too familiar now with the dismissal of heterodox views as beyond the pale, might see behind her call for political reasonableness a more nefarious agenda: to make a bland moderation the test of virtue.

The thinker on whom Lawlor draws most extensively in her discussion of political reasonableness is John Rawls, that giant of postwar American political philosophy. Rawls provided the most influential modern formulation of what reasonableness demands [under conditions of pluralism](#)—the condition under which the people in most of the world’s democracies live. His starting point was not optimism about the likelihood of human agreement but a sober recognition of its unlikelihood.

Modern societies, he thought, are marked by what he called the “burdens of judgment.” People are different; their experiences might have little overlap; their values pull in competing directions. Is it any surprise that conscientious people reasoning in good faith might arrive at incompatible conclusions about what life is for and what justice demands? These disagreements are not curable pathologies but permanent features of a free society. Rawls doesn’t think that we must all be relativists; we still have the right to think our own views true. But he does derive from these premises the counsel of restraint. To be reasonable, in Rawls’s sense, is to accept that one’s deepest convictions may fail to command assent from others who are no less sincere or thoughtful, and then to propose terms of political coöperation that others can appreciate.

This idea of reasonableness is easily caricatured as moral timidity or a bloodless neutrality that drains politics of passion. But Rawls didn’t seek to empty politics of conviction. The alternative to what he called “public reason” is not authenticity, or what Yeats called the “passionate intensity” of the worst, but force. When citizens insist on shaping the basic terms of social life by appealing to premises that others cannot reasonably be expected to accept—revelation, doctrines of transcendence, private moral visions—the result is not a purer politics but a dangerously brittle one.

The unsentimental grounding for this picture of reasonableness was provided by another giant of postwar American philosophy, though not one

generally praised for his insights into politics: David Lewis. Better known for his bold and occasionally kooky-sounding arguments in metaphysics, he was also the author of a neglected gem of political philosophy. In an essay titled “Mill and Milquetoast,” Lewis takes aim at the comforting stories liberals sometimes tell themselves about tolerance—that we refrain from suppressing one another because we admire diversity or because we believe that truth will emerge from the clash of ideas. Nonsense. The modern norms of tolerance emerged, rather, as a hard-won peace treaty, hammered out, as Rawls had held, after Europe exhausted itself in religious war. “I won’t suppress you if you don’t suppress me” was not an expression of moral indifference, and still less of a sudden burst of generosity. It was a recognition by the wounded and the grieving of a shared vulnerability.

Reasonableness, like tolerance, is best seen as a convention of restraint, sustained because everyone remembers, however vaguely, what happens when the treaty collapses. In time, the treaty of toleration becomes, Lewis writes, “not just a constraint of conduct, but a climate of thought.” The habits that sustain this treaty and this climate are precisely those that radicals on all sides find contemptible: compromise, procedural fidelity, the refusal to go for broke. Demanding absolutely everything, Lewis says, makes you a bad signatory to an agreement that keeps one from being crushed by rivals the next time they have the chance. Lawlor’s evolutionary story, with its emphasis on shared mapping and coöperative signalling, lends this picture further support. Reasonableness is a survival trait. To be unreasonable is to be a bad survivalist.

Say we accept that picture of how we learned to be reasonable. What keeps the peace treaty in place, frayed though it is? In “[Concealment and Exposure](#),” another neglected gem of liberal philosophy, Rawls’s student Thomas Nagel wrote that society depends not only on what is publicly justified but on what is tactfully left unspoken. Civilization, he suggested, would be impossible if we could read one another’s minds. The world of mind readers would be, of course, a world without hypocrisy but also one without discretion. Forcing every disagreement into the open, and demanding consensus on matters of taste, meaning, or identity, would destroy the very conditions that allow diverse ways of life to coexist.

The point is that some disagreements may be too socially expensive to stage as public trials. Why—to take Nagel’s example of a “culture war” episode from the late nineteen-eighties—did art-world partisans dig in their heels and insist that federal funding should support an exhibition of Robert Mapplethorpe’s notoriously provocative photographs? The debate forced a showdown that would have better been avoided. The reason that reasonable liberals may refrain from pressing a victory is not that they hew to Robert Frost’s fond sendup of the type (“so altruistically moral / I never take my own side in a quarrel”). It’s that they understand how fragile the settlement is.

It can be easy to forget in the twenty-twenties, but there was a time when this ethos of restraint defined politics in much of the West. Bill Clinton’s infamous “triangulation,” Tony Blair’s Third Way, and Barack Obama’s insistence on being the most reasonable person in the room were all variations on a single theory of the case: that if you offered terms fair enough to hurt your own side, the opposition, faced with your fairness, would accept them. In retrospect, this faith looks naïve—as, indeed, it looked to some people at the time. But its failures (we are quick to forget its successes) suggest less that reasonableness was a mistake than that too many players stopped believing in the treaty it presupposed. All virtues rely on some set of conditions for their relevance.

Hostility to such politics has been voluble and loud. Left-wing critics of tactical triangulation have maintained that this can be seen only as collaboration with evil. Right-wing impatience with the politics of compromise appears in the disquieting [revival of Catholic “integralism,”](#) whose proponents favor capturing the state in order to impose a singular, and religiously inspired, vision of the common good. What unites these movements is a shared contempt for the moderate, who is dismissed as cowardly, unprincipled, or insincere: wimps who inexplicably hate winning.

Lawlor’s account helps explain why this contempt is so corrosive. When one side decides that the treaty was a mistake—that only total victory will do—it stops sending the costly signals that sustain shared “discursive” space. “Better wrong with Sartre than right with Aron,” the slogan used to go in the glory days of the French postwar left. Who wouldn’t prefer the

glamour and the redemptive grandeur of the radical Jean-Paul Sartre to the pallid temporizing of the liberal [Raymond Aron](#)? But people like Aron have offered something other than the glory of commitment: a sense of imagination, of compassion, an awareness that your foes, too, have ideals that feel glamorous to them.

In defending reasonableness, Lawlor is defending the exhausted majority—those who still want to live together on terms of mutual recognition. She is unlikely to persuade the most passionate of partisans. But she may perhaps give heart to the despised moderates, who may be starting to internalize their critics' charges that their willingness to compromise is really just a failure of nerve.

Think back to another culture-war moment. In the wake of the [1992 Los Angeles riots](#), the rapper and activist Sister Souljah asked, rhetorically, “If Black people kill Black people every day, why not have a week and kill white people?” To a question about whether there were any good white people, she replied, “If there are, I haven’t met them.” Bill Clinton, then running for President, reproached her when he spoke at Jesse Jackson’s Rainbow Coalition. Many on the left saw betrayal and calculation. Why not see it, instead, as a performance of reasonableness, a refusal to allow a minority position within one’s alliance to define the map of value for everyone else?

It is a mistake of the passionate partisan to assume that moderates share the radicals’ principles but lack the audacity to act on them. Perhaps they don’t share those principles. Even if they do, they may value stability over purity and the survival of the treaty over the triumph of a vision. It’s not so much that they hate to win as that they recognize that most victories are temporary. The moderate’s vision may even be the harder one to sustain, requiring a tolerance for frustration and an inurement to defeat and political disappointment. There is something to be said for admitting that the prospects of disagreement are permanent and that wisdom consists not in tearing up the peace treaty but in renewing it.

It’s no secret that half of being a moderate is being a good loser. The other half, less widely acknowledged, is being a gracious winner. One of Aron’s latter-day disciples, Emmanuel Macron, was challenged during his breakout

2017 Presidential campaign over a triangulating phrase he liked to use when registering a reservation about one of his own convictions: “*en même temps*,” meaning “at the same time,” or “on the other hand.” It was, he freely admitted, “a verbal tic.” He was, however, unrepentant: “I’m going to keep on using it.” ♦

[Nikhil Krishnan](#) is the author of “[A Terribly Serious Adventure: Philosophy and War at Oxford, 1900-1960](#).”

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[Books](#)

The Novelist Reimagining the Japanese American Internment

In “Questions 27 & 28,” Karen Tei Yamashita opens an inquiry into how the story of the past gets made.

By [Hua Hsu](#)

April 20, 2026



Formally restless, Yamashita has spent decades testing the limits of the novel. Photograph by Balazs Gardi for The New Yorker

In 1943, the United States government administered a questionnaire to people of Japanese descent who had been confined to [wartime concentration](#) camps in California, Idaho, Arizona, Colorado, Utah, Wyoming, and Arkansas. The [forced imprisonment](#) of some hundred and twenty thousand residents, a majority of whom were U.S. citizens, rested on dubious evidence that they posed any meaningful threat to American safety. The removal orders seemed cruel and arbitrary, given that they applied only to people living on the West Coast. Still, the government sought to measure

their loyalty. The title of Karen Tei Yamashita's fifth novel, "[Questions 27 & 28](#)" (Graywolf), refers to the survey's last two questions:

Question 27: Are you willing to serve in the armed forces of the United States on combat duty, wherever ordered?

Question 28: Will you swear unqualified allegiance to the United States of America and faithfully defend the United States from any or all attack by foreign or domestic forces, and forswear any form of allegiance or obedience to the Japanese emperor, or any other foreign government, power, or organization?

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The Japanese American Citizens League, one of the first organizations that pressed Japanese Americans to view themselves as a community, had encouraged its members to prove that they were “200% American” and to view their incarceration as a kind of patriotic obligation. Some young men, eager to assert their Americanness, answered yes to both questions and volunteered for military service; members of the all-Japanese 442nd Regimental Combat Team quickly became war heroes. Others feared that these were trick questions; there was a rumor that everyone would be sent to Japan anyway as part of a P.O.W. exchange. Those who answered no to the questions were, in most cases, imprisoned for the remainder of the war or beyond. They became pariahs referred to as “no-no boys.”

“Questions 27 & 28” is about what preceded and followed this episode. At first, the novel's conceit seems familiar: a series of scattered, representative lives cohering into a kind of collective story. In the opening pages, the real-life Japanese writer Yone Noguchi—a sensuous seventeen-year-old bohemian who “has left everything behind for his first love, an English

spelling book”—sets sail, in the eighteen-nineties, for San Francisco. Subsequent chapters dramatize the lives of other turn-of-the-century immigrants before returning to Noguchi’s thread, this time through the story of his son, Isamu, already an established artist, who voluntarily submits to internment as an act of solidarity.

As we encounter more people, Yamashita’s approach to narrating their stories grows strange. Life in the camps is told largely through collaged fragments of latter-day writings, testimonies, and oral histories; footnotes remind us that we are accessing these voices at a distance. Other experiences are recounted through dramatic dialogue, or from the perspective of an inanimate object; some chapters adopt the pulpy tone of a spy thriller, breaking from any sense that “Questions 27 & 28” is meant to be a straightforward account of the past.

What initially seems like a novel about the Second World War unspools into the stories of the researchers who first documented and wrote about camp life, and then of the scholars and activists who followed them. Government officials weren’t the only people interested in understanding Japanese Americans. Because of the unprecedented scale of forced removal, social scientists also viewed the camps as rich sites for field work. A recurring presence in Yamashita’s novel is the Japanese Evacuation and Resettlement Study (*JERS*), a project headed by Dorothy Swaine Thomas, a sociologist at the University of California, Berkeley. She hired interned Japanese Americans, who had to work clandestinely, to document life behind barbed wire.

Drawing on these accounts, Thomas published some of the first books that explored the Japanese experience of the war at a time when the subject was seldom discussed, including in the Japanese American community. Yamashita imagines the anthropologist Rosalie Hankey Wax, now an elderly woman, reflecting on the work she did on Thomas’s behalf. She hadn’t expected that the lives she recorded would be fashioned into an official story, or that this story would take on a new political significance decades later:

Trust is a sympathetic ear. And yet to learn anything, she must be neutral, even as neutrality is impossible. A sympathetic ear may hear

with the torn heart of a stranger bound by another set of rules. She is made superior simply by being a researcher, impartial observer, who must see without the prejudicial lens of her own culture and experience. Yet even a robot must be programmed to ask the questions. The reports are made. Dorothy and the one they call X, make sense of them, write the story. She is a footnote. But so many years ago, only she is there to know. Too naive, too immature to understand. She risks becoming Japanese to know.

Historical fiction usually takes for granted the existence of something called “history.” The past becomes a fixed backdrop for the reader’s own present, a way to appreciate how far we’ve come or to realize that nothing has changed at all. “Questions 27 & 28” is a work of fiction about the nature of history, and about the mechanics by which we come to know anything reliable about the past in the first place. It is a sprawling and overwhelming volume, encompassing about a hundred real lives and spanning more than a hundred years, so that the reader experiences the process through which the accumulated occurrences of the past get shaped into historical fact.

Yamashita writes of the legal scholar Peter Irons as he explores the Department of Commerce’s archives in 1981. Working his way through the boxes, he finds a 1944 memo suggesting that the concentration camps were not a military necessity. Here was a “smoking gun” that would become a part of Irons’s book “[Justice at War](#),” from 1983, which informed the movement for reparations, redress, and an eventual government apology. “His heart beats faster, but he needs to look placid, like it’s just paper,” Yamashita writes, as Irons wonders how he will get a copy out of the facility.

A novel about writers writing or researchers digging through archives runs the risk of tedium. But Yamashita is at her best when she zooms out of such small moments and meditates on the greater stakes of these scattered lives. “Even if we don’t survive the consequences of history,” Irons thinks, “what’s left of it becomes a record, stored on hundreds of metal shelves in acid-free boxes, forming an endless labyrinth. Of course, it’s just saved stuff.”

Yamashita, who is seventy-five, has always been fascinated by unlikely convergences. She grew up in Los Angeles, enamored with the countercultural and protest movements of the sixties, then spent long stretches of the seventies and eighties living in Brazil, pursuing an interest in the many Japanese immigrant communities there. She conducted serious inquiries into globalization and connection, held together through magical-realist quirkiness, in such novels as “[Through the Arc of the Rain Forest](#)” (1990), a work of speculative fiction about ecological devastation which is narrated in part by a sentient extraterrestrial orb, and “[Tropic of Orange](#)” (1997), in which characters across the U.S.-Mexico border realize their shared plight, owing to a mystical orange capable of shifting the Tropic of Cancer. She is formally restless. She’s written a play about cyborg kung-fu fighters, a series of short stories that adapt Jane Austen for the L.A. suburbs, and a memoir inspired by possessions left behind by a hoarder aunt.



*“Four-day-old leftovers. She’s one of us.”
Cartoon by Rose Anne Prevec*

In 2010, she published “[I Hotel](#),” a novel about the Asian American activist movement of the nineteen-sixties and seventies which was a finalist for the National Book Award. It consists of ten interlinked novellas recounting the decade-long fight to save the International Hotel, a San Francisco residence for working-class Asian immigrants. “I Hotel” signalled a shift in Yamashita’s approach, from postmodern whimsy to research-heavy experiments with intricate structures and intertextuality. Near the end of this complex six-hundred-page book, Yamashita switches to a collective

pronoun, suggesting that a common dream has connected her characters. It's typical of the rousing, *cri-de-cœur* style she uses to recover idealisms of the past: "We ran and ran," she writes, as the hotel is finally reclaimed by developers who plan to raze it. "We've given our lives to this old place, but tonight we know our imminent failure," she continues. "And for what? To resist death and dementia. To haunt a disappearing landscape. To forever embed this geography with our visions and voices."

The United States began allowing Japanese people to leave the camps before the conclusion of the Second World War. In December of 1944, the Supreme Court had ruled that the government did not have the authority to detain "concededly loyal" citizens. But many had lost everything during the relocation process and had nowhere to return to. "What kind of poison freedom is this?" a character in "Questions 27 & 28" wonders.

In the decades after the war, Japanese Americans would be hailed as a model minority for their resilience and peaceful reintegration into American life. Yet the truth was more complicated. There's a moment in Yamashita's novel when James and Gordon Hirabayashi, two Japanese American academics, walk through a late-sixties demonstration at San Francisco State College, where James teaches. Gordon was a firebrand when he was young, having been imprisoned for challenging curfew and internment orders, but a kind of middle-aged disillusionment has set in. The youth are brash and outspoken, he contends, and "we're has-been." But a student activist named Paul, who also appeared in "I Hotel," recognizes Gordon and shows that their generation views him as a hero. We understand why Paul thinks this. Though ostracized in their time, people who resisted internment are now seen as civil-rights pioneers. In "Questions 27 & 28," as we read our way through the forties and fifties, we are ever conscious of that passage of time, across hundreds of pages, and of how this distance allows for new stories to be pulled from old materials. Most of us understand that history is often just the victor's account of how things happened. But the novel's achievement is that we are forced to experience this insight almost bodily. We feel the weight of the past, all these accumulated voices and perspectives, within and between Yamashita's novels, as well as the process through which disparate stories, anecdotes, or experiences might coalesce as history.

“In the future,” Yamashita writes, looking at a little girl in a wartime photograph and wondering what she is thinking, “no one will remember this future.” Despite Yamashita’s best efforts, there remain limits to what the “endless labyrinth” of the past still holds. The historical record is often vague when it comes to the capaciousness of our forebears’ imaginations. But Yamashita is entranced by such absences, when fiction allows her to inhabit the dreams of these historical characters. A researcher named Nobuya Tsuchida recalls his work as an interpreter for a peace delegation of survivors of the bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki who visited New York in 1964. Tsuchida is assisting two men known simply as the Writer and the Reporter. One afternoon, the delegation visits the home of Yuri Kochiyama, a famed Japanese American activist, and meets her friend Malcolm X. “I have a memory of his tall benevolence,” Tsuchida thinks, yet, decades later, he has not been able to verify this afternoon in anything published by the Writer or the Reporter: “I see now that big history encompasses little histories, overshadows and encumbers. The small matters of small individuals become invisible, pass into oblivion.” Still, he knows it happened. After leaving Kochiyama’s apartment, Tsuchida, the Writer, and the Reporter wander into Smalls Paradise, a Harlem night club, and debate Malcolm X’s politics. “How do we make peace from war?” they wonder, but Tsuchida is already somewhere else, lost in the wail of a saxophone.

We’re always participating in a larger story, even if it’s up to people in the future to make sense of it all. It’s also up to them to decide what genres to use; we don’t choose the conventions we live within. One of the most wondrous chapters in “Questions 27 & 28” imagines a conversation between Michi Nishiura Weglyn, the author of “[Years of Infamy](#),” a 1976 book that helped inspire the redress-and-reparation movement, and Wayne Collins, a civil-rights lawyer who challenged the government’s relocation orders. It’s presented as dramatic dialogue, or maybe as absurdist tragicomedy. “Where are we?” she asks. He surmises that they’re “in the clouds.” It can’t be Heaven, he jokes, because that’s not where he’s supposed to end up. Is it Purgatory? “We’re in the archive,” she realizes. “I loved the archives. I’ve come home.” ♦

[Hua Hsu](#) is a staff writer at *The New Yorker* and the author of the Pulitzer Prize-winning memoir “[Stay True](#).” He teaches at Bard College.

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[The Theatre](#)

Sharp Claws at “Becky Shaw” and “Cats: The Jellicle Ball”

Gina Gionfriddo’s zinger-filled sex farce and the celebratory ballroom-culture adaptation of Andrew Lloyd Webber’s most confounding musical are cathartic catnip.

By [Emily Nussbaum](#)

April 16, 2026



Something wild is in the air at the savage play “Becky Shaw.” Illustration by Javi Aznarez

Minutes into Second Stage’s scorching, spectacular revival of Gina Gionfriddo’s “Becky Shaw” (at the Hayes), an audience member groaned loudly, in pleasure and shock. Ten minutes later, someone else muttered, “Oh, my God.” There were waves of guffaws and, also, supportive finger-snapping. Comedy is about chemistry, but it felt like something more cathartic was in the air, in response to Gionfriddo’s savage corkscrew of a sex farce, which spirals around a blind date gone very, very wrong. First staged in 2008, it’s evolved into a hot-pepper challenge, a way to steel-man your illusions about love.

The play opens in a pitch-dark, three-star-hotel room, a step down for a bereaved family that has lost its patriarch and, as important, its promised inheritance. Suzanna (Lauren Patten), a moody, black-clad psychology grad student with a “Gashlycrumb Tinies” cuteness, is curled on the bed,

watching a true-crime show. “It soothes me and I need it. Don’t judge me,” she tells Max (Alden Ehrenreich), the brusque finance guy who has paid for both her room and her mother’s room. Max turns out to be Suzanna’s brother, kind of—his position in the family is unstable and gets only unstabler. What is clear is their intense bond, the brash intimacy of people addicted to repartee and raised by liars. Max offers Suzanna some tough-love advice, and, by the end of the scene, the stakes, as they say in TV, have been raised.

The story speeds up from there: suddenly, Suzanna is married to Andrew (Patrick Ball), a nice guy who cries at pornography, with whom she lives in a two-star apartment in Providence, Rhode Island. When the newlyweds decide to set Max up with Andrew’s co-worker Becky (Madeline Brewer, all pinwheel eyes and fawn legs), she turns up overdressed and clearly nervous. “Wow, you look like a birthday cake,” Max says. Rattled, she asks for guidance from Suzanna. “Inasmuch as you can, don’t show him any weakness,” Suzanna tells her.

Gionfriddo is something of an expert on true crime, having taken the playwright’s path to survival—a steady gig writing for “Law & Order.” But in her stage plays, including “Rapture, Blister, Burn” and “Can You Forgive Her?,” she’s established herself as an authority on the more covert violence of feminine perversity, with a refreshing frankness about how easily weakness and strength can masquerade as each other. Her dialogue, which is dense with bleak, Wildean zingers, has, on the surface, a LaBute-ian, Mamet-y sting, the exfoliating bite of a Jacobean satire of social hypocrisy; a few dynamics reminded me of some of the more romantic scenes on the HBO show “Succession.” “Love is a happy by-product of use,” Max insists. Suzanna’s mother, Susan (Linda Emond), decrees, “No one respects a woman who forgives infidelity.” There are rolling debates about the nature of morality: “Does pornography make you cry?” Max asks, skeptically. “No, but it should and I wish it did,” Suzanna shoots back.

Still, what distinguishes Gionfriddo is not her ear for cruelty but her ability to see beyond it, and to shift the prism of audience sympathy, in tiny increments. This tension is intensified by Trip Cullman’s precise staging, which is smartly paced, down to the indie-sleaze anthems, such as “Zero,”

by the Yeah Yeah Yeahs, that mark each set change. The costumes, by Kaye Joyce, are almost alarmingly on target, from Becky's try-hard dress to Andrew's fuzzy orange cardigan. Once in a while, black flats compress the space, framing a single character's face, bathed in a bleaching white light, as if their vulnerabilities were being scanned by an MRI. Even David Zinn's set includes a punch line: the cramped quarters feel minimalist, but they pay off in the second act, with a sudden revelation about the way some people get to live.

The cast is terrific, particularly Brewer, whose Becky, an ancestor of Thackeray's social climber, reminded me of the Ben Folds song "Fragile," about an emotional terrorist full of excuses: "It's, like, 'Crash, boom, oops . . . did I break that, too?' " Emond, as Suzanna's hypercritical mother, puts an Olympic-level spin on her withering observations. Ball, that hot doctor on "The Pitt," nails the way decency can conceal secret trapdoors; Patten, as Suzanna, captures the flop sweat of a woman falling, bit by bit, below her own moral standards.

But the engine driving the production is Ehrenreich's magnetic performance as Max, the sort of character who, in many other stories and lots of nineteen-eighties sex comedies, would be the villain. With his subdued growl, rat-a-tat standup-comic delivery, and air of couched melancholy, Ehrenreich lends a peculiar moral weight to Max, a master puppeteer tangled up in his own strings. He's a caustic know-it-all, but, the more we learn about him, the more defensible, and even ethical, his Realpolitik becomes. However callous his words are, he radiates turbulent emotion: whenever someone steps close to him, a Geiger counter starts crackling, as if intimacy itself had a half-life.

There's a wonderful moment early in the play when Ehrenreich is left alone onstage, with a look of such ragged disorientation and abandonment, of little-boy distress, that it lingers, later, even when Max is at his most cutting, when he seems to be doing "American Psycho" cosplay. It's the quality that distinguishes Gionfriddo's play from a brittle farce—its willingness to recognize failed love as something bigger than a player losing a game, an oceanic force roiling beneath the script's surface nastiness. After laughing my head off all evening, there was a moment, just

before the night ended, when my eyes teared up. That, too, felt like the real thing.

Across the street from “Becky Shaw,” there’s another audience going crazy with joy, at “Cats: The Jellicle Ball” (at the Broadhurst), a delirious revival grounded in what may be the greatest dramaturgical insight in musical-comedy history. The material its creators are messing with is, of course, “Cats,” the much mocked British mega-musical that dominated Broadway from 1982 through the turn of the century, infuriating haters of Andrew Lloyd Webber, theatrical bombast, and narrative incoherence. Based, pretty bizarrely, on some light verse by T. S. Eliot, the original production, with its treacly pop-rock score, was set inside a junk yard full of touchy-feely showoffs in kitten ears, competing to reach the Heaviside Layer, a celestial MacGuffin. It made tons of money and no sense.

Two decades later, in 2019, the I.P. flared back up again, like shingles. That January, the show sparked a pair of rude TV satires, first, on the musical-mad series “Crazy Ex-Girlfriend,” where vagina metaphors alternate with wisecracks about “Cats” ruining Broadway, and then, two weeks later, on the sitcom “Unbreakable Kimmy Schmidt,” with a hilarious plot in which the thirsty actor Titus Andromedon crashes the production as the made-up cat Frumbumbly. Backstage, he realizes that he’s cracked the show’s secret code: the entire thing is and always has been pure, improvised nonsense—and anyone who can babble convincingly enough can join the ensemble. That December, a hideous movie adaptation seemed to confirm that view of “Cats,” by congealing any lingering charm beneath layers of “digital fur technology.”

And then, in a miraculous turn, “Cats” scored one more life, downtown. The 2024 revival at *PAC NYC*, which was co-directed by Zhailon Levingston and Bill Rauch, was grounded in a genius, faintly psychedelic insight: that Eliot’s 1939 doggerel was much more logically set in the modern-day Black-ballroom scene, the fragile, shimmering world of queer outsiders captured in Jennie Livingston’s 1990 documentary, “Paris Is Burning.” The reframe worked like a set of corrective lenses, sharpening sentimental mush into something with meaning and claws. “Cats” was, after all, a story about flamboyant street creatures who adopt new names and

alter egos, shape-shifters whose hyperbolic personae at once reflected and satirized the straight world. Queering “Cats” was the inverse of appropriation: the camp version was the authentic one.

Moving this delicate variant to Broadway posed a risk. In midtown, the show’s exuberance could have dimmed, as it did for “Titanique,” the Céline Dion pastiche, a charming goof that feels too slight for its new venue, right across Forty-fourth Street, at the St. James. “Jellicle Ball,” in contrast, confidently fills its space, starting with its lovely, simple opening image, of a d.j. pulling a Diana Ross album out of a plastic crate—a memento mori of the eighties—and holding it up to the knowing crowd. Everything old feels new again, down to the iconic yellow-eyed logo, displayed up on a catwalk lined with TV screens, in which the static cat-eye pupils first wriggle, then reveal themselves as slinky, silhouetted dancers.

From then on, the show never stops moving, with dizzy, propulsive choreography by Omari Wiles, of the House of NiNa Oricci, and Arturo Lyons, of the House of Miyake-Mugler, and epic, decade-spanning couture by Qween Jean. On a runway, dancers duckwalk and spin, stick their hands in the air and wiggle their fingers, then drop into splits and shoot their legs into the air like exclamation marks. Every body and every gender gets a turn, from the silky-haired, pipe-cleaner-limbed, jaw-droppingly limber Robert (Silk) Mason, as Magical Mister Mistoffelees, to Nora Schell, as the strutting, bodacious Bustopher Jones, to a magisterial eighty-year-old André De Shields, as Old Deuteronomy. Not every number landed—that old warhorse (warcat?) “Memory” lacked the requisite grit and sorrow—but perfection felt beside the point, in a performance that was designed to celebrate resilience, against all odds.

TV shows such as “Pose” and “RuPaul’s Drag Race” had clearly primed the crowd to read the room, and to hush, with respect, during the lovely homage to ballroom and queer icons that opens the second act. They roared, later on, offering up the wildest cheers for the ballroom legend Junior LaBeija, who had been observing the proceedings from the proscenium, skeptically, through neon-green eyeshadow and thick, spidery lashes. When LaBeija, as Gus the Theatre Cat, finally strolled onstage to revisit his glory days, wagging his long, polished claws, a younger Gus (Jonathan Burke)

appeared, like a mirror dancing toward him. It was a beautiful suggestion of the show's open-armed sensibility, a way of lovingly glorifying both the past and the present, and, fingers crossed, the future . . . now and forever. ♦

Emily Nussbaum, a staff writer at *The New Yorker* since 2011, is the magazine's theatre critic. Her books include "[*Cue The Sun!: The Invention of Reality TV*](#)."

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The Calculated Uplift of “I Swear”

Kirk Jones’s bio-pic of the activist John Davidson, who has worked to destigmatize Tourette’s syndrome, is effective as an educational tool but mechanical as a drama.

By [Justin Chang](#)

April 17, 2026



“I Swear” isn’t just an account of John Davidson’s life but a direct extension of his activism. Illustration by Anuj Shrestha

Like many upbeat biographical dramas, “I Swear” begins at the end. A culminating moment of triumph is neatly reverse engineered into a prologue: it’s 2019, and the Scottish activist John Davidson (Robert Aramayo) is being honored for his groundbreaking work to raise awareness of Tourette’s syndrome. John is nervous, for good reason. He has severe coprolalia, a symptom of Tourette’s that causes him to blurt out obscenities unpredictably—all in all, not an ideal situation for a man about to meet Queen Elizabeth II. Sure enough, John causes a scene, yelling, “Fuck the Queen!” Once the initial shock in the room has subsided—the Queen herself seems unperturbed—John says, “Sorry, Ma’am,” and quietly finds his seat. The ceremony begins, and the message is clear: if Her Majesty could take such an indignity in stride, what’s the rest of the world’s excuse?

It's an amusing point of entry, although, as a scene of comic vindication, it arguably renders the movie moot. Here is Davidson in a foul-mouthed nutshell: sincere, self-effacing, and prone to embarrassing exclamations that—even after years of anguished personal struggle and laudable public advocacy—he remains powerless to prevent. The film's title, an obvious reference to profanity, also alludes to an incident dramatized later on, when John, on trial after inadvertently triggering a pub brawl, must give sworn testimony in court. (He can't get through the oath without calling the judge a cunt—an assessment as unintentional as it is hilariously spot-on.) What's a man to do when, in striving to tell the whole truth and nothing but the truth, his best-faith efforts are mistaken for the opposite?

“I Swear” serves up an ingratiating answer to that question. It was written and directed by the British filmmaker Kirk Jones, a reliable purveyor of uplift; only in comparison with his earlier work, which includes “Waking Ned Devine” (1998), “Nanny McPhee” (2006), and “My Big Fat Greek Wedding 2” (2016), could his new movie be construed as remotely hard-hitting. With its mostly happy ending established, it flashes back to 1983, when the teen-age John (played movingly by Scott Ellis Watson), who lives with his parents and siblings in the Scottish town of Galashiels, begins to experience his first Tourette's symptoms. His physical tics derail a promising football career, and his verbal eruptions frequently land him in trouble at school, where neither his peers nor his headmaster grasp that he has no control over his offending words and deeds. Even a deeper knowledge of Tourette's is not a guarantee of understanding. When John begins spitting out his food, his mother, Heather (Shirley Henderson), worn down by exhaustion and anger, banishes him from the dinner table—the first in an unceasing series of maternal rejections. (His father's rejection is more final; he abandons the family not long after John's condition worsens.) Years later, only John (now played by Aramayo) remains with Heather at home, medicated into semi-submission, with little hope of a life of independence or fulfillment.

John Davidson's story has been told in several TV documentaries over the past few decades, starting with a 1988 episode of the BBC series “Q.E.D.,” titled “John's Not Mad,” which has been credited with doing much to educate the British public about Tourette's. (Oliver Sacks, one of the

episode's prominent voices, offers a precise, sympathetic analysis of John's symptoms.) Perhaps because it focussed on John's teen-age years, when Tourette's treatments and therapies were fewer and farther between, the documentary took a more downbeat view of its subject and his prospects than the movie does. In "I Swear," John's social rehabilitation is set in motion by Dottie Achenbach (Maxine Peake), the mother of an old school friend, who takes John under her wing. In relatively short order, she moves John into her house, gets him off his meds, and encourages him to apply for a job at a local community center, where his boss, Tommy Trotter (Peter Mullan), proves as saintly as Dottie is. It's Tommy who nudges John toward the realization that the problem lies not with his condition but with society's ignorance of it. A public-awareness campaign is launched, with John heroically leading the way.

"I Swear," then, isn't just an account of Davidson's life. It's a direct extension of his activism, and its effectiveness as an educational tool is what renders it frictionless and predictable as a drama. In the course of the narrative, as John is embraced by friends and assaulted by strangers, Jones's storytelling veers between breakthroughs and setbacks with a rhythm so mechanical as to verge on metronomic. Yet the movie is a slick and expertly calculated piece of work, and it has taken even the most reflexive skepticism into account; you may emerge from the theatre blinking back tears and rolling your eyes. The only remotely complicated figure is his mother, Heather—a would-be villain in the logic of the film, made more complex and tragic by Henderson, who has a gift for gloomy nuance. Strikingly, in "John's Not Mad," the real-life Heather came across as entirely devoted and sympathetic. You needn't be a bio-pic truth fetishist to wonder how close to reality Jones's treatment gets—and how much may have been artificially sweetened, or embittered, for effect.

Aramayo's role raises other questions. Some people may have strong feelings about the ethics of an actor who does not have Tourette's performing the tics and gestures that accompany the condition; as it happens, I was disarmed by the friendly jut of Aramayo's smile and the gentle clownery of his carriage. He strides through the movie with a startling mix of awkwardness and grace: the light-footed assurance of

someone who has learned to anticipate—and perhaps overcorrect for—errant movements.

For me, the possible false note lay not in Aramayo's performance but in the script. At times, it seems that Jones's film, far from being strictly diagnostic, might in fact be egging John on, for the sake of our entertainment, toward perverse new heights of verbal invention. After brewing a cup of tea for Tommy, John blurts out, "I use spunk for milk"—and spunk, more in the spiritual than the bodily sense, is what the movie has in spades. Its humor is so insistent that it's almost unseemly, transforming "I Swear" into a curious kind of misfired-synapses comedy—one that, in tone and intent, seems to fly in the face of the sombre warning issued by the 1988 documentary: "John's obscenities will always be a verbal time bomb, waiting to go off in public."

That grim prophecy was fulfilled—and how—on February 22nd, at the *BAFTAs*, where "I Swear" experienced a one-of-a-kind commingling of glory and disaster. To the shock of many, Aramayo won Best Actor, triumphing over a field that included the Oscar nominees Timothée Chalamet, Leonardo DiCaprio, Ethan Hawke, and Michael B. Jordan. Davidson was in the crowd, too, as the audience had been informed, with an announcement that any outbursts they might hear from him were involuntary and not representative of his views or beliefs. The warning proved scant consolation when Davidson shouted a racial slur at two Black actors—Jordan and Delroy Lindo, both from "Sinners"—who were presenting an award onstage. The BBC inexplicably neglected to excise the incident from its tape-delayed broadcast of the ceremony, and, amid the ugly fallout, much was written about the failures of the network and of *BAFTA* in their duty of care to all involved. More divisive has been the question of who, in the end, was the more aggrieved party: Jordan and Lindo, who were subjected to unconscionable humiliation, or Davidson, who was accused of racism online by countless individuals with no understanding of or empathy for his condition.

What makes the episode worth considering anew, as "I Swear" arrives in American theatres this month, is how it seemed to both destroy and affirm the film in one nightmarish breath—to expose the hollowness of its feel-

good machinery while also proving its larger point about the vindictive ignorance of so much of the public. There's a particularly hideous irony in the fact that "I Swear," which depicts a fictional Davidson prevailing through some of his gravest anxieties, wound up thrusting the real Davidson into the most public embarrassment of his life. What horror! But also, for sheer educational and entertainment value, what an opportunity. Had the filmmakers been inclined to tweak their work at the last minute, they might have reshot their prologue, guerrilla-style, ahead of the film's U.S. release. Who needs a mild anti-monarchist outburst, given the far thornier international debacle on the *BAFTAs* stage? Fuck the Queen, indeed. ♦

[Justin Chang](#) is a film critic at *The New Yorker*.

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By Franz Wright | “My death is in the second drawer.”

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Spring Comes and I Finally Throw Out the Last Flowers I Bought You

By [Ariel Francisco](#)

April 20, 2026

Condemned to the kitchen counter
radiated by the heartless
Louisiana sun, so dry they bloomed
into a fire hazard. It's been weeks.
It's been months. It's been seasons.
Even the ants who army crawl
under the window after rain
have stopped exploring those morbid petals.
Even the trashcan gags
as they crumble to dust in its maw.

This is drawn from “We All Have Moons We Long to Return To.”

[Ariel Francisco](#) is the author of “We All Have Moons We Long to Return To” (2028), among other books.

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Favor

By [Franz Wright](#)

April 20, 2026

My death is in the second drawer.

While you're standing there would you mind getting me one?

And there should be a couple left in the medicine cabinet,
when I
wake up.

If I
wake up.

If I
wake up
tomorrow.

But I am confused, I thought
today was tomorrow.

If I
wake up
in a second,

on the right side of the mirror.

—*Franz Wright (1953-2015)*

This is drawn from "[Axe in Blossom: Last Poems & Fragments](#)."

[Franz Wright](#), who died in 2015, was a Pulitzer Prize-winning poet. His posthumous poetry collection is titled "[Axe in Blossom](#)" (July, 2026).

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The Crossword: Wednesday, April 15, 2026

A beginner-friendly puzzle.

By [Robyn Weintraub](#)

April 15, 2026

Loading game...

[Robyn Weintraub](#) has been constructing crosswords since 2010 and began contributing puzzles to *The New Yorker* in 2020. Her puzzles have appeared in the *New York Times*, the *Los Angeles Times*, and the *American Crossword Puzzle Tournament*.

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